The Retrograde Son



and the Inverted House

Contrapuntal Form, Dhampiric Being, and the Pessimist Anthropodicy of Castlevania: Symphony of the Night

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair



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Abstract

Castlevania: Symphony of the Night (*Akumajō Dracula X: Gekka no Yasōkyoku*; Konami Computer Entertainment Tokyo, 1997; directed by Toru Hagihara, with Koji Igarashi as assistant director and scenario writer, Ayami Kojima as illustrator, and Michiru Yamane as composer) is conventionally remembered as a hinge in the formal history of the video game: the work that fused the hereditary monster-hunt of the *Castlevania* series with an interconnected, ability-gated architecture of exploration, and thereby bequeathed to criticism the compound genre-name "Metroidvania." This dissertation contends that such formal-historical accounts, however accurate, mistake the vessel for the wine. It argues that *Symphony of the Night* is a philosophical work of unusual coherence whose argument is carried less by its sparse script than by two formal operations that its musical titles name without announcing: **retrogradation** and **inversion**. Retrogradation is embodied in Alucard, the dhampir son whose name is his father's read backward; inversion in the Inverted Castle, the father's house turned upon its axis, which the game conceals behind a false ending placed at its structural midpoint. These operations — traced here to the canonic devices of Baroque counterpoint (the *canon cancrizans* and the *canon per motum contrarium*), to the Marian typology in which *Ave* reverses *Eva*, to Irenaeus's doctrine of recapitulation, to Hegel's *verkehrte Welt*, and to the gravitational reversal at the centre of Dante's *Inferno* — together constitute what is here termed **dhampiric reason**: a mode of knowing, acting, and hoping that proceeds by reading every apparent totality against its own grain until its concealed half is disclosed.

The argument takes its bearings from the question the game places in Dracula's mouth at its threshold — "What is a man? A miserable little pile of secrets." — a formula whose answer echoes André Malraux's *Antimémoires* (1967) and whose interrogative form reproduces the fourth and

summative question of Kant's philosophy (*Was ist der Mensch?*), posed by Kant in the very decade in which the game is set. Following Kant's own architectonic, in which the questions of knowledge, duty, and hope are all referred to the question of the human, the dissertation proceeds through a genealogical chapter and an aesthetic chapter to three chapters on the first three questions — the castle as an epistemic object of secrets, memory, and apocalyptic sight; the ethics of Lisa's injunction against hatred; the theology and eschatology of a vampire who indicts religion and a priest who resurrects the devil — before concluding with the fourth, which it answers in the figure of the dhampir.

Situating the game within a constellation that includes the Balkan ethnography of the dhampir, the Habsburg vampire controversies, the Romantic *annus mirabilis* of 1797 (Goethe's "Balladenjahr," Coleridge's "Christabel," Novalis's graveside vision, the "Oldest System-Programme of German Idealism"), the Gothic novel from Walpole to Stoker, the cinematic vampire from Murnau to Coppola, the Japanese traditions of the *onryō* and the dream-Noh, and the aestheticist lineage running from Tanizaki and Moto Hagio to Yoshitaka Amano and *visual kei*, the dissertation reads the game as a *Trauerspiel* in Walter Benjamin's literal sense: a play — and a game — of mourning, in which a sovereign's grief for a martyred woman becomes a world.

Its central claim is that *Symphony of the Night* articulates a **pessimist anthropodicy**: a justification not of God before evil but of humanity before the monster, grounded not in human innocence but in human suffering. Dracula and Lisa concur that the human condition is wretched; they diverge on what wretchedness demands. Dracula draws contempt from it; Lisa draws compassion, converting Malraux's *misérable petit tas de secrets* into Schopenhauer's *compagnon de misères*. The inversion of the castle is accordingly read as the spatial form of an ethical inversion that Hegel names exactly: the passage of punishment into pardon. Alucard's itinerary through the father's house is analysed as a seven-moment sequence — *kenōsis*, *anamnēsis*, *apokalypsis*, *peripeteia*, *anakephalaiōsis*, *anagnōrisis*, *apotaxis* — that fuses the vocabulary of Aristotelian tragedy with that of patristic soteriology. The player, whose avatar sleeps in a coffin to preserve its progress and returns from death to resume it, is drawn into the dhampir's condition as a structural participant rather than a spectator.

The dissertation concludes that the dhampir — neither human nor monster, neither living nor dead — is the game's answer to Kant's question: the human being as constitutively *between*, a creature whose secrets are the measure of its wretchedness and whose wretchedness is the ground of its claim to mercy.

Note on Editions, Translations, and Conventions

The base text is the North American PlayStation release of October 1997, whose English script, for all its idiosyncrasies, is the text through which the game's anglophone reception was formed and its most famous lines canonized. The Japanese PlayStation release of March 1997 is consulted where the argument turns on the original; the 1998 Japanese Sega Saturn version, which adds Maria Renard as a playable character together with further areas, items, and familiars, is treated as a paratextual supplement; the 2007 retranslation and re-recording prepared for *Akumajō Dracula X Chronicles* (*Castlevania: The Dracula X Chronicles*), later reused in the 2018 *Castlevania Requiem* collection, is cited only where it clarifies the Japanese, and divergences are flagged. Because a game's "text" comprises not only its script but its rules, spaces, and the ensemble of its possible traversals, references to locations, items, and sequences are to the game as played rather than to any single performance of it.

Japanese personal names follow the order customary for each figure in English-language scholarship: contemporary creators and scholars who are credited or publish in the Western order appear in that form (Toru Hagihara, Ayami Kojima, Koichi Iwabuchi), while premodern, literary, and critical figures appear family name first (Motoori Norinaga, Tanizaki Jun'ichirō, Karatani Kōjin); Japanese terms are romanized in modified Hepburn with long vowels marked. Translations from German, French, Latin, Greek, and Japanese are the author's unless otherwise stated; quotations from works in the public domain are given in the original where the wording bears weight, and works still under copyright are paraphrased,

with no more than a brief phrase quoted from any one of them. Citations take an author–date form keyed to the bibliography appended to Chapter Eight; classical, patristic, and scriptural texts are cited by conventional divisions, Kant by the Akademie-Ausgabe (Ak.), and the King James Version is used for English scripture.

A final caution concerns evidential tiers. The dissertation distinguishes throughout between (i) **documented filiation**, where a source is attested or the borrowing is unambiguous (the name "Alucard" from Universal's *Son of Dracula*, the bat, wolf, and mist from Stoker); (ii) **generic inheritance**, where the game participates in a tradition without citing any particular member of it; and (iii) **constellational affinity**, where historically unconnected phenomena are arranged so as to make an idea legible. Claims of the third kind — which include most of the dissertation's boldest — are offered as interpretations of the work, not as reconstructions of its makers' intentions.

Contents

Abstract 3

Note on Editions, Translations, and Conventions 6

I Introduction — "What Is a Man?" 15

The Prologue as Philosophical Overture and the Method of Contrapuntal Reading

1.1 The Threshold Scene: A Disputation in the Throne Room 15
1.2 The Fourth Question: Kant, Schiller, Malraux 19
1.3 Two Operations: Retrograde and Inversion 22
1.4 A Game of Mourning: *Symphony of the Night* as *Trauerspiel* 27
1.5 The Pessimist Anthropodicy: Statement of Thesis 29
1.6 Three Centennials: 1797, 1897, 1997 33
1.7 Method: Contrapuntal, Constellational, Procedural 38
1.8 Corpus, Versions, and the Problem of the Ludic Text 40
1.9 State of the Field 42
1.10 Architecture of the Dissertation 44

II "Enter Freely and of Your Own Will" 49

Genealogies of the Revenant, the Dhampir, and the Romantic Annus Mirabilis

2.1 The Son of the Dragon: Vlad III and the Fabrication of a Monster 50
2.2 Revenants of the Habsburg Frontier: Plogojowitz, Paole, Calmet, Voltaire, Rousseau 54
2.3 The Dhampir: Balkan Ethnography and the Hereditary Hunter 57
2.4 The Balladenjahr: Goethe, Coleridge, Novalis, and the New Mythology 59
2.5 From Diodati to Whitby: Polidori, Varney, Le Fanu, Stoker 63
2.6 The Cinematic Count: Murnau, Browning, Dreyer, Fisher, Herzog, Coppola 66
2.7 The Japanese Vampire: Hagio, Kikuchi and Amano, Araki, Hirano 68
2.8 The Belmont Counter-Lineage, 1986–1993 71

III "Gekka no Yasōkyoku" 77

Kojima, Yamane, and the Decadent Sublime of a Revenant Medium

3.1 The Painted Prince: Ayami Kojima and the Aesthetics of Androgyny 78

3.2 *Tanbi*, *Shōjo*, and *Visual Kei* 80
3.3 Partita, Toccata, Requiem: Michiru Yamane's Baroque Revenants 83
3.4 The Sublime in Sprite and Pixel: Burke, Kant, Piranesi 86
3.5 In Praise of Shadows: Tanizaki, Darkness, and Gold 89
3.6 A Revenant Medium: Two Dimensions in the Polygonal Dawn 91
3.7 *Mujō*: The *Heike*, Impermanence, and the Falling Castle 93

IV *Was kann ich wissen?* 99
The Castle as Epistemic Object — Secrets, Memory, and the Apocalyptic Optics of the Holy Glasses

4.1 Castle as World: *Castlevania*, Asterion, Gormenghast, Kafka 100
4.2 The Architecture of the Secret 102
4.3 The Memory Palace: Simonides, Camillo, Bruno, and the Map Screen 104
4.4 The Confessional Machine: Augustine, Rousseau, Foucault, Malraux 106
4.5 The Midpoint Ending: Closure as Deception 107
4.6 *Sol et Luna*: The Gold and Silver Rings 109
4.7 *Apokalypsis*: The Holy Glasses and the Unveiling of the Controller 112
4.8 *Per Motum Contrarium*: The Inverted Castle and Hegel's *Verkehrte Welt* 114
4.9 Mirror Fugue: Bach, Schoenberg, Escher, Hofstadter 117
4.10 200.6 Percent: The Supplement and the Excess of Totality 119

V *Was soll ich tun?* 123
Lisa's Injunction, the Possessed Hero, and the Ethics of Mourning

5.1 The Wrath of the Widower: Dracula and the *Mēnis* of Achilles 124
5.2 The Witch-Fire: Lisa, Hypatia, Servetus 125
5.3 "Misery Made Me a Fiend": The Justified Monster 127
5.4 He Who Fights with Monsters: Richter, Recognition, and the Abyss 129
5.5 The Marionette and the Orb: Kleist and Avatarial Possession 131
5.6 The Inverted Ghost: *Hamlet* and the Prohibition of Revenge 133
5.7 Kundry's Kiss: The Succubus and the Wisdom of Compassion 134
5.8 *Mitleid*: Schopenhauer and the *Compagnon de Misères* 136
5.9 *Devilman*'s Despair and Lisa's Counter-Testimony 138
5.10 Priam's Tears and *Atsumori*'s Prayer: Reconciliation at the Father's Death 139

VI *Was darf ich hoffen?* 143
The Vampire as Critic, the Dark Priest, and the Eschatology of the Undead

6.1 The Vampire as Hermeneut of Suspicion: Voltaire, Feuerbach, Marx, Nietzsche 144
6.2 The Inverted Eucharist 146
6.3 The Dark Priest: Ambrosio, Schedoni, Frollo, Shaft 147
6.4 The Syncretic Arsenal: Cross, Bible, Holy Water, *Vibhūti*, *Agni* 149
6.5 Death in Livery: The *Danse Macabre* Inverted 151

6.6 *Non Serviam*: Milton's Satan and Kierkegaard's Demonic Defiance 152
6.7 The Demiurge's Castle: Gnostic Cosmology and the Hymn of the Pearl 154
6.8 Osiris, Zagreus, Relic: The Dismembered Father 156
6.9 Through the Centre: Dante's Inversion and the Harrowing of Hell 157
6.10 The Centennial Return: Eliade and Nietzsche 160
6.11 1995: Aum, *Evangelion*, and the Japanese Apocalyptic Imaginary 162

VII *Was ist der Mensch?* 167
The Retrograde Son — Dhampiric Being, Kenosis, and the Oedipal Vampire

7.1 The Name Read Backward 168
7.2 Two Natures without Confusion: Chalcedon and the Dhampiric Hypostasis 170
7.3 The Refused Antichrist: Adso, *Good Omens*, *Hellboy* 173
7.4 *Kenōsis* at the Gate: Death, Inanna, and the Robe of Glory 174
7.5 *Anamnēsis*: Relics as Recollection 176
7.6 Bat, Wolf, Mist: Stoker's Metamorphoses and Becoming-Animal 177
7.7 The Vampire Who Filiates: Deleuze, Guattari, and the Oedipalized Undead 179
7.8 The Doppelgänger, the Afterimage, and the Backdash 181
7.9 The Dandy and the Tragic Prince 182
7.10 The Coffin as Save Point: Revenant Ludology 184
7.11 The Accursed Share: Bataille and the Refusal of Inheritance 185

VIII Conclusion — *Compagnon de Misères* 189
Dhampiric Reason and the Afterlives of the Night

8.1 Recapitulation in Inversion 190
8.2 Dhampiric Reason Defined 192
8.3 The Metroidvania and the Ludic Architecture of the Secret 196
8.4 Souls, *Bloodborne*, *Hollow Knight*, *Blasphemous* 198
8.5 *Bloodstained* and the Netflix *Castlevania* 200
8.6 The *Trauerspiel* and the Future of Mourning in Play 202
8.7 Coda: Morning 204

Bibliography 207
Keywords 218

Figures

Figure 1 The Disputation in Six Turns 17
Figure 2 The Four Forms of a Line 23
Figure 3 The Seven Moments 32
Figure 4 A Constellation of Centennials 34
Figure 5 The Architecture of the Dissertation 45

Figure 6 Genealogies of the Revenant 51
Figure 7 Release and Story 72
Figure 8 Sol et Luna 110
Figure 9 Rectus et Inversus 115
Figure 10 Two Hundred Point Six 120
Figure 11 Through the Centre 158
Figure 12 Names Read Backward 169
Figure 13 Two Natures 171
Figure 14 The Between 194
Figure 15 Heirs by Filiation 197



I

What Is a Man?

Chapter One

Introduction — "What Is a Man?"

The Prologue as Philosophical Overture and the Method of Contrapuntal Reading

1.1

The Threshold Scene: A Disputation in the Throne Room

Symphony of the Night begins with an ending. Before the player meets Alucard, before any action of the protagonist has earned the title, the program restages the final duel of its predecessor, *Akumajō Dracula X: Chi no Rondo* (*Rondo of Blood*, PC Engine Super CD-ROM², 1993), set in 1792, and places the controller in the hands of the hunter Richter Belmont rather than of the dhampir who will be the game's hero. The first gesture of the work is therefore a retrograde in the strict musical sense: the cadence of the previous composition is transposed to the head of the new one, so that the game opens where its precursor closed. This dissertation argues that the inaugural reversal is not a convenience of franchise continuity but the first statement of a subject the whole work develops by contrapuntal transformation. That the predecessor bears the name of a musical form (*rondo*) only sharpens the point. The oldest celebrated retrograde in the European repertory is a rondeau,

Guillaume de Machaut's *Ma fin est mon commencement* (fourteenth century), whose voices sing the same line forward and backward and whose text announces the principle: my end is my beginning, and my beginning my end. *Symphony of the Night* is, in this exact sense, the retrograde of a rondo.

The duel is preceded by a dialogue that has become, in the anglophone reception of the game, one of the most quoted exchanges in the medium. Its comic reputation has obscured its structure, which is that of a disputation in six turns, each of which belongs to a different branch of philosophy. In the first, Richter denies the vampire's right to exist in the world: an **ontological** claim of exclusion, which treats the monster as what Mary Douglas, borrowing an older proverb, called matter out of place (Douglas 1966). In the second, Dracula relocates the cause of his presence: he has not resurrected himself, he replies, but been given flesh again by human beings who summoned him in order to pay him homage. The claim is **aetiological**, and it is decisive, for it places the origin of evil not in the monster but in the human desire that conjures him; within the series' fiction the summoner is the dark priest Shaft, a cleric. In the third turn Richter returns to the register of **ethics**, accusing the vampire of stealing souls and enslaving men. In the fourth, Dracula answers with a *tu quoque* that is also a **critique of religion**: the same charge, he suggests, might be laid against every faith. In the fifth, Richter rejects the vampire as a false **saviour**, a word that discloses the soteriological structure into which Dracula's worshippers have placed him: he is not merely a predator but a counter-messiah. In the sixth turn the vampire poses the question that subsumes the others and answers it himself: "What is a man? A miserable little pile of secrets." Only then does he break off the debate in the dueller's formula of the Elizabethan stage — the "Have at you now!" with which Laertes engages Hamlet in the final scene of Shakespeare's tragedy (*Hamlet* 5.2) — and the argument passes from words to arms.

The sequence ontology – aetiology – ethics – theology – soteriology – anthropology is not arbitrary. It recapitulates in miniature the scholastic *quaestio*, in which a disputed proposition is stated, objected to, answered, and determined; and it closes, as the medieval *determinatio* sometimes did when argument failed, in trial by combat, the judicial duel understood as a *iudicium Dei*. The boss battle is an ordeal in the oldest juridical sense: a procedure by which a question that reason cannot settle is submitted to a

Figure 1

The Disputation in Six Turns



The prologue's dialogue read as a scholastic disputation (§1.1). Each of its six turns belongs to a different branch of philosophy, and the sixth subsumes the rest. Discourse fails to decide the question, which passes to the ordeal of combat: the monster wins the exchange of words, the hunter the exchange of blows.

test whose outcome is taken to reveal the truth. What the prologue stages, then, is the failure of discourse to decide the question of the human and the transfer of that question to play. The player decides the disputation not by an argument but by a performance.

The decision is curiously split. Dracula wins the exchange of words: he has the last line, and his question goes unanswered by the hunter, who can only call it empty. Richter wins the exchange of blows. *Logos* goes to the monster and *agōn* to the hero, so that the truth of the scene and its victory are distributed to opposite parties. Everything that follows can be read as the game's attempt to repair this disjunction — to find a mode in which the question Dracula poses is answered not by the sword that silences him but by a form of understanding that his own grievance can recognize. That mode, the dissertation will argue, belongs neither to the hunter nor to the vampire but to the one who is both: the dhampir.

Two further features of the threshold scene deserve notice. First, the player's inaugural avatar is the very body that the main narrative will reveal as possessed. Before Shaft binds Richter with an invisible orb suspended above his head, the player has already occupied him as an external controller. The prologue thus inaugurates, without comment, the relation of controlled body and invisible controller that the game will later expose, through the Holy Glasses, as its own deepest secret (Chapter Five, §5.5). Second, the prologue is followed by a laconic narration of what intervenes: Dracula's defeat, Richter's disappearance a few years later, the search for him undertaken by Maria Renard, and the reappearance of the castle in 1797, ahead of the centennial schedule by which it is supposed to return. Into this disordered time wakes Alucard, son of Dracula and of the human woman Lisa, who had sealed himself in sleep after fighting beside Trevor Belmont in 1476 — the year, as Chapter Two will observe, of the historical Vlad III's death. He crosses a moonlit forest toward the castle; he enters its gate; and at the threshold the figure of Death strips him of his regalia. The game proper begins, as so many descents into the underworld do, with a divestiture.

1.2

The Fourth Question: Kant, Schiller, Malraux

◆

The question with which Dracula closes the disputation is the question with which Kant closed the architecture of his philosophy. In a letter to the theologian Carl Friedrich Stäudlin of 4 May 1793, and again in the *Logic* edited by Gottlob Benjamin Jäsche (1800), Kant enumerates the questions of philosophy in its "cosmopolitan" sense: What can I know? What ought I to do? What may I hope? What is man? Metaphysics answers the first, morals the second, religion the third, and anthropology the fourth; but, Kant adds, all four could be reckoned to anthropology, because the first three refer to the last (Ak. 9:25; Ak. 11:429). The fictional duel in which the vampire asks *what is a man?* takes place in 1792; Kant's letter posing *Was ist der Mensch?* is dated the following spring; his *Anthropology from a Pragmatic Point of View* appeared in 1798, the year after the castle's return. No influence is claimed. But the coincidence of question and decade is a constellation of exactly the kind this dissertation sets out to read: at the moment the European Enlightenment made the human being the summative object of philosophy, the game's fiction places the same question in the mouth of the undead.

The question's twentieth-century career sharpens its stakes. Max Scheler's *Die Stellung des Menschen im Kosmos* (1928) attempted a philosophical anthropology that would place the human between the vital and the spiritual; Heidegger's *Kant und das Problem der Metaphysik* (1929) argued that the fourth question was at bottom the question of finitude; Martin Buber's lectures on the problem of man (1938) read the history of philosophy as an alternation of epochs of homelessness and habitation; and Michel Foucault, whose complementary thesis translated and introduced Kant's *Anthropology* (1961), concluded *Les mots et les choses* (1966) by diagnosing a *sommeil anthropologique*, a slumber into which modern thought had fallen after Kant awoke from his dogmatic one, and by imagining that the figure of "man," a recent invention, might one day be erased like a face traced in sand at the edge of the sea. Read against this lineage, the opening movement of *Symphony of the Night* acquires an unlooked-for density. Its

protagonist is a sleeper who wakes in order to confront the question of the human; his sleep was self-imposed, a refusal of the world undertaken because he judged his own blood a danger to it; and the castle that wakes him is a monument to the vampire's contempt for the very being whose definition is in dispute. Kant, by his own account, was woken from dogmatic slumber by Hume (*Prolegomena*, 1783); Alucard is woken by his father's house.

Between Kant's letter and the castle's return, a second answer to the question was published that bears directly on the medium in which the game makes its own. In the fifteenth of his *Letters on the Aesthetic Education of Man* (1795), Schiller writes: "der Mensch spielt nur, wo er in voller Bedeutung des Worts Mensch ist, und er ist nur da ganz Mensch, wo er spielt" — man plays only where he is human in the full sense of the word, and he is fully human only where he plays. Schiller's *Spieltrieb*, the play-drive, is not one faculty among others but a mediating third that reconciles the sensuous drive (*Stofftrieb*) with the formal drive (*Formtrieb*), animal with rational nature, without abolishing either. The structural homology with the dhampir is exact, and it will be developed in Chapter Seven: the play-drive is the faculty of the between, and the dhampir is its incarnation. For the present it is enough to observe that Schiller answers Kant's fourth question with the concept of play, and that a game answers Dracula's by being played. Gadamer would later make the point ontological, arguing in *Wahrheit und Methode* (1960) that the mode of being of the artwork is play, and that play is not the activity of a subject but a movement that plays through its players. The disputation of the prologue is decided, accordingly, not by the player's opinion but by the to-and-fro of a game in which the player is also played.

Dracula's own answer requires closer attention to its source. The English formula echoes a passage near the opening of André Malraux's *Antimémoires* (1967), where Malraux, explaining why he declines to write the usual confession of a life, holds that in essentials a man is what he conceals — *un misérable petit tas de secrets* — and therefore not worth the memoirist's attention. Whether the echo was deliberate on the part of the game's localization staff is undocumented, and the Japanese text does not, by itself, require it; the dissertation treats the allusion as a fact of the English text, which is the text that canonized the line. Its context matters more than

its provenance. Malraux's sentence is a polemic against the confessional anthropology inaugurated by Rousseau's *Confessions* (1782–1789), in which the truth of a person is located in the private interior that confession exposes, and against its twentieth-century heir, psychoanalysis. For Malraux the secret is contemptible precisely because it is merely private; what deserves narration is the human being who confronts history, destiny, and art — the subject of *La Condition humaine* (1933) and of the *Musée imaginaire* (1947), that "museum without walls" in which photographic reproduction gathers the art of every age into a single, decontextualized space. Each of these Malrucian themes will return: the castle is itself an imaginary museum, an anthology of European architectural and pictorial idioms assembled in Tokyo from reproductions, and its Marble Gallery is a museum in name.

The decisive observation, however, is that the game **inverts Malraux**. Where Malraux dismisses the pile of secrets as unworthy of literature, *Symphony of the Night* makes it the very substance of its world. Its walls break open to disclose rooms; its rooms conceal relics; its relics unlock further rooms; and its apparent totality conceals a second castle the size of the first. The question *what is a man?* is transposed, ludically, into the question *what does the castle hide?*, and the two questions are answered by the same act: search. Dracula's contempt for the secret is refuted not by an argument but by the form of the game that contains him, which treats the secret as the place where value lies. In this inversion, Malraux's misery recovers the counterweight it had lost. Pascal had defined the human being by a dialectic of *misère* and *grandeur* — "L'homme n'est qu'un roseau, le plus faible de la nature; mais c'est un roseau pensant" — in which wretchedness and greatness are inseparable because the same consciousness that knows its misery is the source of its dignity. Malraux's formula keeps the misery and discards the greatness. The game restores the dialectic in another key: the secret that Dracula despises is the measure of a depth he will not grant, and the misery he names will be revalued, by Lisa's injunction, as the ground of compassion.

Behind Pascal stands the oldest answer to the question in the European canon. The first stasimon of Sophocles' *Antigone* opens with the claim that many things are *deinon*, but nothing more *deinon* than the human being (332–333): a word that means at once wondrous, terrible, and strange, and

that Heidegger rendered as *unheimlich*, uncanny, not-at-home. The vampire's question thus arrives already answered by a tradition that found the human the most uncanny of beings. The dhampir, who is at home neither among men nor among monsters, will be that tradition's figure: the human being as the uncanniest, because the most between.

1.3

Two Operations: Retrograde and Inversion

◆

The *Castlevania* series has long titled itself in the vocabulary of music — *rondo*, *nocturne*, *symphony*, and, after 1997, *harmony*, *aria*, *lament*, *portrait*, *order*, *ballad* — and criticism has generally treated the habit as ornament, an index of the series' investment in Gothic atmosphere and of the prestige of its scores. This dissertation takes the titles at their word. A symphony and a nocturne are not merely moods but forms, and the art from which both descend, European counterpoint, possesses a precise grammar of transformation. A melodic subject may be stated in its prime form; it may be read backward, from last note to first (**retrograde**, the *canon cancrizans* or crab canon); its intervals may be turned upside down, so that every rise becomes a fall of the same size (**inversion**, the *canon per motum contrarium*); or both operations may be applied at once (**retrograde inversion**). These four forms, systematized in the canonic practice of the Franco-Flemish polyphonists and brought to a summit in the late works of J. S. Bach, exhaust the ways in which a line may be transformed while remaining recognizably itself. *Symphony of the Night*, the dissertation contends, is organized by the same four forms, and its philosophical argument is carried by them.

The repertory supplies exact precedents. Bach's *Musikalisches Opfer* (BWV 1079, 1747), composed on a theme given by Frederick the Great, includes a two-voice crab canon in which one voice sings the line forward while the other sings it backward, and a canon by contrary motion in which the second voice inverts the first; in *Die Kunst der Fuge* (BWV 1080), Contrapuncti 12 and 13 are mirror fugues, written out twice, *rectus* and *inversus*, the second a complete inversion of the first. Haydn's Symphony No. 47 in

Figure 2

The Four Forms of a Line

THE CIPHER

the alphabet set out in rows beneath the seven note names

A	B	C	D	E	F	G
a	*b*	*c*	*d*	*e*	*f*	*g*
h	*i*	*j*	*k*	*l*	*m*	*n*
o	*p*	*q*	*r*	*s*	*t*	*u*
v	*w*	*x*	*y*	*z*		

THE NAME

D R A C U L A

d d a c g e a

Prime

the line as written

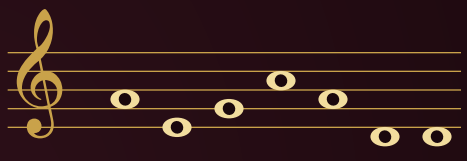


D R A C U L A

d d a c g e a

Retrograde

canon cancrizans, *the crab*



A L U C A R D

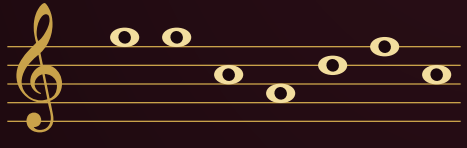
a e g c a d d

mirror in pitch: the inversion

mirror in time: the retrograde

Inversion

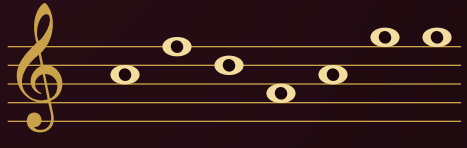
canon per motum contrarium



g g c a d f c

Retrograde inversion

the prime turned through 180°



c f d a c g g

The name as a crab canon. Set to pitches by a musical cipher of the French kind, DRACULA yields the line d d a c g e a; read from last note to first it becomes ALUCARD and sounds the retrograde. Inversion turns every interval upside down. Retrograde inversion, the score turned through 180 degrees as in the table duet, is the form the dissertation finds in the Inverted Castle (§1.3).

G major (1772) has been known as "The Palindrome" because the minuet and trio of its third movement are marked *al roverso*: each second half is the first played backward. A symphony, in other words, can contain a retrograde as one of its movements. Most suggestive of all is the so-called *Spiegel* or "table" duet for two violins, long attributed to Mozart though its authenticity is doubtful, whose single page is laid flat between two players seated face to face: one reads the score right way up, the other upside down, and the two readings sound together as a coherent duet. To rotate a score through 180 degrees is to reverse it on both axes at once — time runs backward and pitch is inverted — so that the second player performs the retrograde inversion of the first. The table duet is the musical form of an object that remains itself when turned on its centre.

The first of the game's two operations is borne by its protagonist's name. ALUCARD is DRACULA read from right to left. The device has a cinematic origin that is also a lesson in the economy of secrets. It was coined for Universal's *Son of Dracula* (1943, directed by Robert Siodmak), in which Lon Chaney Jr.'s "Count Alucard" arrives in the American South under a disguise that is no disguise at all, since any attentive reader can reverse it; the film duly includes the moment of discovery. The retrograde name is therefore an open secret: a concealment that confesses, a mask whose eyeholes spell the face beneath it. When Konami adopted the name for the son of Dracula in *Akumajō Densetsu* (*Castlevania III: Dracula's Curse*, 1989) and gave him the leading role in 1997, the meaning of the device shifted. What had been the father's incognito became the son's identity: the mask of the father turned into the face of the child. The same year in which *Symphony of the Night* made Alucard the dhampir hero, Kouta Hirano's manga *Hellsing* (from 1997) revived the older usage, giving the name to Dracula himself in the service of a Protestant order of vampire hunters. In 1997, in Japan, the reversed name designated both the father and the son.

The retrograde of the name has a theological precedent of startling exactness. The Vespers hymn *Ave maris stella*, attested from the ninth century, salutes the Virgin with the words of the Annunciation and asks her to establish the faithful in peace, "mutans Evae nomen": changing the name of Eve. The change is literal. AVE, Gabriel's greeting to Mary, is EVA read backward, and medieval exegesis drew the consequence that the woman through whom the Fall was undone bore its name reversed. Behind the

hymn stands the theology of Irenaeus of Lyons, whose *Adversus haereses* (c. 180) describes salvation as *recapitulatio* (Greek *anakephalaiōsis*, after Ephesians 1:10): Christ retraces the path of Adam in order to undo it, the tree of the Cross answering the tree of Eden, and Mary's obedience loosing the knot that Eve's disobedience had tied. Irenaeus makes the logic explicit in a figure drawn from cordage: what has been bound can be released only if the windings of the binding are bent back in reverse — *reflectantur retrorsus* — so that the later turns undo the earlier ones (III.22.4). In the patristic imagination, redemption is a retrograde. The figure who undoes the fallen order does so by traversing it backward and by bearing, in reversed form, the name of what she or he redeems. The dissertation does not claim that Alucard's name was devised with Irenaeus in mind; the name came from Hollywood. It claims that the game makes of its borrowed device what the hymn made of Gabriel's greeting: a sign that the son's task is to read the father's history backward until its knot comes loose.

A second, older precedent illuminates the apotropaic function of reversal. The Sator square — SATOR AREPO TENET OPERA ROTAS — inscribed at Pompeii before 79 CE and copied for centuries afterwards as a charm against fire, fever, and witchcraft, reads identically in four directions. In 1926 it was proposed that its letters rearrange into a cross formed by the words PATER NOSTER, crossing at their shared N, with an A and an O left over at each arm's end: alpha and omega. The hypothesis remains contested, but its plausibility to generations of commentators testifies to a durable intuition: that a palindrome may hide a father, and that the reversible word protects its bearer. Alucard's name is such a charm. It contains the father entire and turns him against himself.

The second operation is borne by the castle. After the player has acquired the Holy Glasses and freed Richter from the orb that controls him, Dracula's castle is replaced by its inverse: a second castle in which every chamber of the first reappears turned on its centre, ceilings become floors, and the map of the first castle is reproduced rotated through 180 degrees. The rotation is crucial to the argument. Turning a plane figure through half a circle reflects it on both axes at once: up becomes down and left becomes right. If the map is read as a score — horizontal extension as the dimension of traversal, the temporal axis along which the player's path unfolds, and vertical extension as the dimension of height, which the castle, like a

melodic line, organizes into registers from catacomb to keep — then the Inverted Castle is not merely an inversion but a **retrograde inversion** of the first. It is the table duet built in stone. The player who enters it has, in effect, crossed to the other side of the table.

The complete pattern can now be stated. The prologue retrogrades narrative time, placing the previous work's end at the new work's beginning. The protagonist's name retrogrades the father's. The second castle retrograde-inverts the first. And the climax of the game sets the retrograde son loose in the retrograde-inverted house, completing the matrix of contrapuntal forms. Arnold Schoenberg, defending the twelve-tone method in 1941, argued that musical space is a unity in which a shape remains recognizable however it is turned, as the mind recognizes a knife, a bottle, or a watch in any position; he likened this space to the heaven Swedenborg described, and Balzac dramatized in *Séraphîta* (1834–1835), where there is no absolute up or down, left or right. The analogy will matter twice: once because the Inverted Castle is precisely such a space, recognizable in every orientation; and again because Balzac's Swedenborgian angel is an androgyne, a being between the sexes as Alucard, whose beauty Ayami Kojima painted as conspicuously androgynous, is a being between the living and the dead.

The literary tradition knows the same operations. Lewis Carroll's *Through the Looking-Glass* (1871) presents its readers with a poem printed in mirror-writing, so that "Jabberwocky," the ballad of a monster slain by a boy, must be held up to a glass to be read; and it introduces a White Queen who lives backward, remembering what has not yet happened and crying out before she is pricked. Hegel had already described, in the *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807), a *verkehrte Welt*, an inverted world in which what is honoured in the first world is despised and what is punished is pardoned; Dante had passed, at the centre of the *Inferno*, through the point toward which all weights are drawn, and found himself climbing upward along legs that a moment before had hung downward. Each of these will receive its due in later chapters. Here it suffices to insist on the thesis they jointly support: that the retrograde and the inversion are not tricks laid over *Symphony of the Night* but the grammar of its thought, and that to understand what the game says about the human being, one must learn to read in all four directions at once.

1.4

A Game of Mourning: *Symphony of the Night* as *Trauerspiel*

◆

Walter Benjamin's *Ursprung des deutschen Trauerspiels* (written 1925, published 1928) set out to rescue the German Baroque drama of mourning from the comparison with classical tragedy that had condemned it. The *Trauerspiel*, Benjamin argued, is not a failed tragedy but a distinct form with its own metaphysics: its subject is not myth but history understood as catastrophe; its hero is the sovereign, who appears in the double aspect of tyrant and martyr, the two faces of a single Janus-headed figure; its mood is melancholy; its characteristic figure is the intriguer who manipulates the court; and its mode of signification is allegory, which breaks the world into fragments and reads each fragment as an emblem of transience. "Allegorien sind im Reiche der Gedanken, was Ruinen im Reiche der Dinge," Benjamin wrote: allegories are, in the realm of thought, what ruins are in the realm of things. The Baroque stage is crowded with corpses because, for allegory, the corpse is the body's final truth, the point at which the living form disintegrates into signs.

Every element of this description finds its counterpart in *Symphony of the Night*, and the German word itself makes the correspondence more than an analogy. *Trauerspiel* means mourning-play; but *Spiel* means game as well as play. *Symphony of the Night* is a *Trauer-Spiel* in the most literal sense available to the language: a game of mourning. Its sovereign is Dracula, whose tyranny over humanity springs from his martyrdom as a widower: the war he wages is the shadow of the death of Lisa, executed as a witch by the people he now persecutes, and his two faces are the faces Benjamin found on the Baroque throne. Its intriguer is Shaft, the dark priest who resurrects the sovereign, possesses the hero, and contrives the plot of the castle's return. Its melancholic is Alucard, the prince who has withdrawn from the world into sleep — Benjamin's analysis culminates in Hamlet, the melancholic prince in whom, alone among the dramatis personae of the age, mourning finds a Christian resolution, and Chapter Seven will show that Alucard is Hamlet's inverted double. Its world, finally, is allegorical in

Benjamin's precise sense. The castle is a ruin that has not yet fallen, a heap of architectural and pictorial fragments drawn from every period of European history and arranged without regard to their original contexts; and in its inverted form it disperses the sovereign's body itself into five relics — heart, tooth, rib, ring, and eye — which the hero must gather as the Baroque spectator gathered emblems.

Benjamin's categories can be specified by Freud's. In "Trauer und Melancholie" (1917), Freud distinguishes mourning, in which the libido detaches itself piece by piece from a lost object until the ego is free again, from melancholia, in which the lost object is incorporated into the ego and the reproaches once directed at it are turned inward: "Der Schatten des Objekts fiel so auf das Ich." Dracula is a melancholic whose melancholy has turned outward as rage. Unable to relinquish Lisa, he has made the world the theatre of her loss and his castle its mausoleum. Alucard is a mourner. He has already done the work of detaching himself from the dead, and what he retains of his mother is not her body or her image but her word: the injunction she spoke before her death. The dramatic difference between father and son is the clinical difference between melancholia and mourning, and the plot of the game is the attempt to bring the melancholic to the point at which mourning becomes possible.

The psychoanalysis of Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok deepens the reading by connecting mourning to the secret. In their account, an unmourned loss that cannot be spoken is preserved inside the psyche in a "crypt," an intrapsychic tomb in which the lost object is kept, as it were, undead; and a secret that a parent cannot speak may be transmitted to a child as a "phantom," a gap in the child's own psychic life that speaks in the parent's silence and haunts the descendant with a burden that is not his own (Abraham and Torok 1976; Abraham 1975). The application to *Symphony of the Night* is almost too exact. Dracula's castle is a crypt in both senses: a literal necropolis whose lower levels are catacombs, and a psychic tomb in which an unspoken grief is preserved in a state between life and death. Alucard is the bearer of a phantom, his father's unmourned loss passed to him as the curse of his blood. The Belmonts, whose every generation must fight the same enemy, inherit a phantom of their own. And Malraux's pile of secrets, read through this lens, ceases to be a contemptible residue of private life and becomes the very material of transgenerational

suffering: the secrets of the dead that govern the living. The Inverted Castle, on this reading, is the crypt turned inside out — the place where what was kept hidden is made into the space of the world.

1.5
The Pessimist Anthropodicy: Statement of Thesis

◆

The word *theodicy* was coined by Leibniz, whose *Essais de Théodicée* (1710) sought to justify the goodness of God in the face of evil by arguing that the actual world, with all its suffering, is the best that was possible. Voltaire's *Candide* (1759), written in the aftermath of the Lisbon earthquake of 1755, mocked the argument into the ground; and in 1791 — the year before the duel that opens the game — Kant published an essay declaring the failure of every philosophical attempt at theodicy, offering in its place the figure of Job, whose sincerity before an incomprehensible God he preferred to the advocacy of Job's friends. Odo Marquard has argued that the collapse of theodicy did not end the trial but changed the defendant: once God was acquitted, so to speak, by being removed from the dock, the human being took his place, and modernity became an epoch in which humanity is ceaselessly accused and must ceaselessly justify itself. Nikolai Berdyaev had already given the new task a name, *anthropodicy*, the justification of the human being, which he located in the creative act (Berdyaev 1916); Ernest Becker later argued that a secular age requires an anthropodicy to replace the theodicy it has lost (Becker 1968).

Symphony of the Night stages such a trial. Its prosecutor is Dracula, whose indictment of humanity is grounded in a concrete injustice — the burning of Lisa — and generalized into the anthropological contempt of the prologue. Its advocate is Lisa, who speaks only once and posthumously, through her son's memory: do not hate humans, she tells him; if you cannot live among them, at least do them no harm, for their lot is already hard enough. Its executor is Alucard, who must carry the advocate's plea through the prosecutor's house and enforce it against the prosecutor himself. What makes the anthropodicy *pessimist* is the ground of Lisa's plea. She does not argue that humans are innocent. They burned her; the game

never suggests they did not. Nor does she argue that they are, on balance, good, or that their history tends toward improvement. She argues that their condition is already one of suffering, and that suffering, not merit, is the ground of the claim they make on the one who could destroy them.

This is the precise point at which the vampire's anthropology and the mother's ethics touch and divide. Dracula and Lisa agree on the premise: the human condition is wretched. They diverge on the conclusion. For Dracula, wretchedness warrants contempt: the human being is a miserable little pile of secrets, and its misery disqualifies it from consideration. For Lisa, the same wretchedness warrants compassion. The divergence was formulated, half a century before Malraux, by Schopenhauer, who proposed in *Parerga und Paralipomena* (1851, II, §156) that the fitting form of address between one human being and another would be not *Monsieur* or *Sir* but "Leidensgefährte, Soci malorum, compagnon de misères, my fellow-sufferer." The ethical movement of *Symphony of the Night* runs from Malraux's *misérable* to Schopenhauer's *compagnon de misères* — from the contempt that misery elicits in the one who stands outside it to the fellowship it elicits in the one who knows himself to share it. That Schopenhauer drew his ethic of compassion, *Mitleid*, partly from his reading of Indian thought, and that the Buddhist movement from *duḥkha* to *karuṇā*, from suffering to compassion, is a commonplace of the Japanese religious culture in which the game was made, is a resonance the dissertation will note without overstating.

The inversion of the castle gives this ethical movement its spatial form, and Hegel supplies the hinge. In the chapter of the *Phenomenology* on force and the understanding, Hegel describes the inverted world as one in which the laws of the first are turned into their opposites, and he chooses a juridical example: the punishment that, in the first world, disgraces and destroys the criminal becomes, in the inverted world, a pardon that preserves his essence and restores his honour. The passage could serve as an epigraph to the second half of the game. Dracula's castle is the world of punishment, in which humanity is condemned for the crime of Lisa's death; its inversion is the world of pardon, in which the same crime is met with the mercy Lisa asked for. The Inverted Castle is the *verkehrte Welt* of vengeance: the same building, read in the opposite direction, becomes the architecture of forgiveness.

The dissertation formalizes Alucard's itinerary through this architecture as a sequence of seven moments, each named by a term from the Greek vocabularies of tragedy and of patristic theology. The first is ***kenōsis***, the emptying (Philippians 2:7): at the castle gate Death strips Alucard of the regalia with which he arrives, so that the son enters the father's house in the form of a servant. The second is ***anamnēsis***, recollection: the powers Alucard recovers in the castle — the Soul of Bat, the Form of Mist, the Soul of Wolf — are not new acquisitions but fragments of his own nature, so that his progress is a remembering of what he already was. The third is ***apokalypsis***, the unveiling: the Holy Glasses that Maria gives him reveal the orb that controls Richter, making visible the invisible apparatus of possession. The fourth is ***peripeteia***, the reversal that Aristotle placed at the heart of tragedy (*Poetics* 11): the castle turns on its axis. The fifth is ***anakephalaiōsis***, recapitulation in Irenaeus's sense: Alucard gathers the dispersed remains of his father, which the game files in the same inventory category, "Relics," as the recovered fragments of the son's own powers. The sixth is ***anagnōrisis***, recognition, Aristotle's second tragic hinge: defeated, Dracula learns from his son the last words of the woman he lost, and in recognizing them recognizes the betrayal his war had committed against her. The seventh is ***apotaxis***, the renunciation that early Christian baptism required of the candidate, who, according to the mystagogical catecheses of Cyril of Jerusalem, faced west to renounce Satan before turning east to profess the faith: Alucard, his father dead, renounces the inheritance of his blood and withdraws from the world.

The thesis of the dissertation can now be stated in full. *Castlevania: Symphony of the Night* is a *Trauerspiel* — a game of mourning — whose argument is carried by the contrapuntal operations of retrograde and inversion and whose answer to the question of the human is a pessimist anthropodicy. Through the figure of Alucard, who reads his father's name and history backward, and through the Inverted Castle, which turns the father's house of punishment into a house of pardon, the game constructs a mode of understanding that the dissertation calls **dhampiric reason**: the capacity to disclose the concealed half of an apparent totality by reading it against its own grain, without abolishing either of the halves thus brought into relation. Dhampiric reason knows the human being as Dracula knows it, as a miserable pile of secrets; it acts toward the human being as Lisa

Figure 3

The Seven Moments



Alucard's itinerary as formalized in §1.5: seven moments named from the Greek vocabularies of tragedy and patristic theology. Three fall in the first castle and three in its inversion; between them stands the peripeteia*, the reversal Aristotle placed at the heart of tragedy, which here is the turning of the house itself.*

asked, with the compassion owed to a fellow-sufferer; and it hopes, as the inversion of the castle hopes, that punishment may be turned into pardon by the one who bears in his own blood both the accuser and the accused. Its answer to Kant's fourth question is the dhampir: the human being as the creature that exists between, and that finds in its betweenness not a defect to be cured but the condition of mercy.

1.6

Three Centennials: 1797, 1897, 1997

◆

The fiction of the *Castlevania* series holds that Dracula's castle returns once a century, and that its premature appearance in 1797 is a sign of disorder in the cycle. The game's own position in history repeats the cycle with an exactness its makers may not have intended. Its diegetic year, 1797, stands one hundred years before the publication of Bram Stoker's *Dracula* on 26 May 1897; its release, in 1997, fell in the novel's centenary year. The castle's centennial return is thus enacted at the level of the work's own chronology: 1797, 1897, 1997. The dissertation reads the three dates as a constellation in Benjamin's sense — "Die Ideen verhalten sich zu den Dingen wie die Sternbilder zu den Sternen," ideas are to things as constellations are to stars — that is, as an arrangement of historically separate points that makes an idea visible without claiming a causal line between them.

The prologue's year, 1792, is the year in which the European order the vampire embodies began to die. On 20 September the revolutionary army held the Prussians at Valmy, and Goethe, who was present, later recorded his verdict to his companions: "Von hier und heute geht eine neue Epoche der Weltgeschichte aus, und ihr könnt sagen, ihr seid dabei gewesen" — from this place and this day a new epoch of world history begins, and you can say you were there. The next day the Convention abolished the monarchy. The aristocratic undead of the Gothic imagination were already, for some contemporaries, figures for the *ancien régime*; Marx would later fuse the two images in the opening of *Der achtzehnte Brumaire des Louis Bonaparte* (1852): "Die Tradition aller toten Geschlechter lastet wie ein Alp

Figure 4

A Constellation of Centennials



The three centennials read as a constellation in Benjamin's sense (§1.6): historically separate points arranged so that an idea becomes visible, without a causal line drawn between them. Around each year, the events the dissertation gathers to it.

auf dem Gehirne der Lebenden." The tradition of all dead generations weighs like a nightmare on the brains of the living — and *Alp* is not merely a bad dream but the demon that sits on the sleeper's chest, the incubus. That Rondo's Count is defeated in the year the French monarchy fell, and that his castle returns in the exhausted years of the Directory, places the series' aristocratic monster in exactly the historical position Marx's sentence describes.

The year 1797 is the *annus mirabilis* of the Romantic undead. In German literary history it is the *Balladenjahr*, the year in which Goethe and Schiller competed in the composition of ballads, and Goethe's contributions read like a programme for the game. "Die Braut von Korinth," written in June, is among the foundational vampire poems of European literature: a girl vowed to the Church by her converted mother returns from the grave to her pagan bridegroom, drinks his heart's blood, and indicts the new faith in terms that anticipate Dracula's jibe at religion: "Opfer fallen hier, / Weder Lamm noch Stier, / Aber Menschenopfer unerhört" — victims fall here, neither lamb nor bull, but human sacrifices unheard of. At the poem's close she asks her mother to build a pyre, so that the lovers may hasten through fire to the old gods. "Der Zauberlehrling," of the same year, supplies the motto of the prologue's aetiology, in which Dracula insists that human beings summoned him: "Die ich rief, die Geister, / Werd ich nun nicht los" — the spirits that I called I now cannot be rid of. And "Der Gott und die Bajadere," also of 1797, poses in its first stanza the question of the anthropodicy itself. The god Mahadöh descends to earth to share human joy and torment, because "Soll er strafen oder schonen, / Muß er Menschen menschlich sehn": if he is to punish or to spare, he must see human beings humanly. Within a single season, then, Goethe wrote a vampire who accuses religion, an apprentice who cannot dismiss what he conjured, and a god who must decide whether humanity deserves punishment or mercy, and who can decide only by seeing it from within. These are the three axes of *Symphony of the Night*.

Coleridge composed the first part of "Christabel" in the same year. Its lamia, Geraldine, cannot enter the castle unaided; Christabel must lift her "over the threshold of the gate," anticipating by a century the rule, made canonical by Stoker's Count ("Enter freely and of your own will!"), that the vampire's entry requires the host's consent. Inside, the spirit of Christabel's

dead mother hovers as a guardian, and Geraldine banishes it: "Off, wandering mother! Peak and pine! / I have power to bid thee flee." The dead mother as protector of the threatened child, and the vampire as the power that would drive her away, are the poles between which Alucard moves. Meanwhile, in Saxony, the death of Novalis's fiancée Sophie von Kühn on 19 March 1797 led to the experience at her grave that he recorded on 13 May and transfigured into the *Hymnen an die Nacht* (1800), the founding document of the Romantic sacralization of night. The game's Japanese subtitle, *Gekka no Yasōkyoku*, "Nocturne in the Moonlight," belongs to that tradition. In the same years, an anonymous manuscript in Hegel's hand, the so-called "Oldest System-Programme of German Idealism" (1796/97), demanded *eine neue Mythologie*, a "mythology of reason" that would make philosophy sensuous and the people rational, and declared the highest act of reason to be an aesthetic act. The dissertation proposes, in its conclusion, that games like *Symphony of the Night* are among the forms in which such a mythology has actually been realized.

The constellation of 1797 extends further. Ann Radcliffe published *The Italian*, whose sinister confessor Schedoni stands in the lineage of the corrupt cleric that culminates, in the game, in Shaft. Mary Wollstonecraft, whose *Vindication of the Rights of Woman* had appeared in 1792, died on 10 September 1797, eleven days after giving birth to the daughter who, as Mary Shelley, would write *Frankenstein* on the same Genevan night in 1816 that produced Polidori's "The Vampyre": the modern monster and the modern vampire were conceived together, and the author of the first was born in the year of the game's fiction to a mother she lost at birth. Haydn was composing *Die Schöpfung*, whose overture, "Die Vorstellung des Chaos," represents the primordial disorder from which light is called — a musical image of the castle that later games in the series would describe as a creature of chaos. On 17 October the Treaty of Campo Formio extinguished the Venetian Republic after more than a millennium: an ancient polity fell into ruin as the castle rose.

The year 1997 belongs to a different world, and the game's relation to it is equally pointed. Japan was in the middle of the economic stagnation that followed the collapse of the asset bubble, and 1995 had brought twin traumas: the Great Hanshin earthquake in January and, in March, the sarin attack on the Tokyo subway by Aum Shinrikyō, an apocalyptic sect that had

syncretized Buddhist, Hindu, and Christian eschatology under a guru who styled himself a messiah. Anno Hideaki's *Shinseiki Evangelion* (1995–1996), whose cinematic conclusion appeared in July 1997, had made Judaeo-Christian esoterica a dominant idiom of Japanese popular spectacle. In the same July, Miyazaki Hayao's *Mononoke-hime* told of a young man cursed by the hatred of a wounded god, who resolves to look upon the world with eyes that hatred does not cloud: a parable of Lisa's injunction, released four months after the game. In the United States, *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* premiered in March 1997, ten days before the game's Japanese release, introducing a vampire whose restored soul obliges him to renounce his nature. In May, IBM's Deep Blue defeated the world chess champion Garry Kasparov, giving the question *what is a man?* a computational urgency it had not had in Kant's Königsberg. And in the academy, 1997 saw the publication of Espen Aarseth's *Cybertext* and Janet Murray's *Hamlet on the Holodeck*, the two books from which the academic study of games would take its first bearings.

In the history of the medium, finally, 1997 was the year of the polygon. *Final Fantasy VII*, released in January, consolidated the industry's turn toward three-dimensional, cinematic presentation that *Super Mario 64* had inaugurated the previous year; the platform holder in North America was widely reported to disfavour two-dimensional titles. *Symphony of the Night* arrived as a lavishly animated work of two-dimensional sprite art, using the PlayStation's capacities for transparency, scaling, and layered effects to perfect a mode that the market had begun to treat as obsolete. The game is thus itself a revenant: an older form returning before its time had come again, sustained by the blood of a newer technology, out of joint with its era as its castle is out of joint with its century. Chapter Three develops this reading of the game as a revenant medium.

1.7

Method: Contrapuntal, Constellational, Procedural

◆

The dissertation's method has three components, each named for the operation it performs on its object. The first is **contrapuntal**. The term is borrowed, with acknowledgment and alteration, from Edward Said, who in *Culture and Imperialism* (1993) proposed a "contrapuntal reading" of metropolitan texts that would hear, alongside the history they narrate, the histories against which they act. Here the term operates in two registers. Formally, it names the analysis of the game's structure through the four transformations of counterpoint set out in §1.3. Culturally, it names the attempt to hear three voices at once in a single work: the European tradition from which the game's imagery descends (Gothic, Romantic, Catholic, Baroque); the Japanese reimagining of that tradition, which belongs to a lineage of imaginary Europes running from Riyoko Ikeda's *Berusaiyu no Bara* (*The Rose of Versailles*, 1972–1973) and its Takarazuka staging through Moto Hagio's vampire manga to the aristocratic gothic of *visual kei*; and the anglophone localization, which, by echoing Malraux, inscribed into the work a European philosophical allusion its Japanese text did not require. The result is a double displacement — Europe imagined from Tokyo, then retranslated into a European idiom — that is itself a contrapuntal operation, a subject passed between voices and altered in the passing. Koichi Iwabuchi's account of the *mukokuseki*, the "stateless" or culturally odourless character of many Japanese media exports (Iwabuchi 2002), is relevant here with a qualification: *Symphony of the Night* is not odourless but conspicuously European in its fiction, while its Japanese authorship is visible only in its paratexts and in an aesthetic sensibility the following chapters will try to name.

The second component is **constellational**, after Benjamin's "Erkenntniskritische Vorrede" to the *Trauerspiel* book. A constellation is not a genealogy: it does not claim that the stars it joins influenced one another, only that their arrangement discloses a figure that none of them shows alone. The dissertation's comparisons — Kant's letter and Dracula's

question, Irenaeus's knot and Alucard's name, Hegel's inverted world and the inverted castle — are constellational in this sense, and the three evidential tiers set out in the prefatory note (documented filiation, generic inheritance, constellational affinity) are designed to keep the method honest. Since W. K. Wimsatt and Monroe Beardsley's critique of the "intentional fallacy" (1946), literary criticism has accepted that a work's meanings are not limited to those its makers intended; the dissertation accepts the principle but declines its abuse, and marks every claim that goes beyond what can be documented.

The third component is **procedural**. A game argues not only through its script and images but through its rules and processes, a capacity Ian Bogost has called procedural rhetoric (Bogost 2007). Espen Aarseth's concept of the ergodic, a text whose traversal requires non-trivial effort (Aarseth 1997), Jesper Juul's account of games as "half-real," composed of real rules and fictional worlds (Juul 2005), Henry Jenkins's description of game design as narrative architecture (Jenkins 2004), Alexander Galloway's theory of gamic action (Galloway 2006), and C. Thi Nguyen's argument that games are an art whose medium is agency itself (Nguyen 2020) together license the dissertation's central methodological wager: that the philosophy of *Symphony of the Night* is to be found as much in its map, inventory, save system, and gating structure as in its dialogue. The coffin in which Alucard sleeps to preserve the player's progress, the inventory category that files the son's powers beside the father's remains, and the percentage counter that measures exploration against a total it can exceed are treated as philosophical statements in their own right.

These components are held together by a hermeneutic stance. Paul Ricoeur famously grouped Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud as the "masters of suspicion," interpreters who taught modernity to read every manifest meaning as the mask of a latent one (Ricoeur 1965). It has gone unremarked that all three reached for the figure of the revenant at decisive moments. Marx described capital as dead labour that, vampire-like, lives only by sucking living labour (*Das Kapital* I, 1867, ch. 10). Nietzsche wrote in *Der Antichrist* (§58): "Das Christenthum war der Vampyr des imperium Romanum." Freud's theory of the uncanny (1919) is a theory of the return of what was repressed, the dead that do not stay buried. The vampire is the emblem of suspicion, and in the prologue of *Symphony of the Night* the

emblem speaks in its own voice, turning the hermeneutics of suspicion against the faith that hunts it. Ricoeur, however, did not stop at suspicion. He proposed that beyond the desert of criticism lay the possibility of a "second naïveté," a renewed hearing of symbols that had passed through critique, and he summarized the principle in a formula: *le symbole donne à penser*. The dissertation reads the trajectory of the game as a passage from suspicion to such a second hearing, from the vampire's unmasking of religion to the son's recovery of a mother's word.

Comparative mythology, finally, is used with caution. Joseph Campbell's monomyth, with its stages of the threshold crossing, the woman as temptress, and atonement with the father, maps onto Alucard's itinerary with suspicious ease, and the ease is itself a warning: the monomyth was constructed to fit everything and therefore explains little. Mircea Eliade's accounts of the eternal return and the *axis mundi* and Claude Lévi-Strauss's analysis of myth as the logical mediation of contradiction — in which an anomalous mediator, such as the carrion-eating raven between hunter and grazer, bridges opposed categories — are more useful, because they describe operations rather than plots. The dhampir is a Lévi-Straussian mediator of the purest kind, and its preferred animal form, the bat, was already anomalous in Leviticus (11:19), which lists it among the birds that may not be eaten.

1.8

Corpus, Versions, and the Problem of the Ludic Text

◆

What, precisely, is being read? A novel has a text that every reader traverses in the same order; a game has a space of possible traversals, no two identical. Aarseth distinguished between the "scriptons" a reader actually encounters and the "textons" from which they are generated, and his distinction applies here with full force: the text of *Symphony of the Night* is not any single playthrough but the structured ensemble of all of them, including the many that never reach the Inverted Castle. That ensemble includes the abortive ending in which Alucard, lacking the Holy Glasses,

kills the possessed Richter and the game concludes at what is in fact its midpoint; it includes the variant endings that follow Dracula's defeat, inflected by how much of the two castles the player has explored; and it includes the paths that remain hidden from most players, such as the name-entry codes that let a player who has finished the game begin again as Richter. A reading that ignored these variants would misdescribe the work, because the variants are where the work hides its argument.

The ludic text is surrounded by paratexts in Gérard Genette's sense, the thresholds through which a text is entered (Genette 1987): manuals, official illustrations, strategy guides, soundtrack releases, interviews, and the editorial history of later re-releases. Genette's figure for the paratext is a vestibule, and it is apt that *Symphony of the Night* begins in one: the prologue, a playable restaging of another work, is a paratext that has been absorbed into the text, a threshold one must cross in order to enter. Statements by the game's makers are used sparingly and never as the final word. Koji Igarashi, for example, has said in interviews that the exploratory design owed more to the *Legend of Zelda* series than to *Metroid*, the comparison posterity has nonetheless enshrined in a genre name; and the series itself had experimented with non-linear exploration in *Vampire Killer* (MSX2, 1986) and *Castlevania II: Simon's Quest* (1987). Such information illuminates the game's place in design history without settling its meaning.

The instability of the text across versions is itself instructive. The 1998 Saturn version adds a playable Maria Renard and further areas; the 2007 retranslation, prepared for a handheld compilation and later reused, recast the dialogue, including the prologue, in an English closer to the Japanese and more restrained than the 1997 script, at the price of the lines that the original localization had made famous. The dissertation's preference for the 1997 text is not a judgment of fidelity but of reception: it is the 1997 text that entered the culture, that generated the meme-life of its prologue, and that carries the Malrucian echo on which so much of this argument depends. The game's textual history thus repeats its theme. Like the castle, the text returns in altered forms, and like the castle, each return both preserves and inverts what came before.

1.9
State of the Field

Symphony of the Night occupies a curious position in the literature: universally cited, rarely read. In the history of game design it figures as a canonical origin, the work whose synthesis of action, role-playing progression, and interconnected exploration gave its name to half a genre; design criticism has analysed its gating structures, its pacing, and its economy of rewards with considerable sophistication. Its afterlife in enthusiast culture is vast — in preservation and translation-comparison communities, in speedrunning, in the meme-life of its prologue — and much of the most precise knowledge about the game resides there. Academic criticism has engaged it far less. The Gothic turn in game studies, represented by the work of Tanya Krzywinska, Laurie N. Taylor, Ewan Kirkland, and Bernard Perron, among others, has concentrated on survival horror, where the Gothic is an engine of fear. *Symphony of the Night* is a Gothic work that is scarcely frightening at all. Its dominant mode is not horror but elegy, and Susan Napier's distinction among the apocalyptic, festival, and elegiac modes of Japanese animation (Napier 2001) describes it better than the categories of horror criticism: it is elegiac in tone and apocalyptic in structure.

Vampire studies offer a richer context. Christopher Frayling's anthology and essay on the literary vampire from Byron to Stoker (1991), Nina Auerbach's argument that every age embraces the vampire it needs (1995), Ken Gelder's survey of the vampire's readings (1994), and Paul Barber's forensic account of the folklore of the revenant (1988) establish the genealogy on which Chapter Two builds; Jan Perkowski's editions of Slavic material (1976, 1989) make available the ethnography of the dhampir. Two classic interpretations of Stoker bear directly on a Japanese reimagining of the Gothic: Franco Moretti's reading of the Count as monopoly capital (1978), and Stephen Arata's reading of the novel as a fantasy of "reverse colonization" in which the periphery invades the imperial centre (1990). *Symphony of the Night* performs a reverse colonization of its own, in which the Gothic, a genre through which Britain once figured its anxieties about

the East, is reappropriated from the East and returned to the West in altered form. Monster theory — Jeffrey Jerome Cohen's seven theses on the monster as a category crisis that polices the borders of the possible (Cohen 1996), Noël Carroll's account of the horrific as the categorically interstitial (Carroll 1990), Mary Douglas's anthropology of pollution (1966), and Julia Kristeva's theory of the abject (1980) — supplies the vocabulary for analysing the dhampir as a figure of the between. Japanese media theory, finally, from Iwabuchi's account of transnational circulation to Azuma Hiroki's diagnosis of a late-1990s shift from grand narratives to "database" consumption (Azuma 2001), illuminates the game's encyclopedic bestiary and item compendium as forms of a database aesthetic that coexists, uneasily, with its grand narrative of mourning.

The philosophy of games, from Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens* (1938) and Roger Caillois's typology of play (1958) to Miguel Sicart's ethics of computer games (2009) and Brendan Keogh's phenomenology of the player's embodied circuit with the avatar (2018), provides the theory of play against which the dissertation reads the game's procedures. Caillois's category of *ilinx*, the play of vertigo in which perception is deliberately disordered, describes the experience of the Inverted Castle with precision; Huizinga's "magic circle," the bounded space within which play suspends ordinary life, describes a castle that appears and vanishes on a schedule of its own.

What no existing account has attempted is a sustained reading of *Symphony of the Night*'s form as philosophical argument. The dissertation's contribution is fivefold. It proposes a contrapuntal hermeneutics of game form, in which the transformations of counterpoint serve as an analytic for spatial and narrative structure. It introduces the concept of dhampiric reason as a mode of understanding embodied in the game's procedures. It reconstructs the game's ethics as a pessimist anthropodicy and locates it in the history of theodicy and its collapse. It develops a revenant ludology, an account of the save, the death, and the return as ontological rather than merely technical features of play. And it reads the game's Gothic Europe through Japanese categories — the *onryō*, the dream-Noh, *mono no aware*, *mujō* — as well as European ones, in the belief that a work made in Tokyo about Transylvania is best understood from both sides of the table.

1.10
Architecture of the Dissertation

◆

The dissertation follows the architectonic of Kant's four questions, preceded by two chapters that establish the game's inheritance and its sensuous form.

Chapter Two, "Enter Freely and of Your Own Will," reconstructs the genealogies from which the game draws: the historical Vlad III and the Order of the Dragon, whose emblem joined Christian militancy to the image of the devil; the Habsburg vampire controversies of the 1720s and 1730s and the Enlightenment's ironic adoption of the vampire as a figure of critique; the Balkan ethnography of the dhampir as a hereditary hunter with the gift of seeing what others cannot; the Romantic year 1797 in detail; the literary vampire from Polidori to Stoker; the cinematic Count from Murnau to Coppola, including Eiko Ishioka's Academy Award-winning costumes for the 1992 film; the Japanese vampire from Moto Hagio's *Pō no Ichizoku* to Hideyuki Kikuchi and Yoshitaka Amano's dhampir D; and the series' own Belmont counter-lineage from 1986 to *Rondo of Blood*.

Chapter Three, "Gekka no Yasōkyoku," analyses the game's aesthetics: Ayami Kojima's androgynous painted prince and his relation to Pre-Raphaelite, Symbolist, and *shōjo* traditions; the Japanese gothic sensorium of *tanbi* aestheticism and *visual kei*; Michiru Yamane's score, whose partitas, toccatas, and requiems revive Baroque forms in a modern idiom; the Burkean and Kantian sublime as rendered in sprite and pixel; Tanizaki's praise of shadow; the game's status as a revenant medium; and the Buddhist aesthetics of impermanence in which the castle's fall is felt.

Chapter Four, *Was kann ich wissen?*, treats the castle as an object of knowledge: the castle as a world unto itself, from Borges's house of Asterion to Peake's Gormenghast; the architecture of the secret; the map as a memory palace in the tradition reconstructed by Frances Yates; the confessional, which the game's Royal Chapel literally contains; the false ending at the midpoint; the gold and silver rings as an alchemical union of sun and moon; the Holy Glasses as instruments of *apokalypsis* and Maria as the woman of Revelation 12; the Inverted Castle as Hegel's inverted world

Figure 5

The Architecture of the Dissertation



I Introduction: "What Is a Man?"
II Genealogies of the revenant
III The decadent sublime
IV *Was kann ich wissen?*
V *Was soll ich tun?*
VI *Was darf ich hoffen?*
VII *Was ist der Mensch?*
VIII Conclusion: *compagnon de misères*

The dissertation drawn as a façade (§1.10). Chapters of inheritance and of sensuous form stand as towers either side of the introductory portal; the three lancets are Kant's questions of knowledge, duty and hope, referred, as in his architectonic, to the rose of the fourth. The conclusion crowns the gable at dawn.

and Bach's mirror fugue; and the excess of the 200.6 per cent completion figure as a Derridean supplement that reveals every totality to be incomplete.

Chapter Five, *Was soll ich tun?*, reconstructs the game's ethics: Dracula's grief as the wrath of Achilles and the curse of the Japanese *onryō*; Lisa's execution in the history of the persecution of learned and healing women; the justified grievance of Frankenstein's creature; Richter's possession as a parable of the hunter's dependence on the hunted, glossed by Hegel's struggle for recognition and Nietzsche's warning to those who fight monsters; the orb above Richter's head as an allegory of avatarial control, read through Kleist's essay on the marionette theatre; the inversion of *Hamlet* in which a ghost forbids revenge; the Succubus who takes the mother's form, read through Kundry's seduction of Parsifal; Schopenhauer's ethics of compassion; Go Nagai's *Devilman* as the despairing counter-text to Lisa's injunction; and the reconciliation of enemies through shared grief in *Iliad* 24 and Zeami's *Atsumori*.

Chapter Six, *Was darf ich hoffen?*, turns to religion and eschatology: the vampire as hermeneut of suspicion; the inverted Eucharist; the evil cleric from Lewis's Ambrosio and Radcliffe's Schedoni to Hugo's Frollo and the game's Shaft; the syncretic arsenal of cross, Bible, holy water, *vibhūti*, and the fire-spell named for Agni; Death as a liveried servant; Dracula as Milton's Satan and as an instance of the demonic defiance Kierkegaard analysed; the castle as a Gnostic demiurge's prison and the Hymn of the Pearl as the template of Alucard's descent; the dismembered father as Osiris and Zagreus; Dante's inversion at the centre of Hell and the Harrowing of Hell; the centennial return as eternal recurrence; and the Japanese apocalyptic imaginary of 1995.

Chapter Seven, *Was ist der Mensch?*, answers the fourth question in the figure of Alucard: the name read backward; the dhampir as a parody of the Chalcedonian union of two natures; the refused Antichrist, from Adso's legend to *Good Omens* and *Hellboy*; the kenosis at the gate, read through Inanna's descent and the Hymn of the Pearl; anamnesis; the Stokerian metamorphoses into bat, wolf, and mist as Deleuzian becomings; the vampire who, uniquely, propagates by filiation rather than contagion; the doppelgänger and the afterimage; the dandy and the tragic prince; the coffin

as save point and the player as dhampir; and Bataille's accursed share as the key to Alucard's final refusal of inheritance.

Chapter Eight concludes by recapitulating the argument in inversion, defining dhampiric reason, tracing the game's afterlives — in the Metroidvania, in the Souls series and *Bloodborne*, in *Hollow Knight* and *Blasphemous*, in Igarashi's *Bloodstained* and the Netflix *Castlevania* — and reflecting on the future of mourning in play. It closes, as the game does, at dawn.



II

Enter Freely and of Your Own Will

Chapter Two

"Enter Freely and of Your Own Will"

Genealogies of the Revenant, the Dhampir, and the Romantic Annus Mirabilis

Every figure that *Symphony of the Night* assembles in 1997 arrives with a lineage, and each lineage, traced to its sources, confirms the claim the vampire makes in the prologue: that the monster does not raise itself but is called into being by human beings who desire it. This chapter reconstructs eight such lineages — the historical voivode whose name the vampire bears, the revenants of the Habsburg frontier, the hereditary hunter of Balkan folklore, the Romantic year of the game's fiction, the literary vampire from the Villa Diodati to Whitby, the cinematic Count, the Japanese vampire, and the series' own line of human hunters — in order to show that the game inherits not an iconography alone but an argument already in progress. At every stage the vampire is produced by a human medium: the printing press, the forensic report, the ballad, the serial novel, the film, the manga, the game. The chapter takes its title from the Count's greeting to Jonathan Harker in the second chapter of Stoker's novel — "Welcome to my house! Enter freely and of your own will!" — because the rule it encodes, that the vampire may cross a threshold only with the host's consent, governs the genealogy itself. Europe, and then Japan, invited the vampire in.

2.1

The Son of the Dragon: Vlad III and the Fabrication of a Monster

THE NAME the series gives its sovereign is already a filial name, and this fact governs the relation between the voivode of Wallachia and the vampire of the castle more decisively than any detail of the historical record. In December 1408 Sigismund of Luxembourg, King of Hungary and later Holy Roman Emperor, founded with his queen, Barbara of Cilli, the *Societas Draconistarum*, a fraternity of princes pledged to defend the Cross against the Ottoman advance; its badge showed a dragon curled upon itself, its tail wound about its own neck. In February 1431, at Nuremberg, Sigismund invested with the order Vlad, claimant to the Wallachian throne, who thereafter bore the byname *Dracul*, "the Dragon." His second son, born around 1430 and remembered as the Impaler, styled himself in his Latin correspondence *Dragwlya — Drăculea*, son of Dracul. Romanian *drac*, moreover, names not only the dragon of heraldry but the devil of popular belief. The name Dracula therefore means, at once and indissolubly, son of the Dragon and son of the Devil, and the order that conferred it had taken as its emblem the beast the Apocalypse identifies with Satan: "the great dragon . . . that old serpent, called the Devil" (Revelation 12:9). The inversion this dissertation traces through the game is inscribed in the name before any vampire bore it: a crusading order wearing the adversary's sign, a son named for his father's sobriquet. When the series calls Dracula's son Alucard, it reverses a patronymic. The retrograde of the name is the retrograde of filiation itself.

The historical life supplied the materials of a monster without yet producing one. Delivered with his younger brother Radu as a hostage to the Ottoman court in 1442, Vlad grew up inside the empire he would fight; he ruled Wallachia briefly in 1448, again from 1456 to 1462, and for a few weeks in 1476. His reputation rests on the systematic use of impalement as an instrument of terror, which earned him from the Ottomans the name *Kazıklı Voyvoda*, of which the Romanian epithet *Țepeș* is a later equivalent; on the night attack of June 1462 against the camp of Mehmed II; and on the

Figure 6

Genealogies of the Revenant



Symphony of the Night

The lineages Chapter Two traces, from Sigismund's Order of the Dragon to the year of the game: the European revenant of chronicle, controversy, page and screen on the left, the Japanese vampire and the Belmont series on the right. Dates as given in the text; the scale is compressed before 1700.

forest of the impaled that, according to the Byzantine historian Laonikos Chalkokondyles, met the Sultan's army before Târgoviște. Imprisoned in Hungary for more than a decade by Matthias Corvinus, he recovered his throne in 1476 and was killed in battle near Bucharest in the winter of 1476–77. Near-contemporary reports, followed by most historians, hold that his head was sent to Constantinople as a trophy; the resting place of his body remains disputed between the island monastery of Snagov and the monastery of Comana that he founded. The historical prince ended as a dispersed body. *Symphony of the Night* names the five fragments of its sovereign that the player gathers in the Inverted Castle the Heart, Tooth, Rib, Ring, and Eye "of Vlad": in the game's English text, the historical name survives only on the scattered relics of the father's body.

The monster was manufactured by the press. Within a year of Vlad's arrest, the Meistersinger Michel Beheim composed for the court of Frederick III a poem on the raging tyrant of Wallachia; from the 1480s printers in Nuremberg, Augsburg, Lübeck, Bamberg, and Strasbourg issued pamphlets recounting his atrocities, among the first secular best-sellers of the incunable age, and a Nuremberg print of 1499 shows him at table among the impaled. The image that has defined him since was a reproduction before it was a legend; the Count is, in this precise sense, a creature of what Benjamin would call technical reproducibility. The German pamphlets, shaped by the grievances of the Transylvanian Saxon merchants whom Vlad had persecuted, give the tyrant without remainder. Other archives remember otherwise. The Russian *Skazanie o Drakule voevode*, usually attributed to the diplomat Fyodor Kuritsyn (c. 1486–1490), presents a cruel but just sovereign whose terror maintains order, and reserves its harshest judgment for his reported abandonment of Orthodoxy for the Latin rite in captivity; Romanian popular memory preserves the story of a golden cup left at a public fountain that no one dared steal while he reigned. The historical Dracula is already a figure of contested reading — tyrant to one archive, lawgiver to another — the Janus-headed sovereign that Benjamin found on the Baroque throne (§1.4).

The identification of this prince with Stoker's vampire is a construction, and a late one. Stoker's working notes, preserved at the Rosenbach Museum in Philadelphia and published in facsimile in 2008, show that his vampire was first called Count Wampyr and that the name Dracula was taken from

William Wilkinson's *An Account of the Principalities of Wallachia and Moldavia* (1820), which Stoker read in the public library at Whitby in 1890 and from which he copied the gloss that in the Wallachian language the word means devil. The novel's historical allusions are few: the Count boasts of one "of my own race who as Voivode crossed the Danube and beat the Turk on his own ground" (ch. 3), and Van Helsing concludes from his Budapest correspondent that the vampire "must, indeed, have been that Voivode Dracula who won his name against the Turk" (ch. 18). The full fusion of voivode and vampire was the work of Raymond McNally and Radu Florescu's *In Search of Dracula* (1972), and it has been sharply contested by Elizabeth Miller (2000). Konami inherits the identification rather than the history, and uses it to anchor its own cycle.

The anchor is fixed with remarkable precision. *Castlevania III: Dracula's Curse* dates the first defeat of Dracula by a Belmont, aided by Alucard, to 1476, the year of the historical Vlad's last reign and death. The series thereby converts the end of the voivode's life into the beginning of the vampire's cycle: the year in which history buried the prince is the year in which myth first defeated the Count. And because Alucard seals himself in sleep after that victory and wakes only in 1797, his sleep spans exactly the three centuries in which Europe fabricated his father's legend — the pamphlets, the Habsburg reports, the Enlightenment controversies, the first Romantic ballads. The son sleeps through the making of the father's myth and wakes when Romanticism requires the vampire. His waking belongs to a family of sleepers who return into a world that has moved on without them: the Seven Sleepers of Ephesus, who in Christian legend and in the eighteenth sura of the Qur'an slept through a persecution to wake in a converted empire; Washington Irving's Rip Van Winkle (1819), who sleeps through a revolution; and, closest to the game's makers, Urashima Tarō, who spends what seem a few days in the Ryūgū-jō, the Dragon Palace beneath the sea, and returns to find that centuries have passed and that the box he was forbidden to open contains his years. Alucard, too, wakes from the house of the dragon into a world three centuries older, and the castle that rises before him is a box of secrets that will cost him everything to open.

2.2

Revenants of the Habsburg Frontier: Plogojowitz, Paole, Calmet, Voltaire, Rousseau

THE VAMPIRE entered the vocabulary of modern Europe not through literature but through a forensic report, and it did so when a Habsburg administration took possession of part of the principality the historical Dracula had ruled. By the Treaty of Passarowitz (1718) Austria acquired northern Serbia and Oltenia, the western portion of Wallachia, and its officials thereby encountered the revenant beliefs of the villages along the Military Frontier. In 1725 the imperial provisor Frombald reported from Kisiljevo that a peasant named Petar Blagojević — Peter Plogojowitz in the German texts — ten weeks dead, was held responsible for nine deaths within eight days; his widow said he had come to her to ask for his shoes. Exhumed in Frombald's presence, the body was found free of the odour of decay, with fresh blood at the mouth, its old skin sloughed away to reveal new skin, its hair and nails apparently grown; when the villagers drove a stake through it, blood poured from the ears and mouth, and they burned it. Frombald, who called the creature by its local name, *vampyri*, disclaimed responsibility in advance, pleading the villagers' terror; his report appeared in the *Wienerisches Diarium* that July. A second case, at Medveđa, produced the document that made the vampire a European sensation: the *Visum et Repertum* dated at Belgrade on 26 January 1732 and signed by the regimental field surgeon Johann Flückinger and his colleagues, which described the exhumation of more than a dozen bodies found in "the vampire condition" and traced the contagion to one Arnaut Paole, a former soldier who had claimed to have cured himself of a vampire's attentions by eating earth from its grave and smearing himself with its blood.

The title of Flückinger's report — "seen and found," the formula of the medico-legal inspection — names the genre in which the modern vampire was born. It is the first monster of modern Europe to be certified by the state: examined by surgeons, attested by officers, filed with the imperial administration, and reprinted, translated, and disputed across the continent. Within two years more than a dozen treatises had appeared in

the German-speaking lands alone, among them an expanded edition of Michael Ranft's study of the chewing and smacking of the dead in their graves (1728; German version 1734), and the word entered English and French print in the wake of the reports. The physicians and theologians who debated the cases confronted a sign that their own traditions read in opposite directions. In the Latin West the incorrupt corpse was a mark of sanctity, the body preserved for glory; in the Greek East, as Leo Allatius had reported in 1645, the body that would not decay was the *tympaniaios*, swollen like a drum, the corpse of an excommunicate held by an unlifted anathema. The same phenomenon signified the saint to one Church and the damned to the other. The vampire and the saint are retrograde images of one another — a single sign read from opposite sides of the schism — and the controversy the Habsburg reports provoked was at bottom a quarrel about how to read the dead.

The Enlightenment answered with taxonomy and irony. Dom Augustin Calmet, Benedictine abbot of Senones, collected the reports in his *Dissertations sur les apparitions des anges, des démons et des esprits, et sur les revenans et vampires de Hongrie, de Bohême, de Moravie et de Silésie* (1746; expanded as a *Traité*, 1751), an encyclopedic and faintly bewildered catalogue that neither credited nor dismissed its material and became the principal source of later literary vampirism. Linnaeus, whose *Systema Naturae* (1735) had listed the hydra, the dragon, the phoenix, and the satyr among its "paradoxical animals" in order to expel them from natural history, exemplifies the age's method of cataloguing its monsters to abolish them. Voltaire mocked Calmet as the historiographer of vampires and observed, in his *Questions sur l'Encyclopédie* (1770–1772), that the true bloodsuckers of the age dwelt not in cemeteries but in very agreeable palaces — a jibe that would pass through Marx's capital into Moretti's Count. Rousseau drew the epistemological consequence with greater force in the *Lettre à Christophe de Beaumont* (1763): "S'il y a dans le monde une histoire attestée, c'est celle des vampires. Rien n'y manque: procès-verbaux, certificats de notables, de chirurgiens, de curés, de magistrats. La preuve juridique est des plus complètes. Avec cela, qui est-ce qui croit aux vampires? Serons-nous tous damnés pour n'y avoir pas cru?" The vampire, for Rousseau, is the limit case of testimony: attested by every authority the age recognized, believed by no one who mattered. His argument is the counterpart of Hume's "Of Miracles" (1748), which

holds that no testimony suffices to establish a miracle unless its falsehood would be more miraculous than the fact it attests. In the Enlightenment's own reasoning the vampire belongs with the miracle: it is what testimony cannot prove.

The state completed what philosophy began. In the mid-1750s, after a further case in Silesia, Maria Theresa dispatched her physician Gerard van Swieten, whose report attributed the phenomena to natural decomposition and popular credulity, and issued decrees withdrawing such cases from clerical jurisdiction and forbidding the traditional remedies of exhumation, staking, and burning. The grave passed under the authority of medicine, an episode in the history Foucault would trace in *Naissance de la clinique* (1963), in which the opened corpse becomes the seat of medical truth. Paul Barber's forensic reconstruction (1988) confirmed van Swieten's verdict in detail: bloating, the purge fluid taken for fresh blood, the slippage of the epidermis taken for new skin, the retraction of flesh that makes hair and nails seem to grow, the groan of escaping gas as the stake goes in — all ordinary phenomena of decay. The vampire was a misreading of the corpse. Yet the Enlightenment's victory had an unforeseen consequence. Driven from the grave, the vampire migrated into representation; disenchanted as fact, it was re-enchanted as image. In revolutionary Paris in the early 1790s Paul Philidor projected ghosts for paying audiences, and in 1798 Étienne-Gaspard Robertson opened his *Fantasmagorie*, in which spectres conjured by magic lantern rushed toward the spectators out of smoke. Terry Castle has argued that the eighteenth century, in rationalizing the supernatural, relocated it within the mind, spectralizing consciousness itself (Castle 1995). The century that buried the vampire under forensic reports ended by projecting it onto smoke.

All of this happened while Alucard slept. The game's fiction places the forensic Enlightenment offstage, in the interval between the son's withdrawal and his waking, and its traces survive in the castle only in transfigured form. The most precise is the enemy list, the in-game compendium that records each creature's name, attributes, strengths, and weaknesses only once the player has destroyed it. It is a *Visum et Repertum* of the castle: the monster becomes an object of knowledge at the moment it becomes a corpse, catalogued by its examiner as Flückinger catalogued the dead of Medveđa.

2.3

The Dhampir: Balkan Ethnography and the Hereditary Hunter

◆

The dhampir is the figure in which European folklore conceived the hunter as the monster's child, and its founding logic — that the power to destroy the vampire is inherited from the vampire — is the logic of Alucard. In the revenant beliefs of the central Balkans, recorded most fully among Serbian and Romani communities of Kosovo and Metohija by Tatomir Vukanović (1957–1959) and made available to anglophone scholarship by Jan Perkowski and Paul Barber, the vampire who returns to his widow by night may father children upon her. The child of such a union — called in Serbian *vampirović* or *vampijerović*, and in the usage that has passed into international fiction *dhampir*, a word of uncertain etymology despite a popular derivation from Albanian roots meaning "tooth" and "drink" — possesses a gift no ordinary person has: the ability to see vampires, who are invisible to everyone else, and therefore to destroy them. The dhampir is the vampire's son and the vampire's executioner, hired by the village, for a fee, to rid it of his father's kind. Among the procedures reported in the ethnographic literature is one of extraordinary symbolic economy: the hunter removes his shirt, turns it inside out, and looks through its sleeve as through a lens, whereupon the invisible revenant appears. The dhampir sees by inversion. His second sight requires that the garment he wears be turned against its own grain.

Three consequences follow, and each structures the game. The first is that the dhampir's inheritance is a *pharmakon* in the double sense Derrida recovered from Plato's *Phaedrus*, at once poison and remedy (Derrida 1968): the blood that makes Alucard a danger to humanity is the blood that allows him to enter his father's house and survive it. Curse and weapon are one substance. The second is that the dhampir is a figure of marginality. He serves the community from its edge, as a specialist whose usefulness marks his difference, and the ethnographic record locates many such hunters among Balkan Roma — a people held in slavery in Wallachia and Moldavia until the abolitions of 1855 and 1856 and persecuted across Europe. The

hunter whose gift protects the village is a pariah within it. The series repeats the structure in lore that has the Belmonts driven out by the people they protected, who feared their power, and in Lisa, the healer burned by those she healed. René Girard's account of the scapegoat, the victim whose expulsion restores a community in crisis and who is afterwards sacralized (Girard 1972, 1982), describes the pattern, and the dhampir is the scapegoat become professional: the expelled one who returns to perform the expulsion of others. The third consequence is that the dhampir's vocation is a matter of descent rather than choice. He is not made a hunter; he is born one.

The dhampir belongs to a wider European family of hereditary night-fighters, whose common feature is that the hunter resembles the hunted. In the Friulian trials studied by Carlo Ginzburg (1966), men and women born with the caul — *nati con la camicia*, "born with the shirt" — testified that on the Ember Days their spirits left their bodies to fight witches with stalks of fennel for the fertility of the fields; over decades of interrogation the Inquisition redescribed these *benandanti* as witches, until some of the accused adopted their judges' account of what they were. In Istria and the Slovene lands the *kresnik* and his adversary the *kudlak* were said to be born alike, marked by cauls of different colours, and to fight by night in animal forms; in Hungary the *táltos* fought in the shape of a bull. The motifs converge with uncanny precision. The benandanti are born with a shirt; the dhampir sees through an inverted shirt; the hunter's vision depends on a garment that is either the membrane of his birth or the clothing of his body turned inside out. And the trajectory Ginzburg documents — the night-fighter reclassified as the creature he fought — is the trajectory of Richter Belmont, the hunter who in the interval between prologue and game becomes, to all appearances, lord of the castle he once stormed. Ginzburg's later *Storia notturna* (1989) reconstructed the Eurasian substrate of these beliefs as a nocturnal history; *Symphony of the Night* is, in its own medium, another.

The figure has a Japanese counterpart whose details answer the European material with diagrammatic exactness. According to a legend that reached its classic form in Takeda Izumo's puppet play *Ashiya Dōman Ōuchi Kagami* (1734), Abe no Seimei, the *onmyōji* who protected the Heian court against demons, was the son of a man and a white fox who had taken

the form of a woman named Kuzunoha. When her nature was discovered she left husband and child, writing on a paper screen the most famous parting poem of the Japanese stage:

Koishiku ba / tazune kite miyo / Izumi naru / Shinoda no mori no / urami kuzunoha.

If you long for me, come and see me in the forest of Shinoda in Izumi — the arrowroot leaves turned over. The last line turns on a pun no translation holds: *urami* is both the underside of the arrowroot leaf, which the wind flips to show its pale reverse, and resentment. In a celebrated piece of kabuki stage business, the actor playing Kuzunoha writes part of the poem in reversed characters, *uramoji*, so that it reads correctly from the audience's side of the screen. The hybrid exorcist's non-human parent departs, leaving a text written in reverse whose key word means at once "the other side" and "grudge." The genders are inverted — in Japan the monstrous parent is the mother, in the Balkans the father — but the structure is the same: the child of a human and a non-human becomes humanity's protector against the non-human by virtue of powers inherited from the non-human parent, and that parent's legacy is a word about resentment. Lisa leaves her son an injunction against hatred; Kuzunoha leaves hers a poem in which resentment and the reverse side are one word. Dhampiric reason begins here: to see what is hidden, one must turn over the leaf, or the garment, one was born in.

2.4

The Balladenjahr: Goethe, Coleridge, Novalis, and the New Mythology

◆

Chapter One sketched the constellation of 1797 (§1.6); this section reads its principal stars more closely, beginning with the ballad that stands behind them. Gottfried August Bürger's "Lenore" (1773) tells of a girl whose betrothed has not returned from the Seven Years' War. In her grief she rejects her mother's counsel of patience and declares that there is no mercy in God; at midnight the dead Wilhelm arrives on horseback and carries her through the night to their bridal bed, which is the grave, while the refrain

marks the speed of the ride — "Die Todten reiten schnell" — and a chorus of spirits closes the poem with its moral: "Geduld! Geduld! Wenn's Herz auch bricht! / Mit Gott im Himmel hadre nicht!" Have patience, though the heart break; do not quarrel with God in heaven. Walter Scott's version, *William and Helen* (1796), was his first publication and carried the ballad into English; a century later Stoker's Harker records its refrain, overheard among his fellow passengers on the road to the Borgo Pass (ch. 1). "Lenore" fixes the theological situation of the mourner that *Symphony of the Night* inherits: grief that refuses consolation becomes blasphemy, and blasphemy delivers the mourner to the dead. Dracula is a Lenore who did quarrel with God — the mourner who rejected the counsel of patience and, instead of being carried off by the dead, became their sovereign.

Goethe's "Die Braut von Korinth" supplies the second term: the vampire as the creation of religion. Its source is a tale in the *Peri thaumasiōn* of Phlegon of Tralles (second century CE), in which a dead girl, Philinnion, returns by night to a guest in her parents' house; Goethe, who knew it through Johannes Praetorius's seventeenth-century retelling, transplanted it to Corinth, the city in which Philostratus had set Apollonius of Tyana's unmasking of the lamia betrothed to the young Menippus (*Vita Apollonii* 4.25). In Goethe's version the girl's mother, converted to the new faith, has vowed her to heaven, and the vow has consigned her to the grave; she returns to her pagan bridegroom because the ascetic denial of the body cannot abolish what it denies: "Aus dem Grabe werd' ich ausgetrieben, / Noch zu suchen das vermßte Gut, / Noch den schon verlornen Mann zu lieben / Und zu saugen seines Herzens Blut." From the grave I am driven forth, still to seek the good I was denied, still to love the man already lost, and to suck his heart's blood. The vampire is the return of what the vow repressed. The poem's ending illuminates the game by inversion. The bride asks her mother to build a pyre, so that the lovers may pass through fire to the old gods. In *Symphony of the Night* the woman burned and the vampire made by her burning are two persons, Lisa and Dracula; in Goethe they are one, and the fire the Bride of Corinth requests as release is the fire Lisa suffers as persecution.

Coleridge's year is richer still. The preface to "Kubla Khan" dates its composition to the summer of 1797, and the poem, whose dreamt palace is lost when the poet is interrupted by "a person on business from Porlock,"

ends in a conditional that reads as a prophecy of the game: "Could I revive within me / Her symphony and song, / To such a deep delight 'twould win me, / That with music loud and long, / I would build that dome in air." A revived symphony would build a palace, and then "all should cry, Beware! Beware! / His flashing eyes, his floating hair! / Weave a circle round him thrice, / And close your eyes with holy dread." The poem imagines a demonic beauty with flashing eyes and floating hair whom beholders must ward off with a magic circle; it imagines a revived music that raises an architecture; and it survives only as a fragment, the ruin of a vision. *Symphony of the Night* fulfils the conditional. It revives an older music — Baroque counterpoint, Romantic nocturne — and builds with it a palace in air, inhabited by a prince whose flashing eyes and floating hair Ayami Kojima painted, enclosed like Huizinga's play-space within a magic circle. In November of the same year Coleridge began "The Rime of the Ancient Mariner," whose spectral ship carries two players, Death and "The Nightmare LIFE-IN-DEATH . . . / Who thicks man's blood with cold" (text of 1817), dicing for the crew. Death wins the sailors; Life-in-Death wins the Mariner, condemned to a living death and to the compulsion to confess his tale to strangers. His release comes not through penance but through an unwilled compassion for the loathsome: watching the water-snakes by moonlight, "A spring of love gushed from my heart, / And I blessed them unaware," and the albatross falls from his neck. The poem's moral — "He prayeth best, who loveth best / All things both great and small" — is Lisa's injunction extended across the boundary of kind.

The year also gave Romanticism its religion of music and its theology of night. Wilhelm Heinrich Wackenroder's *Herzensergießungen eines kunstliebenden Klosterbruders*, dated 1797 on its title page, closes with the life of the fictional composer Joseph Berglinger, for whom music is a revelation that consumes its devotee; the doctrine culminated in E. T. A. Hoffmann's review of Beethoven's Fifth Symphony (1810), which declared instrumental music the most Romantic of the arts and credited Beethoven with opening "das Reich des Ungeheuern und Unermeßlichen," the realm of the monstrous and the immeasurable. Hoffmann also wrote the tale later known as "Vampirismus" (1821); the symphony and the vampire share a father. Jean Paul's *Siebenkäs* (1796–97) contained the "Rede des toten Christus vom Weltgebäude herab, daß kein Gott sei," in which the dead rise

in a churchyard to hear Christ announce that there is no God; when the dead children ask whether they have no father, he answers: "Wir sind alle Waisen, ich und ihr, wir sind ohne Vater." The death of God, a century before Nietzsche, takes the form of a universal orphanhood proclaimed among the risen dead. Novalis, whose vision at the grave of Sophie von Kühn dates from May 1797 (§1.6), would address night in the first of the *Hymnen an die Nacht* (1800) as "heilige, unaussprechliche, geheimnisvolle" — holy, ineffable, and, in the literal sense of the German, full of secrets. Hölderlin's *Hyperion*, whose first volume appeared in 1797, would close two years later with a musical theodicy: "Wie der Zwist der Liebenden, sind die Dissonanzen der Welt. Versöhnung ist mitten im Streit und alles Getrennte findet sich wieder. Es scheiden und kehren im Herzen die Adern" — the dissonances of the world are lovers' quarrels; reconciliation lies in the midst of strife; the veins part and return in the heart. Reconciliation is figured as the circulation of blood.

Two documents of the year bear on the game's ethics, and one on its genre. Kant's *Metaphysik der Sitten* (1797) makes the cultivation of sympathetic feeling an indirect duty (*Tugendlehre* §§34–35), and his essay of the same year, "Über ein vermeintes Recht aus Menschenliebe zu lügen," denies that one may lie even to a murderer at the door who asks where one's friend is hiding: the ethics of compassion and the ethics of the secret are posed with maximal rigour in the year of the castle's return (Chapters Four and Five). And Sade published *La Nouvelle Justine*, in which a libertine aristocracy subjects virtue to systematic cruelty in secluded castles; in his "Idée sur les romans" (1800) he would identify the Gothic novel as the indispensable fruit of the revolutionary upheavals that all Europe had felt.

The "Oldest System-Programme" had demanded a new mythology (§1.6), and Friedrich Schlegel's "Rede über die Mythologie" (1800) stated the lack precisely: modern poetry, he argued, has no centre such as mythology was for the ancients, though it stands close to acquiring one. Read together, the texts of 1797 compose in fragments the score such a mythology would require, and which *Symphony of the Night* performs whole: grief that quarrels with God, the vampire as the return of what religion represses, the threshold and the dead mother's guardian spirit, the revived symphony that builds a palace, compassion for monsters as release from undeath, music as revelation of the monstrous, the orphaned dead, a

night full of secrets, reconciliation as resolved dissonance, the morality of the secret, and the Gothic as the fruit of revolution. The castle that returns in 1797 is the return of these fragments as a single building.

2.5

From Diodati to Whitby: Polidori, Varney, Le Fanu, Stoker

◆

The literary vampire of the nineteenth century was born from a contest and a secret. In June 1816, the "year without a summer" that followed the eruption of Tambora, Byron proposed to his company at the Villa Diodati that each write a ghost story. Mary Godwin began *Frankenstein*; Byron sketched and abandoned a fragment about a mysterious traveller who dies at a Turkish burial ground after binding his companion to silence; and Byron's physician, John William Polidori, developed the fragment into "The Vampyre," published in the *New Monthly Magazine* in April 1819 under Byron's name. Its Lord Ruthven takes his name from the Byronic seducer of Lady Caroline Lamb's *Glenarvon* (1816) and his manner from Byron himself: the aristocratic vampire begins as the portrait of a poet. Less remarked is that the tale turns on an oath of secrecy. Dying, as it seems, Ruthven makes young Aubrey swear to conceal what he knows for a year and a day; restored to life by moonlight, he returns to London and courts Aubrey's sister, while Aubrey, bound by his oath, is driven mad by a truth he may not speak. When the term expires it is too late, and the tale ends with the news that "Aubrey's sister had glutted the thirst of a VAMPYRE!" The first modern vampire story in English is a tragedy of the kept secret. Malraux's pile of secrets, which Dracula despises as contemptible, appears here as lethal.

Byron had already placed the vampire within the family. In *The Giaour* (1813) the curse upon the infidel condemns him to return from the grave and "suck the blood of all thy race; / There from thy daughter, sister, wife, / At midnight drain the stream of life," while his victims "Shall know the demon for their sire." The culminating torment is recognition: "But one that for thy crime must fall, / The youngest, most beloved of all, / Shall

bless thee with a father's name — / That word shall wrap thy heart in flame!" The vampire father consumed by the word his child speaks is the scene that *Symphony of the Night* stages and inverts at its close, where the dying father hears from his son not his own name but the last words of the woman he lost, and where those words, rather than wrapping his heart in flame, bring it to rest. The father's Heart is among the relics the son must first recover.

Polidori's tale reached the stage within a year — Charles Nodier's melodrama *Le Vampire* (Paris, 1820) and James Robinson Planché's adaptation (London, 1820), which introduced the "vampire trap" through which the revenant vanished and reappeared — and the opera house within a decade, in Heinrich Marschner's *Der Vampyr* (1828). The penny-dreadful *Varney the Vampire* (1845–1847), usually attributed to James Malcolm Rymer, added two features that matter for Alucard. Sir Francis Varney is the first sustained portrait of the self-loathing vampire, who regards his condition with horror and finally ends it by casting himself into the crater of Vesuvius. And *Varney*, sprawling across more than two hundred serial chapters, showed that the vampire was ideally suited to a form in which no ending is final and every death prepares a return.

Sheridan Le Fanu's "Carmilla" (1871–1872; collected in *In a Glass Darkly*, 1872) gives the vampire an onomastic law. Mircalla, Countess Karnstein, reappears across the centuries as Millarca and as Carmilla, each name an anagram of the others, as though she were bound to keep her letters while disguising their order. Alucard is the limit case of the Carmillan anagram: the rearrangement that is pure reversal. Le Fanu also binds hunter to hunted by love and secrecy. The scholar who finally locates Carmilla's tomb, Baron Vordenburg, owes his knowledge to an ancestor who had been her lover and who concealed her resting place after her death; the hunter's art descends from the vampire's beloved, and his first act of knowledge undoes a family secret. A portrait of Mircalla dated 1698, recognized as Carmilla's likeness, makes painting the instrument of anagnorisis; and the collection's title, from 1 Corinthians 13:12 — "For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face" — names the eschatological optics that the Holy Glasses will make literal (Chapter Four).

Stoker's *Dracula* (1897) gathered these lines into the form the twentieth century would inherit. His notes draw on Wilkinson for the name, on

Sabine Baring-Gould's *Book of Were-Wolves* (1865), and on Emily Gerard's essay "Transylvanian Superstitions" (1885) and her travel book *The Land Beyond the Forest* (1888), whose title translates the name Transylvania; the game opens, fittingly, with its hero running through a moonlit forest toward the castle. The Count bequeathed to the series Alucard's repertoire of transformations: Van Helsing explains that the vampire can become wolf or bat and can "come in mist which he create" (ch. 18), and the three forms the dhampir recovers in the castle are the Count's forms, a documented filiation. Stoker supplied, besides, the threshold rule that titles this chapter, the doctrine that "the blood is the life" (ch. 11, after Deuteronomy 12:23), the crucifix, the consecrated Host with which Van Helsing seals Lucy's tomb, and the line that the English title of the game seems to answer. Hearing the wolves on Harker's first night, the Count turns to him: "Listen to them — the children of the night. What music they make!" (ch. 2). A symphony of the night is what the Count hears in the howling of his creatures.

The novel's form carries its argument. *Dracula* is a dossier — shorthand journals, letters, cuttings, a ship's log, phonograph diaries — which Mina Harker transcribes on her typewriter and arranges in order so that the hunters can read the whole and act on it. Friedrich Kittler read the novel as a war between the vampire and the media technologies of its age (Kittler 1982); its deeper inversion is that the Count is defeated when the human community converts its private secrets into a shared archive. The vampire thrives on the isolation of individuals — the sleeping victim, the silenced Aubrey — and is overcome when the pile of secrets becomes a collation: the novel's anthropology is the reverse of Dracula's in the prologue. One thread more. Stoker entered Henry Irving's service after reviewing Irving's Hamlet in Dublin and meeting the actor in 1876, and he managed Irving's Lyceum Theatre for nearly three decades. The author of *Dracula* came to his life's work through *Hamlet*, as the game's prologue leaves its disputation through Laertes' challenge.

2.6

The Cinematic Count: Murnau, Browning, Dreyer, Fisher, Herzog, Coppola

◆

Cinema made the vampire a creature of the dark auditorium, and its decisive works supplied the game with a title, an iconography, and a narrative of grief. The title comes first from Murnau. *Nosferatu, eine Symphonie des Grauens* (1922) — a symphony of horror — is the first great vampire film and the first to call itself a symphony; the game's English name stands between Murnau's subtitle and the Count's line about the music of the children of the night. Murnau's unauthorized adaptation renames the Count Orlok, borrows its title from a word Emily Gerard had reported as Romanian for the vampire, and makes its monster a bearer of plague who arrives with rats in a ship's hold. Its resolution belongs to a woman. Ellen, having read that only a woman pure in heart who freely gives her blood can hold the monster past cockcrow, keeps Orlok at her side until the sunlight destroys him, and dies. The vampire is undone not by a hunter but by a woman's self-offering, consummated at dawn, the hour at which *Symphony of the Night* also ends. The film's history repeats its theme: Stoker's widow sued, a German court ordered the prints destroyed in 1925, and copies survived abroad. *Nosferatu* is a revenant print, a work condemned to death that would not stay dead.

The iconography comes from Universal. Tod Browning's *Dracula* (1931) gave Bela Lugosi's Count the evening dress, the high-collared opera cape, the slow cadence, and the hypnotic stare that every subsequent Count, the series' included, has worn or parodied. Its production history supplies an image of inversion as exact as any in this dissertation: a Spanish-language version, directed by George Melford with Carlos Villarías as the Count, was shot at night on the same sets after the English-language company had left for the day. The vampire film had a nocturnal twin — the same story performed in the same rooms by another cast in the hours of darkness. Lugosi's identification with the role became total; he was buried, in 1956, in one of his Dracula capes, an actor possessed by the figure he played.

Universal's sequels then produced, within a decade, a striking sequence of vampire children and of vampires seeking release. In *Dracula's Daughter* (1936) Countess Marya Zaleska burns her father's body in the hope of freeing herself from his inheritance and turns to a psychiatrist for a cure; in *Son of Dracula* (1943) the Count calls himself Alucard; in *House of Dracula* (1945) the vampire himself seeks medical deliverance. The vampire who wishes to be other than his blood is a Universal invention. Carl Theodor Dreyer's *Vampyr* (1932), loosely drawn from Le Fanu, contributes one image of decisive importance: its protagonist dreams his own burial, and the camera shows it from his point of view, looking up through a small window in the coffin lid as he is carried through the village. The coffin becomes a viewpoint and the dead man a spectator — the position *Symphony of the Night* will assign to its player (Chapter Seven).

Hammer Film Productions gave the vampire colour and repetition. Terence Fisher's *Dracula* (1958), with Christopher Lee and Peter Cushing, ends with Van Helsing tearing down the curtains to admit the sun and improvising a cross from two candlesticks; the series' candles, which yield crosses among their hidden contents, preserve the gesture, consciously or not. *The Brides of Dracula* (1960) offers an inverted Alucard in Baron Meinster, a young aristocratic vampire kept chained in his château by a mother who procures his victims; freed, he destroys her, and Van Helsing kills him by turning the sails of a windmill so that their shadow falls on him as a cross. *Dracula: Prince of Darkness* (1966) and its successors open, again and again, with a ritual resurrection that undoes the previous film's ending. Hammer thereby discovered that the vampire is the ideal subject of seriality — the aesthetics of repetition Umberto Eco would later analyse (Eco 1985) — since a creature that cannot stay dead licenses an infinite series. The *Castlevania* doctrine of the castle's centennial return is the diegetic rationalization of this commercial law.

The late cinema of the vampire made the Count an object of pity and grief. Werner Herzog's *Nosferatu: Phantom der Nacht* (1979) gives Klaus Kinski's Count a weary melancholy: he speaks of an existence without end and without love as a torment worse than death. Its ending inverts the genre. After Lucy's sacrifice destroys the Count, Van Helsing is arrested for his murder, and Jonathan Harker, infected, rides away as the new vampire; the hunter becomes the hunted, and the cycle continues — the fate of

Richter Belmont and the logic of the castle's returns. Francis Ford Coppola's *Bram Stoker's Dracula* (1992) supplied the narrative of grief that the game would adapt. Its prologue, set in 1462, shows Dracula's wife Elisabeta, falsely told of his death in battle, throwing herself from the castle into the river; when the priests declare her soul damned as a suicide, Dracula renounces God, drives his sword into the altar cross, which bleeds, and drinks the blood. A sovereign's war on God and humankind is grounded in the death of a beloved woman and in the Church's refusal of mercy to her — the template of the game's backstory, in which Lisa dies as a condemned witch and Dracula turns on humanity. Elisabeta and Lisa bear the long and short forms of a single name, from the Hebrew *Elisheba*, "my God is an oath." The film ends with Mina releasing the Count from his curse and his restored youth ascending with Elisabeta in a painted vault: love, not the hunt, redeems the vampire. Its costumes, by the Japanese designer Eiko Ishioka, won the Academy Award in 1993 and brought to the Gothic an Asian modernist eye — a crimson robe with a vast train, white hair coiled in an elaborate double knot, armour modelled on flayed musculature. Four years before *Symphony of the Night*, the most celebrated visualization of Dracula in decades was already a Japanese reading of the Gothic.

Anne Rice's novels, and Neil Jordan's film of *Interview with the Vampire* (1994), contributed the last two figures of this lineage: Louis, the vampire who confesses his life to a human interviewer's tape recorder and loathes his own nature, and Lestat, who in *The Vampire Lestat* (1985) becomes a rock star. The first returns the vampire to Rousseau's confessional; the second leads directly to the aristocratic gothic of Japanese *visual kei* (Chapter Three).

2.7

The Japanese Vampire: Hagio, Kikuchi and Amano, Araki, Hirano

◆

The Japanese vampire is a translation that became a tradition, and the game's makers inherited it as surely as they inherited Stoker. The standard

Japanese term, *kyūketsuki*, renders "vampire" as a blood-sucking *ki* — the character for the *oni*, the demon, which also names the spirits of the dead — so that the Western revenant entered Japanese as a species of demon-ghost. It found native kin. The tale of the Peony Lantern, which passed from Qu You's Chinese collection *Jiandeng xinhua* (c. 1378) into Asai Ryōi's *Otogi Bōko* (1666), thence into San'yūtei Enchō's rakugo *Kaidan Botan Dōrō* (published 1884), and which Lafcadio Hearn retold in English (1899), concerns a dead woman, Otsuyu, who visits her lover nightly until his life is drained; Buddhist charms pasted over the doors keep her out, until a servant, bribed, removes them, and the young man is found dead in the embrace of a skeleton. It is the Japanese counterpart of the Bride of Corinth and of Geraldine: a revenant bride, a threshold she cannot cross unaided, and a human being who opens it for gain. Modern Japanese fiction first took up the word in the detective mode — Edogawa Ranpo's *Kyūketsuki* (1930–1931) makes the vampire a puzzle for the rationalist Akechi Kogorō, repeating in Tokyo the forensic origin of the European vampire — and postwar cinema imported Hammer's Count wholesale in Michio Yamamoto's trilogy for Toho (1970–1974).

The manga of the 1960s anticipated the game's most peculiar structure, the gathering of a dispersed body. In Osamu Tezuka's *Dororo* (1967–1968), the warlord Daigo Kagemitsu trades forty-eight parts of his newborn son's body to forty-eight demons in exchange for power, and the son, Hyakkimaru, recovers himself part by part as he kills the demons who hold them, until he confronts the father who sold him. In Shigeru Mizuki's *Hakaba Kitarō* (from 1960; later *GeGeGe no Kitarō*), Kitarō, last of a ghost tribe, is born in a grave from his mother's corpse, while his father, his body rotted away, survives as a single animated eyeball, Medama-oyaji, who rides with his son and counsels him. The yōkai boy who protects human beings from other yōkai is a mediator between worlds, and the fourth television series of his adventures was on the air throughout the game's development and release (1996–1998). A son recovers his body from the demons to whom his father sold it; a father survives as an eye beside his son. In *Symphony of the Night* the son recovers his own powers and his father's scattered body — the Eye of Vlad among its relics — in a single itinerary.

The *shōjo* manga of the 1970s supplied the aesthetic. Moto Hagio's *Pō no Ichizoku* (*The Poe Clan*, 1972–1976), among the founding works of the

women artists who transformed girls' comics in that decade, follows Edgar and Allan, eternal adolescents of a vampire clan, through two centuries of European history — melancholy, beautiful, androgynous, more mournful than predatory. Riyoko Ikeda's *Berusaiyu no Bara* (1972–1973), staged with enormous success by the all-female Takarazuka Revue from 1974, had already made revolutionary France, the period of the game's prologue, a Japanese theatre of aristocratic tragedy and androgynous heroism. The dhampir received his definitive Japanese form in Hideyuki Kikuchi's *Vampire Hunter D* (from 1983), illustrated by Yoshitaka Amano and animated in 1985. D is the son of the vampire lord called the Sacred Ancestor; he hunts vampires for pay across a far-future Earth, beautiful to the point of menace, despised by humans and vampires alike, and accompanied by a sardonic parasitic face in the palm of his left hand — an Other lodged within the hybrid body. Amano's ornamental, Art Nouveau–inflected line made the dhampir a figure of elegance as well as terror. D is the closest antecedent of Kojima's Alucard.

Works contemporary with the game develop the hybrid's ethics. In the first part of Hirohiko Araki's *JoJo no Kimyō na Bōken* (from 1987), Dio Brando, who has poisoned his own father, renounces his humanity by means of an ancient stone mask and becomes a vampire; his adoptive brother Jonathan Joestar fights him with a breathing art that channels the energy of sunlight, and the feud passes down the generations until, in a later part, Dio's head is joined to Jonathan's body — the enemy wearing the hero's flesh. Dio is Alucard's exact inverse: born human, he chooses monstrosity out of contempt for human weakness; Alucard, born half-monster, chooses his mother's ethic. Rumiko Takahashi's *Inuyasha*, serialized from November 1996, gives its half-demon hero, son of a great dog-demon and a human woman, a sword forged from his father's fang, which restrains the son's demonic blood and lets him protect human beings, while his full-demon half-brother despises humans as their father did not; the father's tooth remade as the son's instrument has its counterpart in the Tooth of Vlad. Kouta Hirano's *Hellsing*, begun in 1997, completes the picture: its Alucard, Dracula himself bound to the service of a Protestant order, insists that a monster must be destroyed by a human being who has remained human, and reserves his contempt for those who abandon their humanity. Across these works the Japanese vampire acquires four features

that the game inherits together — aestheticization, hybridity, the quest for the dispersed body, and an argument about what makes a human being human.

2.8
The Belmont Counter-Lineage, 1986–1993

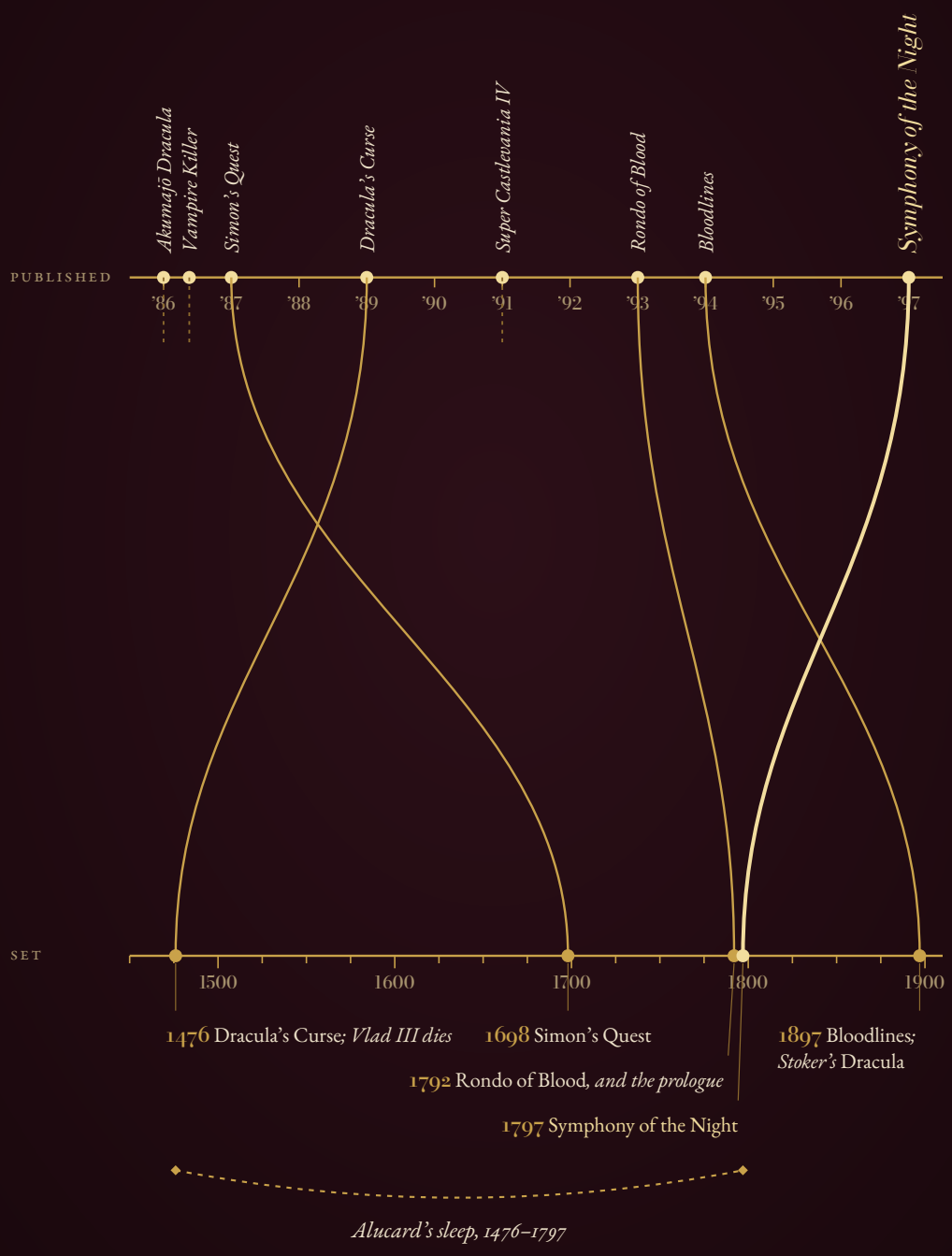
◆

The series that *Symphony of the Night* inverts was from its first installment a self-conscious descendant of the cinematic Gothic, and its human heroes form a counter-lineage to the vampire's. *Akumajō Dracula* (Famicom Disk System, 1986; *Castlevania* in North America, 1987), directed by Hitoshi Akamatsu, sent the whip-wielding Simon Belmont through a castle populated by the monster rally of Universal and Hammer — giant bat, Medusa, mummies, Frankenstein's creature with a hunchbacked attendant, Death, the Count — and the closing credits of its North American release listed cast and staff under punning aliases drawn from horror cinema, among them "Vram Stoker," "Christopher Bee," and "Belo Lugosi." The game imagined itself as a film and its creatures as a cast. Its Japanese title names the building, *Akumajō*, the demon castle, and joins it to the Count's name — an identification of sovereign and house that the later games would make literal.

The second installment invented the device on which the climax of *Symphony of the Night* depends. In *Dracula II: Noroi no Fūin* (1987; *Castlevania II: Simon's Quest*), set in 1698, Simon, cursed after his victory, must recover the Count's scattered remains — Rib, Heart, Eye, Nail, and Ring — in order to revive and destroy him for good; the parts serve as instruments, the Rib as a shield, the Nail for breaking through walls, the Eye for disclosing what is hidden. The game's open world, its cycle of day and night, its several endings, and its notoriously cryptic or lying townspeople, whose testimony the player cannot trust, made it a game about the unreliability of testimony concerning vampires — Rousseau's argument rendered as play. *Symphony of the Night* recapitulates the quest and inverts it: the relics of Vlad are again Heart, Rib, Eye, and Ring, now joined by a Tooth, but they are gathered by

Figure 7

Release and Story



The Belmont series on two time-lines (§2.8): above, the year each game was published; below, the year in which its story is set, where the text gives one. The series advances by reaching backward, and between its first and last settings lies Alucard's sleep, from 1476 to the castle's untimely return.

the vampire's son rather than his hunter, and their gathering prepares not a resurrection but a reconciliation.

Akumajō Densetsu (1989; *Castlevania III: Dracula's Curse*), set in 1476, gave the series its branching routes, its ensemble of allies, and Alucard, who first appears as an adversary testing the hunter's worth before joining him. Series lore holds that the Belmonts had been driven from Wallachia by people who feared their power, and that the line continues through Trevor's union with the sorceress Sypha Belnades — a hunter's house founded in part by a woman of the kind the people burned. *Super Castlevania IV* (1991) made spectacle of the castle through the Super Famicom's Mode 7 hardware, including a chamber that rotates around the hero as he clings to it: a revolving castle six years before the Inverted Castle made rotation structural. *Akumajō Dracula X: Chi no Rondo* (1993) set its story in 1792 and named its hero Richter, German for "judge"; it introduced the dark priest Shaft, whose rite raises the Count, and Maria Renard, the girl Richter rescues and who will, in 1797, search for him; and it laced its stages with hidden routes and alternative exits for the player who searched. Its final duel is the scene the later game restages as its prologue, so that a judge presides over the disputation of the threshold, and the corruption of that judge by possession becomes the hidden premise of all that follows. *Castlevania: Bloodlines* (1994), finally, made explicit what the centennial constellation of Chapter One implied: its hero, John Morris, is the son of Quincey Morris, the Texan of Stoker's novel, so that the events of *Dracula* occupy 1897 in the series' chronology as one of the Count's returns.

The Belmont line is thus constituted as a counter-lineage, and the two lines transmit their inheritances in different modes. The vampire transmits a substance, blood; the hunters transmit an artifact, the whip called the Vampire Killer. The human line is defined by what it holds, the vampire's by what it is. Yet the Belmonts are as bound to the cycle as their enemy: their identity depends on his return, and their inheritance is, in Abraham and Torok's sense, a phantom — a task bequeathed by the dead and repeated by each generation without hope of completion (§1.4). *Symphony of the Night* suspends this line. Its Belmont is absent, possessed, and rescued by another; its Maria seeks the lost hunter rather than leading the hunt; and its hero belongs to the vampire's line turned against itself. The game is the series' retrograde: the hunter's story told from the side of the hunted.

Here the genealogies converge, and the prologue's aetiology can be read at the level of production. When the vampire insists that he did not raise himself but was summoned by human beings wishing to pay him tribute, he describes exactly the condition of a serial character: each game resurrects him because players desire his return, and the tribute is the price of the game. At every stage traced in this chapter — pamphlet, forensic report, ballad, novel, film, manga, game — the vampire has been called forth by a human medium and a human desire. He enters freely, but only because he has been invited. Chapter Three turns from what the game inherits to how it renders it: from genealogy to aesthetics.



III

Gekka no Yasōkyoku

月下の夜想曲

Chapter Three

"Gekka no Yasōkyoku"

Kojima, Yamane, and the Decadent Sublime of a Revenant Medium

The sensuous form of *Symphony of the Night* is not ornament laid over its argument but the argument's first appearance: before the player has learned anything of the castle's secrets, image, sound, and medium have already taught how its world is to be felt. This chapter names that teaching a **decadent sublime** — the sublime of terror, obscurity, and magnitude that Burke and Kant theorized and Piranesi drew, refracted through an aesthetics of beauty that knows itself doomed, which the European Decadence and the Japanese traditions of *tanbi*, *mono no aware*, and *mujō* articulated in different keys — and argues that the game renders it in a medium that was itself passing into obsolescence. The Japanese subtitle supplies the chapter's emblem. *Gekka no Yasōkyoku* is a nocturne beneath the moon: *yasōkyoku*, literally a "night-reverie piece," is the standard Japanese rendering of the European nocturne, and *gekka*, "under the moon," names the only light the work admits. Moonlight is sunlight inverted into night, a light that reaches the dark only by reflection. It is the light of a creature who cannot face the sun but must see the world the sun illuminates: the light of the dhampir. The seven sections that follow read the painted face, the subculture that framed it, the music, the sublime of the castle, the praise of shadow, the obsolescent medium, and the impermanence under whose sign the whole is felt.

3.1

The Painted Prince: Ayami Kojima and the Aesthetics of Androgyny

THE FACE of Alucard is a painting before it is a sprite, and the game's double rendering of its hero — a portrait in dialogue, a pixel body in play — is the first aesthetic expression of the dhampir's two natures. Ayami Kojima, the illustrator Konami engaged for the project, worked not in the line-and-cel idiom of contemporary anime, with its clear contours and flat fields of colour, but in a painterly manner in which figures emerge from dark grounds through modulated tone, and her designs would define the series' visual identity for much of the following decade. In the game her art appears in two registers. Her character illustrations served as the models for the portraits that appear beside the game's dialogue, next to which the speakers' sprites stand and gesture; the player meets every principal figure twice, as an icon and as an actor. Ernst Kantorowicz's account of medieval political theology, *The King's Two Bodies* (1957), distinguished the king's body natural, mortal and fallible, from his body politic, which does not die. Alucard possesses an analogous duality. His painted body is timeless, fixed, and contemplated; his sprite body runs, leaps, bleeds, dies, and is restored. The one is the dhampir as image, the other the dhampir as action, and the game requires both.

Kojima's Alucard is a figure of conspicuous androgyny. The long pale hair falling past his shoulders, the narrow face with its fine features and lowered eyes, the slender body hidden in a high-collared cloak over an aristocratic coat, the stance at once languid and alert: every element withholds the signs by which the period's game heroes declared their masculinity — the broad shoulders, the square jaw, the musculature that the box art of Konami's own earlier Belmonts had displayed. The androgyny is not decoration. It is the visual translation of the dhampir's ontological condition. A being that is neither wholly human nor wholly vampire is rendered as a being that is neither wholly masculine nor wholly feminine; the betweenness of kind is given to sight as the betweenness of sex. Where a novelist would have to state Alucard's hybridity, the painter

shows it, and shows it in the register in which European and Japanese visual culture had long figured the reconciliation of opposites.

That register has a long Western history. In Aristophanes' speech in Plato's *Symposium* (189c–193d), the first human beings were double, and among them was the *androgynos*, at once male and female, whom Zeus cut in half; love is the longing of each half for the other. The alchemical tradition made the hermaphrodite, the *Rebis* or "double thing," the product of the union of Sol and Luna, as the woodcuts of the *Rosarium philosophorum* (1550) depict it — a figure to which Chapter Four will return when it reads the game's gold and silver rings. Romanticism adopted the androgyne as the image of a healed humanity. In the "Dithyrambic Fantasy on the Loveliest Situation" of Friedrich Schlegel's *Lucinde* (1799), the lovers exchange roles; Balzac's *Séraphîta* (1834–1835) gives Swedenborg's angel a body that each lover perceives as the opposite sex; and Théophile Gautier's *Mademoiselle de Maupin* (1835), whose preface declared that "Il n'y a de vraiment beau que ce qui ne peut servir à rien," joined a cross-dressed heroine to the doctrine of art for art's sake. The Victorian and fin-de-siècle aesthetes made the androgyne a cult: Swinburne's "Hermaphroditus" (1866), written before the sleeping hermaphrodite of the Louvre; the epicene youths of Edward Burne-Jones and Simeon Solomon; the sphinxes and twins of Fernand Khnopff; Joséphin Péladan's novel *L'Androgyne* (1891) and his Salons de la Rose+Croix (1892–1897), which proclaimed the androgyne the supreme subject of art. Kojima's painted prince is, whether by design or by the logic of the tradition, its late heir.

The Japanese genealogy is as deep and arrives by another route. The prints of Suzuki Harunobu (1725–1770) render young men and women with faces and bodies so alike that sex is legible chiefly through dress, and the *wakashu*, the adolescent youth of Edo culture, was an object of aesthetic and erotic attention in his own right. The Japanese stage cultivated androgyny in two mirror-image forms: the *onnagata* of kabuki, men who play women, whose art the actor Yoshizawa Ayame (1673–1729) codified as a discipline of living as a woman offstage as well as on; and the *otokoyaku* of the Takarazuka Revue (first performance 1914), women who play men, whose stylized gallantry would carry *The Rose of Versailles* to its triumph in 1974 (§2.7). Japan thus possesses a canon of gender in two voices, one the inversion of the other. The *bishōnen*, the beautiful youth of postwar *shōjo*

manga, descends from both, and from the European aesthete as well; it is the figure through which Hagio's Edgar and Kikuchi's D were imagined, and through which Kojima's Alucard is seen.

Mircea Eliade's *Méphistophélès et l'Androgyne* (1962) supplies the concept that unites these genealogies and binds them to the game. Eliade read the devil and the androgyne as the two great mythic figures of the *coincidentia oppositorum*: the one a negativity that turns out to serve the whole, the other a primordial unity in which opposites are reconciled. Goethe had given the first its canonical formula when his Mephistopheles described himself as "Ein Teil von jener Kraft, / Die stets das Böse will und stets das Gute schafft" (*Faust I*, 1335–1336) — part of that power which always wills evil and always works good. *Symphony of the Night* sets these two figures in the relation of father and son. Dracula is the Mephistophelian sovereign, whose war on humanity will, against its intention, produce the occasion of his son's mercy and his own recognition; Alucard is the androgyne, the being in whom divided natures are held together without being dissolved. The painted face of the son is the game's first image of reconciliation, offered before a word of its argument has been spoken.

3.2

Tanbi, *Shōjo*, and *Visual Kei*

◆

The Japanese gothic in which *Symphony of the Night* participates was an aestheticism of the imaginary aristocrat, and its genealogy runs from the literary aesthetes of the late Meiji and Taishō periods to the costumed rock of the 1990s. Its first term, *tanbi*, "absorption in beauty," was the Japanese rendering of European Aestheticism, and it named a literary current — the *tanbi-ha* of Nagai Kafū and Tanizaki Jun'ichirō — that took Baudelaire, Poe, and Wilde as its masters. Tanizaki's first celebrated story, "Shisei" ("The Tattooer," 1910), contains a sentence that might serve as the motto of Dracula's anthropology: "Subete utsukushii mono wa kyōsha de ari, minikui mono wa jakusha de atta" — all who were beautiful were strong, and all who were ugly were weak. The aesthete's equation of beauty with power, and of its absence with contemptible weakness, is the creed of a

vampire who regards humanity as a miserable pile of secrets. Wilde's *Salome* reached the Tokyo stage in 1913, and Aubrey Beardsley's illustrations for it, themselves deeply indebted to the Japanese prints that had reached London, returned to Japan to shape a generation of illustrators. The circulation of the aesthetic image between Europe and Japan was contrapuntal from the start: a subject passed from one voice to the other and back, altered at each passage.

The Gothic, moreover, was a genre of secondary origins from its inception, a fact that disposes of any suspicion that a Japanese Gothic must be derivative. Horace Walpole presented *The Castle of Otranto* (1764) in its first edition as a translation, by one "William Marshal, Gent.," of an Italian work printed at Naples in black letter in 1529; James Macpherson's Ossianic poems (1760–1763) passed off modern composition as ancient Gaelic epic; Thomas Chatterton forged the medieval verse of an imaginary monk, Thomas Rowley; and Walpole's house at Strawberry Hill was Gothic in lath and plaster. The Gothic revival was a mode of fabricating a past one had never possessed. A Gothic imagined in Tokyo is therefore faithful to the genre's founding gesture rather than a departure from it. Postwar Japan received the European dark aesthetic through further mediators. Mishima Yukio's *Kamen no Kokuhaku* (*Confessions of a Mask*, 1949) places its narrator's awakening before Guido Reni's *Saint Sebastian*, the beautiful martyred youth. Shibusawa Tatsuhiko translated Sade, was tried for obscenity over his version of *Juliette* in a case that ran through the 1960s, and in essays such as *Kuro Mahō Techō* (*Black Magic Notebook*, 1961) and *Sekai Akujo Monogatari* (1964), whose gallery of wicked women includes Elizabeth Báthory, made European demonology, alchemy, and decadence a resource of Japanese counter-culture.

The *shōjo* manga of the 1970s and 1980s converted this inheritance into a popular visual language. The women artists of the generation of Moto Hagio and Keiko Takemiya set their stories in European boarding schools, salons, and châteaux, among *bishōnen* whose flowing hair and enormous eyes registered interior states that the pages' flowers, lace, and screen-toned backgrounds amplified. By the early 1990s the idiom had acquired an explicitly Gothic branch: Kaori Yuki's *Count Cain* series (from 1991) follows a young Victorian earl, collector of poisons, heir of a cursed lineage and of a father who had tormented him, through a London of secret societies and

family crimes. The enmity of father and son at the centre of *Symphony of the Night* was a *shōjo* theme before it was a Konami one.

In music the same sensibility became *visual kei*, the movement whose name derives from the slogan of the band X, later X Japan: "Psychedelic Violence Crime of Visual Shock." X's major-label debut album was titled *Blue Blood* (1989), and its leader, Yoshiki, fused speed metal with classically trained piano, so that the band's aristocratic costume was matched by a musical claim on the European concert tradition. In September 1997, six months after *Symphony of the Night* appeared in Japan, X Japan announced its dissolution; its final concert took place at the Tokyo Dome on 31 December 1997. The movement's most self-consciously Baroque band, Malice Mizer, formed in 1992 around the guitarist Mana, dressed its members as French courtiers and gothic revenants, and in 1998 released a single whose title is identical to the game's Japanese subtitle: *Gekka no Yasōkyoku*. No documentary connection between the single and the game is known, and the coincidence may testify to nothing more than a shared vocabulary; but that is precisely the point. "Nocturne beneath the moon" had become, by 1997–1998, a phrase that the Japanese gothic could produce in two media at once. In 1999 Mana gave the fashion that grew around the movement its names, "Elegant Gothic Lolita" and "Elegant Gothic Aristocrat," and founded a label, Moi-même-Moitié, to clothe it.

The sociology of this aesthetic illuminates the game's aristocrats. Japan abolished its peerage, the *kazoku*, in 1947, when the postwar constitution declared that peers and peerage would no longer be recognized. In a society that had legislated aristocracy out of existence, the European count returned as costume and fantasy: an aristocracy of the imagination, open to anyone who could dress for it, and marking, in Pierre Bourdieu's terms, a distinction of taste rather than of birth (Bourdieu 1979). The vampire is the ideal figure of this imaginary nobility, because he is a lord who survives the abolition of lords — an aristocrat out of time. Anne Rice's Lestat had already become a rock star (§2.6); *visual kei* made the vampire's aristocracy a performable identity. *Symphony of the Night* stands at the centre of this moment, neither its cause nor its consequence but a parallel expression of it: its painted aristocrats, its fusion of Baroque timbres with the propulsion of rock, and its melancholy of the beautiful belong to the same sensorium that dressed a generation of Tokyo youth in lace and black.

3.3

Partita, Toccata, Requiem: Michiru Yamane's Baroque Revenants

◆

The score of *Symphony of the Night* is an imaginary museum of European music, and its titles name the forms whose revival the game performs. Michiru Yamane, a Konami staff composer who had already scored *Castlevania: Bloodlines* (1994), wrote for the game a body of music of unusual stylistic range: Baroque counterpoint in harpsichord and organ timbres, chorale-like passages for synthesized voices, Romantic piano writing, driving gothic rock, jazz-inflected harmony, electronic dance rhythms, ambient textures, and, in the North American release, an English pop ballad over the closing credits, "I Am the Wind." Commentators have long remarked the eclecticism; it is better understood as a programme. The score does in sound what the castle does in architecture and Kojima does in costume: it assembles, from reproductions, an anthology of European idioms detached from their historical contexts and juxtaposed in a single space — Malraux's *musée imaginaire* (§1.2) transposed into music.

The titles of the tracks turn the anthology into a lexicon of forms. The Long Library resounds with "Wood Carving Partita" and the Clock Tower with "The Tragic Prince"; elsewhere the score offers a "Requiem for the Gods," a "Final Toccata," a "Nocturne," and a sequence of festive titles — "Festival of Servants," the boss theme, "Dance of Gold," "Black Banquet" — that recall the stylized court dances of the Baroque suite. The suite is the governing analogy. In music a suite is a sequence of dances in related keys; in architecture a suite is a sequence of rooms opening one into the next, the enfilade of Baroque palaces whose aligned doorways create a vista through the whole. The castle is a suite in both senses, a sequence of chambers each with its own dance. The etymologies of the forms, moreover, read like a theory of the game. *Partita*, in Italian, names both the Baroque set of variations or dances and a game or match — *una partita a scacchi*, a game of chess — so that the Long Library's partita is, in the language that gave the form its name, literally a game. *Toccata*, from *toccare*, "to touch," is the touch-piece, the virtuoso display in which a keyboard

player tests an instrument under the fingers; a videogame is played by touch, and every traversal of the castle is a toccata of the player's hands. *Symphonia* is "sounding together"; the nocturne is the piece of night; the requiem is the rest the dead are asked to receive.

The requiem's text bears directly on the undead. The Introit of the Mass for the Dead asks: "Requiem aeternam dona eis, Domine, et lux perpetua luceat eis" — eternal rest grant unto them, O Lord, and let perpetual light shine upon them. Rest and light are precisely what the vampire is denied: he cannot sleep in his grave and cannot bear the sun. A requiem sounded in Dracula's castle is therefore a prayer for what its master cannot have, and a "requiem for the gods" is a mourning for divinities who have died — the Romantic theme of Jean Paul's dead Christ (§2.4) set as liturgy. The genre carries its own legend of a count in mourning. Mozart's Requiem (1791), left unfinished at his death and completed by his pupil Franz Xaver Süssmayr, was commissioned anonymously, through an intermediary, by Count Franz von Walsegg-Stuppach, who wished to commemorate his young wife, dead in February of that year, and intended to pass the work off as his own. Romantic legend turned the messenger into a grey stranger from the other world, and Pushkin's *Mozart and Salieri* (1830) has the composer haunted by the man in black who ordered a requiem that would prove to be his own. The most famous requiem of the age was thus written by a dying man for a widowed count, in 1791, the year before the game's prologue.

The partita, too, conceals a tomb. Bach's Partita No. 2 in D minor for solo violin (BWV 1004), whose closing Chaconne is among the summits of the instrumental repertory, survives in an autograph fair copy dated 1720. In July of that year, according to the obituary published by Carl Philipp Emanuel Bach and Johann Friedrich Agricola in 1754, Bach returned from a journey with his prince to find his wife, Maria Barbara, dead and already buried. Helga Thoene has argued (1994), controversially, that the Chaconne encodes chorale melodies on death and resurrection and was conceived as a *tombeau* — the French Baroque genre of musical memorial of which Froberger's "Tombeau fait à Paris sur la mort de Monsieur Blancheroche" (1652) is the classic instance, and which Ravel revived in *Le Tombeau de Couperin* (1914–1917), each of whose movements memorializes a friend killed in the war. Whether or not Thoene is right, her hypothesis is a perfect emblem of the game's musical structure: a husband who returns to

find his wife already gone, and a partita that is secretly a grave. The score of *Symphony of the Night* is, in this sense, a tombeau for Lisa, and the castle a mausoleum built of dances.

The toccata carries a different history, that of the Gothic cliché. Bach's Toccata and Fugue in D minor (BWV 565), whose attribution to Bach Peter Williams seriously questioned (1981), became in the sound cinema of the 1930s the musical sign of the villain at the organ: it opens Rouben Mamoulian's *Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde* (1931) and is played by Boris Karloff's satanist in Edgar G. Ulmer's *The Black Cat* (1934). A Bach that may not be Bach became the anthem of the Gothic, and the vampire at the keyboard a fixture of the genre — a further instance of the Gothic's birth from pseudepigraphy (§3.2). Yamane's toccata stands in this lineage while dispensing with its clichés; her organ and choral timbres evoke not the mad scientist's laboratory but the liturgy whose rest the castle's master refuses.

The Romantic symphony had already discovered the night. Hector Berlioz's *Symphonie fantastique* (1830), subtitled "Episode in the Life of an Artist," follows a lover who, in an opium dream, believes he has killed his beloved, is led to the scaffold, and wakes at a witches' sabbath, where the melody that has represented her throughout the work — the *idée fixe* — returns as a grotesque dance while bells toll and the brass intone the *Dies irae*. A symphony that ends in a nocturnal sabbath, in which the beloved reappears in monstrous form among the dead, is the precise ancestor of a game in which Lisa's form is assumed by a succubus in the depths of the castle (Chapter Five). Camille Saint-Saëns's *Danse macabre* (1874) gave Death a violin and set the dead dancing at midnight until the oboe's cockcrow scatters them; Modest Mussorgsky's *Night on Bald Mountain* (1867), in Rimsky-Korsakov's revision (1886), ends its sabbath with a church bell at dawn. The decisive precedent is cinematic. Disney's *Fantasia* (1940) closes by joining Mussorgsky's night, in which the demon Chernabog summons the dead from their graves, to Schubert's "Ave Maria," sung by a procession of light-bearers moving through a forest toward dawn. The demon's night is answered by the *Ave* — Gabriel's greeting that reverses *Eva* (§1.3) — and the dark is dissolved by a hymn to the woman who undid the Fall. *Symphony of the Night* ends, like *Fantasia*, when the demon's night yields to morning, and its resolution, as Chapter Five will show, is a woman's word.

3.4

The Sublime in Sprite and Pixel: Burke, Kant, Piranesi

THE CASTLE is the eighteenth century's theory of the sublime built in tiles. Edmund Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful* (1757) located the source of the sublime in "whatever is fitted in any sort to excite the ideas of pain, and danger," and enumerated its conditions: terror, obscurity, power, privation (darkness, vacuity, solitude, silence), vastness, infinity, difficulty, magnificence, sudden transitions of light, and the cries of animals. Its paradigm of sublime obscurity is a figure who appears at the threshold of *Symphony of the Night*. Burke quotes Milton's portrait of Death at the gates of Hell — "The other shape, / If shape it might be call'd that shape had none / Distinguishable in member, joint, or limb, / Or substance might be call'd that shadow seem'd, / For each seem'd either; black it stood as Night" (*Paradise Lost* II. 666–670) — and judges that in this description "all is dark, uncertain, confused, terrible, and sublime to the last degree." In Milton, Death keeps the gate of Hell beside Sin, and he is, as Sin reveals, the son of Satan. In the game, Death meets Alucard at the castle gate and strips him of his arms and powers. The son of the devil confronts the son of the devil at the threshold; the sublime begins, as in Burke, with Death.

Burke's most suggestive category for a medium built of repeated units is the "artificial infinite." Succession and uniformity of parts, he argued, produce in architecture the idea of infinity: a colonnade or a rotunda whose identical elements continue beyond what the eye can hold lets the imagination proceed as though without end. A two-dimensional game of 1997 is constructed literally of such parts. Its rooms are assembled from tiles, small graphical units repeated across the screen, and its corridors of columns, shelves, and windows — the Marble Gallery, the Long Library, the Outer Wall — are the artificial infinite rendered in code. The castle's vastness is produced by repetition, and the repetition is legible, as Burke said it must be, only as an intimation of what exceeds it. Susan Stewart's distinction between the miniature, which turns the world inward into a

space of contemplation, and the gigantic, which exceeds the body and can be known only in part (Stewart 1984), names the paradox the game resolves: its castle is a miniature of the gigantic, a sublime object small enough to be held within a television screen.

Kant's *Kritik der Urteilskraft* (1790) supplies the mechanism by which that paradox works. In the mathematical sublime (§§25–27), the imagination can apprehend a magnitude progressively, part after part, without limit, but cannot comprehend it in a single intuition; Kant's examples are the pyramids, which Savary advised must be seen from neither too near nor too far, and the bewilderment that seizes the visitor on first entering Saint Peter's in Rome (§26). The game separates apprehension and comprehension into two interfaces. On the play screen the castle is apprehended room by room, its totality always beyond the frame; on the map screen it is comprehended as an outline whose blanks mark what remains unknown. Reason's demand for totality is given its own instrument, and the gap between the two screens — the castle as lived and the castle as mapped — is the space in which the sublime is felt. The dynamical sublime (§28) depends on a further condition: the spectacle of overwhelming power becomes more attractive the more fearful it is, Kant writes, provided only that we find ourselves in safety (*wenn wir uns nur in Sicherheit befinden*). The castle builds Kant's condition into its architecture. Its save rooms, sealed chambers that no enemy enters and in which progress is preserved, are the safe places from which its terrors become sublime rather than merely terrible. And because, for Kant, the sublime lies not in the object but in the mind that judges it — in the discovery of a vocation that no natural power can overwhelm — the castle's vastness finally refers the player to the dhampir's vocation: a mercy that his father's might can neither compel nor prevent.

Giovanni Battista Piranesi drew the architecture of this sublime. His *Carceri d'invenzione*, first issued around 1750 and reworked into darker and more vertiginous states in 1761, depict impossible prisons of colossal vaults, bridges, chains, and stairways leading nowhere, through which minute figures wander in spaces whose structure cannot be resolved. Their most influential description is itself a relay of a relay. In the *Confessions of an English Opium-Eater* (1821), De Quincey recalls Coleridge describing to him a set of Piranesi's plates called "Dreams": a staircase on which Piranesi himself

gropes upward until the stair breaks off above the abyss; then, higher, a second stair, on which Piranesi again appears; and so on until stair and climber are lost in the upper gloom. His own architecture, De Quincey writes, proceeded in dreams "with the same power of endless growth and self-reproduction." No plate answers to the description, and De Quincey had not seen the prints; the most famous account of Piranesi's sublime is a dream of a description, passed from one Romantic to another. The game's verticals realize it. The Clock Tower and the Outer Wall raise their stairs and ledges into an upper gloom, breaking off above drops, ascended by a small figure who reappears at each level — Piranesi climbing within his own plate, the avatar within its castle.

The castle is also a collection, and its eclecticism has an architectural precedent of exact date. In 1792, the year of the game's prologue, the architect John Soane bought No. 12 Lincoln's Inn Fields in London, the first of three houses he would transform over four decades into a labyrinth of casts, fragments, models, paintings, and antiquities, culminating in the alabaster sarcophagus of Seti I, acquired in 1824 for the basement's sepulchral chamber. In 1812 Soane wrote a fantasy, "Crude Hints towards an History of my House," in which future antiquaries puzzle over the building's ruins and debate whether it had been a temple, a convent, or the dwelling of a magician; in 1830 his draughtsman Joseph Gandy exhibited a view of Soane's Bank of England as a ruin. The house-museum imagined as its own future ruin is the closest architectural analogue to Dracula's castle, which gathers Roman arena, Gothic chapel, scholarly library, marble gallery, alchemical laboratory, mechanical clock tower, and Early Christian catacomb into a single, disjunct, and impermanent structure. The castle is a *musée imaginaire* that knows it will become a ruin, and its sublimity is inseparable from its transience — the theme of §3.7.

3.5

In Praise of Shadows: Tanizaki, Darkness, and Gold

THE CASTLE is a world of shadows in Tanizaki's sense, and its gold is the gold of a dark room. In *In'ei Raisan* (*In Praise of Shadows*, 1933–1934), Tanizaki Jun'ichirō argued that the traditional Japanese aesthetic had been formed in dim interiors and depended on darkness for its effects. Lacquerware was made to be seen by candlelight, which brings its depths to life and its gold designs to a faint gleam; the gold leaf of sliding doors and folding screens, set deep in the recesses of rooms, catches the last light from the garden and glows in the obscurity; Noh costume reveals its splendour only on a dim stage. Beauty, on his account, lies less in the thing itself than in the play of shadow and light that one thing creates against another. He set this aesthetic against the brilliance of the modern West, whose electric illumination he blamed for its destruction, and he set it, characteristically, against the Gothic: where the cathedral's beauty lies in roofs and spires thrust upward toward the sky, the beauty of the Japanese temple lies in the deep shadow beneath its heavy, overhanging eaves.

Symphony of the Night inverts the opposition while honouring its terms. A Japanese work, it imagines Europe not as the civilization of light that Tanizaki deplored but as a house of shadows. Its castle presents a Gothic silhouette at the end of the forest road, but the player inhabits it almost entirely from within, in chambers whose dark grounds are lit by candles, stained glass, and the glint of metal: a Gothic exterior with a Japanese interior. The game's economy of light confirms the reading. The candles that line its corridors are both sources of light and vessels of gifts, yielding when struck the hearts that power the hero's sacred weapons, coins, and hidden items; light, in this castle, is something one breaks open. Tanizaki recounts that he once abandoned a plan to view the autumn moon at the temple of Ishiyama-dera on learning that loudspeakers would play recordings of the "Moonlight" Sonata among the trees for the viewers' entertainment. Some six decades later a Japanese game named itself after the

Western music of moonlight that had driven Tanizaki from the moon, and made of it the idiom of a night he would have recognized.

Kojima's paintings and the game's palette share Tanizaki's gold. Her figures emerge from black and umber grounds, picked out with gold at collar, hilt, and embroidery, and the castle's ornament glints in the same manner against the dark. The gold of the dark room has its Western counterparts. Byzantine mosaic and the gold grounds of medieval panel painting set the saints against the light of eternity; Caravaggio and Georges de La Tour made darkness the field from which light reveals, and La Tour's *Magdalene with the Smoking Flame* (c. 1640), the penitent's hand resting on a skull beside a single candle, is a vanitas in which shadow, golden light, and death compose one image. The decadent sensibility turned gold against life itself. In the fourth chapter of Huysmans's *À rebours* (1884), Des Esseintes has the shell of a living tortoise gilded and encrusted with gems so that it may glitter against his carpet; the creature dies beneath its splendour. Odilon Redon, whom Huysmans championed, held black to be the most essential of colours and, in the lithographs he dedicated to Edgar Poe (1882), sent an eye rising like a strange balloon toward infinity — an image to which the Eye among Dracula's relics, and the eye that survives as Kitarō's father (§2.7), stand in uncanny relation.

The Japanese archetype of gold in darkness is the Konjikidō of Chūsonji at Hiraizumi, built in 1124 by Fujiwara no Kiyohira: a small hall sheathed in gold leaf and inlaid with mother-of-pearl, beneath whose altars rest the mummified bodies of three generations of the Northern Fujiwara and the head of the fourth, Yasuhira, killed when Minamoto no Yoritomo destroyed the house in 1189. Since the Kamakura period the golden hall has been enclosed within a protective outer building, so that its splendour has for centuries been kept in shadow — gold sealed in darkness around the relics of a fallen lineage. Visiting in 1689, Bashō wrote: "Samidare no / furinokoshite ya / Hikaridō" — have the early summer rains, falling on all things, left this one untouched, the Hall of Light? A golden chamber holding the preserved bodies and the severed head of a ruined dynasty, sheltered by a dark enclosure and spared by time, is an image of the treasure that lies in the depths of Dracula's castle, where the son gathers the relics of a father whose house is about to fall. Gold in this tradition is not the colour

of wealth but of what survives, glowing faintly, in the dark that surrounds the dead.

3.6

A Revenant Medium: Two Dimensions in the Polygonal Dawn

◆

Symphony of the Night is a revenant in medium as well as in theme: an outmoded form returning before its time, sustained by the blood of a newer technology. The consoles that defined its moment — Sega's Saturn and Sony's PlayStation, both launched in Japan at the end of 1994, and Nintendo's N64 in 1996 — were marketed on the promise of polygonal space, and the works that set the industry's agenda in 1996 and 1997, from *Super Mario 64* and *Tomb Raider* to *Final Fantasy VII*, confirmed that the future lay in navigable volumes and cinematic cameras. Two-dimensional sprite games came to appear, in the industry's own discourse, as a residue of the previous generation. Against this current, Konami made a lavishly hand-animated two-dimensional work, using the PlayStation's capacities for semi-transparency, scaling, rotation, layered scrolling, and occasional polygonal effects not to escape the plane but to perfect it. Its reception followed a revenant's pattern: admired by critics, modest at first in commercial impact, it grew in standing retrospectively until it was treated as a founding classic.

Walter Benjamin identified the logic by which an outmoded form becomes newly significant. In his 1929 essay on Surrealism he credited Breton with being the first to perceive the revolutionary energies that appear in "the outmoded" (*das Veraltete*) — the first iron constructions, the earliest photographs, objects that have begun to die out — and Rosalind Krauss developed the insight into a theory of the medium (Krauss 1999): a technical support becomes available for artistic reinvention precisely when it becomes obsolete, released from commercial necessity into a second life. Marshall McLuhan had put the same paradox in temporal terms. "We look at the present through a rear-view mirror," he and Quentin Fiore wrote in *The Medium is the Massage* (1967); "We march backwards into the future."

McLuhan's later tetrad of media effects (*Laws of Media*, 1988, with Eric McLuhan) asked four questions of every medium: what it enhances, what it renders obsolete, what it retrieves, and into what it reverses when pushed to its limit. *Symphony of the Night* retrieves the sprite that polygonal space had rendered obsolete, and at its own limit it reverses, its castle turning over into its inverse. The game marches backward into the future in the precise sense of this dissertation's title: it is a retrograde.

Derrida supplied the term for what such a work does to time. *Spectres de Marx* (1993) opens with Hamlet's line — "The time is out of joint" — and develops a "hauntology" in which the specter is a *revenant*, that which comes back, so that every present is disjointed by returns from a past that will not stay past; Mark Fisher later extended the concept to cultural forms that preserve the traces of lost futures (Fisher 2014). The game is hauntological in both senses. Its castle comes back before its century is complete, out of joint with its own cycle, and its medium comes back at the moment of its supersession, out of joint with its industry. The term the industry used for its characters confirms the diagnosis. A *sprite* — the name adopted in the hardware vocabulary of the late 1970s for a graphic that moves independently over a background — is, in the older sense of the word, a spirit, from the Latin *spiritus* by way of the Old French *esprit*. The figures of a two-dimensional game are, by the medium's own nomenclature, ghosts.

The game's two-dimensionality has, besides, a Japanese pictorial genealogy older than any console. The narrative handscrolls (*emaki*) of the Heian and Kamakura periods unroll a story horizontally, scene by scene, in a continuous movement that the reader controls with both hands, and the illustrated *Tale of Genji* of the twelfth century uses the convention of the *fukinuki yatai*, the "blown-off roof," to show the interiors of buildings from above with roofs and walls removed. A side-scrolling game presents its castle in a lateral equivalent of the convention: a cross-section with the near wall stripped away, so that rooms, stairs, and passages are visible as the hero moves through them. The castle's two axes correspond, moreover, to the two formats of the Japanese scroll — the horizontal handscroll of its corridors and the vertical hanging scroll of its towers. Read thus, *Symphony of the Night* is an *emaki* unrolled in two directions at once, a picture-scroll unrolled by the player's hands; and when the Inverted Castle rotates the

map through half a circle, the reversal of left and right makes the second castle a scroll read against the direction of the first.

The hand-drawn plane mattered to the game's argument in a further way. In Japanese fan discourse, "two dimensions" (*nijigen*) designates not only a graphic mode but an ontological domain — the world of drawn characters, distinct from the "three dimensions" of embodied reality and capable of eliciting attachments of its own (Saitō 2000; Azuma 2001) — and Takashi Murakami's "Superflat" manifesto (2000) traced a lineage of flatness from Edo painting to anime as the native mode of Japanese visual culture. Whatever one makes of these claims, they illuminate the decision of 1997. To keep the castle flat was to keep it in the domain of the drawn, where Kojima's painted faces and the sprites' pixel bodies could belong to a single world, and where the mood of the whole — melancholy, ornamental, nocturnal — could be sustained without the literalism of polygonal space. A revenant theme found its proper body in a revenant medium.

3.7

Mujō: The *Heike*, Impermanence, and the Falling Castle

◆

The emotional key of *Symphony of the Night* is impermanence: its castle is beautiful because it must fall, and the game is felt under the sign of *mujō* before it is understood. The classic Japanese statement of the feeling opens the *Heike Monogatari*, the medieval epic of the rise and destruction of the Taira:

Gion shōja no kane no koe, shogyō mujō no hibiki ari. Shara sōju no hana no iro, jōsha hissui no kotowari o arawasu. Ogoreru hito mo hisashikarazu, tada haru no yo no yume no gotoshi. Takeki mono mo tsui ni wa horobinu, hitoe ni kaze no mae no chiri ni onaji.

The bell of the Jetavana monastery sounds the impermanence of all things; the colour of the sāla flowers declares that the flourishing must decline. The proud do not endure; they are like a dream on a spring night. The mighty fall at last; they are as dust before the wind. The *Heike* is the story of a tyrant — Taira no Kiyomori, whose arrogance it condemns and

whose death in a burning fever it narrates — and of the destruction of his house, culminating in the sea battle of Dan-no-ura in 1185. There Kiyomori's widow, the nun Nii-no-Ama, took the child emperor Antoku in her arms and, before leaping with him into the waves, told him that beneath the waves too there is a capital. The surviving empress-mother, Kenreimon'in, recounts at the epic's close a dream in which she saw her drowned kin assembled in splendour in a palace that she was told belonged to the Dragon King. The fallen dynasty continues in an inverted capital beneath the sea, in the dragon's palace. *Symphony of the Night*, which discloses beneath its castle another castle turned over upon itself, and which belongs to the son of the Dragon (§2.1), inherits the image whether or not it intends it: the Inverted Castle is a capital beneath the waves.

The doctrine of impermanence was the alphabet of classical Japanese literacy in a literal sense. The *Iroha*, the Heian-period poem that uses each syllable of the kana syllabary exactly once and served for centuries as the order in which those syllables were learned and listed, is a meditation on transience: "Iro wa nioedo / chirinuru o / waga yo tare zo / tsune naran / ui no okuyama / kyō koete / asaki yume miji / ei mo sezu" — though the colours are fragrant, they scatter; in our world who abides forever? Crossing today the deep mountains of existence, we shall not see shallow dreams, nor be drunk. The complete inventory of a writing system is a poem of impermanence; totality, in this tradition, teaches transience — a lesson to which Chapter Four will return when it reads the game's completion percentage. And in the very years of the game's fiction, Japanese thought produced its own theory of the feeling. Motoori Norinaga's commentary on the *Tale of Genji*, *Tama no Ogushi*, completed in 1796 and printed in 1799, argued against the moralizing readings of Buddhist and Confucian scholars that the tale exists to teach *mono no aware*, the capacity to be moved by things and to know the hearts of others; and in 1798, after thirty-four years of labour, Norinaga completed the *Kojiki-den*, his monumental commentary on Japan's oldest chronicle of the gods. While the authors of the "Oldest System-Programme" demanded a new mythology, a scholar in Matsusaka was recovering an old one, and grounding his ethics in sympathy with the transient.

Europe's counterpart is the aesthetics of the ruin, which reached its height in the same decades. Denis Diderot, contemplating Hubert Robert's

paintings at the Salon of 1767, wrote: "Les idées que les ruines réveillent en moi sont grandes. Tout s'anéantit, tout périt, tout passe. Il n'y a que le monde qui reste. Il n'y a que le temps qui dure." Everything vanishes, everything perishes, everything passes; only the world remains, only time endures. Volney's *Les Ruines, ou Méditation sur les révolutions des empires* appeared in 1791, and at the Salon of 1796 Robert exhibited a pair of canvases showing the Grande Galerie of the Louvre, the new national museum, once as a project for its renovation and once as an imaginary ruin, open to the sky, its vaults collapsed, its statues fallen among the weeds. The gallery and its ruin, painted as pendants, are the most exact prefiguration in European art of the paired castles of *Symphony of the Night*, whose Marble Gallery has its inverted counterpart (Chapter Four). The Gothic novel had made the fall of the house its very form. The first of them, Walpole's *Castle of Otranto* (1764), turns on a prophecy that the castle shall pass from the present family "whenever the real owner should be grown too large to inhabit it," and ends when the walls are thrown down and "the form of Alfonso, dilated to an immense magnitude," appears among the ruins to name the true heir. Poe's "The Fall of the House of Usher" (1839) makes house and lineage a single body: the mansion splits along its fissure and sinks into the tarn at the moment its last master dies. Reality obliged the genre: the great tower of William Beckford's Gothic folly, Fonthill Abbey, collapsed in 1825.

Japan had its own demon castle. Oda Nobunaga, who in a letter reported by the Jesuit Luís Fróis styled himself the Demon King of the Sixth Heaven, *Dairokuten Maō*, built at Azuchi between 1576 and 1579 a castle whose donjon was painted within in gold by Kanō Eitoku and arranged as a cosmos ascending from Buddhist to Confucian imagery; it burned in 1582, within days of his death and three years after its completion. The most celebrated golden building of modern Japan suffered the same fate by another hand. In 1950 a young acolyte set fire to the Kinkaku-ji in Kyoto, and Mishima's novel of 1956 imagined his motive as a beauty so absolute that it stood between him and life; the novel ends with the arsonist, the pavilion burning, resolving to live.

The *Castlevania* series made the fall of the castle its signature: the first game ends with the castle crumbling as its hero watches, and *Symphony of the Night* ends with the collapse of Dracula's house as the night gives way to

morning. The beauty of the castle is from the first the beauty of a ruin that has not yet fallen, and the player explores it in the knowledge — conveyed by the series' cycle, by the elegiac music, and by an aesthetic of the obsolescent — that its splendour is provisional. This is the decadent sublime: not the sublime of a nature that outlasts us, but of a magnificence that will not outlast us; not the terror of the overwhelming, but the tenderness of the doomed. The North American release closes over its final images with a ballad titled "I Am the Wind." In the *Heike*, the mighty are scattered as dust before the wind. Chapter Four turns from how the castle is felt to what it conceals: from aesthetics to the question of knowledge.



IV

Was kann ich wissen?

Chapter Four

Was kann ich wissen?

The Castle as Epistemic Object — Secrets, Memory, and the Apocalyptic Optics of the Holy Glasses

The first of Kant's questions receives in *Symphony of the Night* an answer given not in propositions but in architecture: what can be known is what can be reached; what can be reached depends on what the knower's body can become; and the totality of what is known always exceeds the measure that claims to contain it. This chapter reads the castle as an epistemic object — a structure whose forms of concealment, disclosure, memory, deception, and inversion amount to a theory of knowledge — in ten movements: the castle as world; the architecture of the secret; the map as memory palace; the confessional; the false ending; the conjunction of sun and moon; the unveiling of the controller; the inverted world; the mirror fugue; and the excess of totality figured by the completion percentage. Kant described his own critical turn as an inversion. Since every attempt to explain knowledge by supposing that cognition must conform to its objects had failed, he proposed to try whether objects must conform to cognition, as Copernicus, finding that the heavens would not revolve around a stationary spectator, tried whether matters went better if the spectator turned and the stars stood still (*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*, B xvi). The game performs a Copernican revolution of its own: at its midpoint the knower's world turns over, and what he learns thereafter concerns the knower as much as the known.

4.1

Castle as World: *Castlevania*, Asterion, Gormenghast, Kafka

◆

The castle of *Symphony of the Night* is not a building within a world but a world entire, and the series' Western name says so. *Castlevania*, a portmanteau of *castle* and *Transylvania*, fuses a building with a country, as though the land beyond the forest had contracted into a single edifice; the Japanese *Akumajō Dracula* names the demon castle and its lord in one title (§2.8). The game honours the identification. Apart from the moonlit approach of its opening, it has no outside — no town to return to, no road beyond the gate, no landscape that is not an annex of the castle: caverns, mines, and catacombs beneath it, an outer wall and towers above. The castle is a cosmos with the structure of a house.

Borges gave this structure its modern parable. In "La casa de Asterión" (1947), the Minotaur speaks of his house as the size of the world — or rather, as the world itself — and of his solitary days among its innumerable, identical galleries, waiting for a redeemer who will deliver him; the story's closing lines reveal the redeemer as Theseus and report that the Minotaur scarcely defended himself. The Cretan labyrinth was built by Daedalus to conceal a hybrid son, the offspring of a queen and a bull, whose existence was the shame of a royal house: the first great architecture of the secret in European myth is the hiding place of a monstrous child. *Symphony of the Night* inverts the parable at its root. Its hybrid son is not the labyrinth's captive but its explorer, and the monster awaiting deliverance is the father, whom the son's coming will release.

Mervyn Peake's Gormenghast trilogy (1946–1959) supplies the castle as a world of inherited ritual, whose labyrinthine extent and incomprehensible laws bind every inhabitant to a role. Its heir, Titus, comes of age within this world and, at the close of the second volume, rides out of it, renouncing the earldom his birth assigned him; the heir who refuses the castle at the end is a figure the game's conclusion will repeat (Chapter Seven). Peake's intriguer Steerpike, a kitchen boy who rises through the castle by manipulation,

murder, and the exploitation of ritual, is a kinsman of Shaft, the priest who has insinuated himself into the machinery of Dracula's house.

Kafka's *Das Schloß* (written 1922, published 1926) poses the castle as an object of knowledge that will not be known. It opens with an arrival: "Es war spätabends, als K. ankam. Das Dorf lag in tiefem Schnee. Vom Schloßberg war nichts zu sehen, Nebel und Finsternis umgaben ihn, auch nicht der schwächste Lichtschein deutete das große Schloß an." It was late evening when K. arrived; the village lay in deep snow; nothing of the castle hill could be seen, mist and darkness surrounded it, not even the faintest gleam of light betrayed the great castle. K. is a land surveyor, a *Landvermesser* — a measurer of land — summoned, as he believes, by the castle; he never reaches it, never surveys anything, and is never certain that he was summoned at all. Kafka's castle is the epistemic object as pure withdrawal, approached through endless mediation and known only by rumour, officials, and documents. The game answers Kafka's surveyor with a surveyor who succeeds. Its player is a *Landvermesser* whose measurement is displayed as a percentage, and its castle, though it hides much, can be entered, crossed, and mapped. Where Kafka's castle is inaccessible because its secret is administrative and infinite, the game's castle is accessible because its secrets are spatial and finite — until, as §4.10 will show, the finite measure begins to exceed itself.

Italo Calvino's *Il castello dei destini incrociati* (1969; expanded 1973), finally, imagines a castle in which travellers struck mute tell their stories by laying tarot cards on a table, each card serving many narratives and each narrative crossing the others: a castle whose world is generated combinatorially from a finite set of images. The game's castle is such a deck, a finite repertory of rooms, creatures, items, and relics from which each traversal composes its own sequence; Calvino's castle and Azuma's database (§1.9) meet in its structure. The castle as world is thus at once Borges's labyrinth, Peake's ritual house, Kafka's withheld object, and Calvino's combinatorial deck, and its epistemology begins from all four.

4.2

The Architecture of the Secret

THE CASTLE'S epistemology is an architecture of the secret, and its first principle was stated by Georg Simmel: "Das Geheimnis bietet sozusagen die Möglichkeit einer zweiten Welt neben der offenbaren" — the secret offers, so to speak, the possibility of a second world beside the manifest one (*Soziologie*, 1908). The game builds Simmel's sentence literally, for the Inverted Castle is a second world beside the manifest one, disclosed only to the player who has penetrated the first world's secrets; but the principle governs the first castle too, at every scale. Walls that yield to a blow conceal rooms; ledges glimpsed above the reach of a jump conceal passages; grates, currents, and narrow shafts conceal regions accessible only to a transformed body. The castle shows its secrets before it yields them.

This exhibition of the unattainable is the game's answer to the oldest paradox of inquiry. In Plato's *Meno* (80d–e), Meno objects that one cannot search for what one does not know, since one would not recognize it if one found it, nor for what one knows, since one has it already; Socrates replies with the doctrine that learning is recollection, *anamnēsis*, and demonstrates it on a slave boy who, by being questioned, discovers a geometrical truth he seemed not to possess. The game dissolves Meno's dilemma by design. It lets the player see what cannot yet be reached — a door that will not open, a platform beyond the arc of a leap, a passage visible through a grate — so that the object of the search is known enough to be sought but not enough to be possessed. The castle teaches as Socrates taught, questioning by obstruction until the seeker remembers what he can do; and because Alucard's new powers are recoveries of his own nature (§1.5), the game's learning is recollection in the literal sense.

The structure has a scriptural template that Frank Kermode made the starting point of a theory of narrative secrecy (*The Genesis of Secrecy*, 1979). Asked why he speaks in parables, Jesus answers in Mark's Gospel: "Unto you it is given to know the mystery of the kingdom of God: but unto them that are without, all these things are done in parables: That seeing they may see, and not perceive; and hearing they may hear, and not under-

stand" (Mark 4:11–12). A secret is not an absence but a presence that is not perceived. The castle's secrets are of this kind: they stand in plain view, among the tiles of a corridor or behind the texture of a wall, and are hidden only from those who see without perceiving. Kafka's parable "Vor dem Gesetz" (1915) supplies the corresponding image of the door. A man from the country waits his whole life before the open door of the Law, kept out by a doorkeeper, and learns at the end that this door was meant for him alone and will now be shut. The castle is full of doors meant for one particular power — the blue doors that yield only to the relic called the Jewel of Open, the barriers that give way only to mist or wolf or bat — and its epistemology is Kafka's inverted: each door was made for its seeker, and the seeker can learn to pass.

Passage, in this castle, requires metamorphosis, and here the game's epistemology becomes a theory of the knowing body. Jakob von Uexküll's studies of animal environments (*Streifzüge durch die Umwelten von Tieren und Menschen*, 1934) argued that each organism inhabits an *Umwelt*, a world constituted by what its perceptual and motor organs can register and do; the tick's world contains warmth, the scent of butyric acid, and the texture of hair, and nothing else. Alucard's castle is an *Umwelt* that expands as his body changes. As a bat he reaches heights, and with the relic called Echo of Bat he gains a sense of echoes; as mist he passes through grates; as a wolf he runs low and fast along the ground. Thomas Nagel's "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?" (1974) argued that the subjective character of echolocation is inaccessible to us; the game cannot refute him, but it makes the bat's form a condition of knowledge. The deepest consequence concerns filiation. The forms Alucard must assume to know his father's house are his father's own Stokerian forms (§2.5): the son can enter the father's secrets only by becoming like the father. Plotinus held that the eye could never have seen the sun had it not first become sunlike (*Enneads* I. 6.9), and Goethe rendered the thought in verse: "Wär nicht das Auge sonnenhaft, / Die Sonne könnt es nie erblicken." Were the eye not sunlike, it could never behold the sun. The dhampir's knowledge obeys the same law, darkly: to see the father's world, the son must become, in part, the father.

4.3

The Memory Palace: Simonides, Camillo, Bruno, and the Map Screen

THE CASTLE is a memory palace, and the art it reactivates was founded on a collapsed hall and the identification of the dead. Cicero tells the story (*De oratore* II.351–354). The poet Simonides of Ceos, engaged to praise the boxer Scopas at a banquet, devoted part of his ode to the twin gods Castor and Pollux; Scopas paid only half the fee and told him to collect the rest from the twins. A message came that two young men were asking for him outside; he went out and found no one; while he was gone the roof fell, crushing the company beyond recognition. Simonides identified each body for burial by remembering where each guest had sat, and derived from the experience the principle of the art of memory: that an orderly arrangement of places (*loci*) preserves the order of things. The art of memory was born, in its founding legend, from a catastrophe and a funeral. Its patrons were the Dioscuri, twins of whom one was mortal and the other divine, who shared immortality by alternating days among the living and the dead — the classical myth's nearest approach to a dhampiric pair.

The *Rhetorica ad Herennium* (c. 80s BCE) codified the technique. The student memorizes a series of places in a building and sets in each an image, and the images must be *imagines agentes*, active images striking enough to fix themselves in the mind: figures of exceptional beauty or singular ugliness, some crowned or robed in purple, some disfigured, stained with blood or smeared with mud (III.xxii.37). The castle's rooms are *loci*, and its bestiary is a gallery of *imagines agentes*; the rhetorician's prescription for memorable images reads like a design brief for a Gothic menagerie. Frances Yates's history of the art (1966) traced its Renaissance transformations, two of which illuminate the game. Giulio Camillo's Memory Theatre, built as a wooden model in the 1530s and described in *L'idea del theatro* (1550), arranged the images of all knowledge in the tiers of a Vitruvian auditorium and placed its user not in the seats but on the stage, looking out at the images where the audience would sit — a theatre turned inside out. Giordano Bruno's *De umbris idearum* (1582), "On the Shadows of Ideas,"

built combinatorial memory wheels whose images were shadows cast by the divine ideas; Bruno was burned as a heretic in the Campo de' Fiori in 1600, a fate Chapter Five will set beside Lisa's. And in 1596 the Jesuit Matteo Ricci taught the method to Chinese literati in a treatise on the Western art of memory (Spence 1984), carrying the European memory palace into East Asia: the art had already made the journey between Europe and Asia that the castle's imagery would make in reverse.

The map screen is the game's memory palace made visible. Each room the player enters is recorded on it, unexplored regions remain blank, and the outline that accumulates over hours of play is an externalized memory: a record of where the player has been, and an index of the castle's unrecalled remainder. Edward Tolman's experiments on rats in mazes (1948) proposed that organisms build "cognitive maps" of their environments rather than chains of responses; Kevin Lynch's *The Image of the City* (1960) described the legible city through its paths, edges, districts, nodes, and landmarks; and Fredric Jameson adapted Lynch's terms to describe the subject's need for a "cognitive mapping" of a social totality that exceeds individual experience (Jameson 1988). The castle is legible in Lynch's terms — its districts are its named areas, its landmarks the Clock Tower and the Keep, its edge the Outer Wall, its node the Castle Center — and its map grants the player the cognitive mapping that Jameson thought the late twentieth century withheld. In a world without an outside, the map is the only view from above.

The castle remembers in a second register as well. Each district has its music, and a return to a region restores its theme, so that the score works like the "little phrase" of Vinteuil's sonata in Proust's *Du côté de chez Swann* (1913), a melody that returns a place and a past to the listener without the labour of recollection. Augustine had already described memory as an architecture, coming in Book X of the *Confessions* to "campos et lata praetoria memoriae, ubi sunt thesauri innumerabilium imaginum" — the fields and spacious palaces of memory, where lie the treasures of innumerable images (X.8.12). The phrase joins the art of memory to the art of confession, the subject of the next section, and it names exactly what the castle is: a palace of images whose treasures, gathered by an act of recollection, are the restored powers of the one who remembers.

4.4

The Confessional Machine: Augustine, Rousseau, Foucault, Malraux

◆

The castle extracts its secrets as a confessor extracts sins, and it contains, in its Royal Chapel, a confessional. A player who seats Alucard in the booth may summon a spectral figure to its other side — by most accounts sometimes a penitent, sometimes a priest whose ministrations can turn hostile — and the episode, brief as it is, sets at the heart of the castle's sacred precinct the apparatus by which the Western Church made the interior of the person available to a hearer. The game's interest in the secret is therefore sacramental as well as spatial: it asks what kind of knowledge of a person confession produces, and whether the "miserable little pile of secrets" of the prologue is a thing found in human beings or a thing made by the procedures that search them.

Augustine set the terms. The *Confessions* (c. 397–400) are addressed to a God "cuius oculis nuda est abyssus humanae conscientiae" — before whose eyes the abyss of human conscience lies naked (X.2.2) — so that confession reveals nothing to its divine hearer and everything to the one who confesses. In confessing, Augustine discovers himself as a question: "mihi quaestio factus sum," I have become a question to myself (X.33.50). Kant's fourth question begins, in this sense, in a confession; and the abyss of conscience, naked before the divine eye, is the counterpart of the castle's depths, naked before the Holy Glasses (§4.7). Rousseau turned confession from God to the public. His *Confessions* (1782–1789) open by claiming an enterprise without precedent and by staging a judgment — let the trumpet of the Last Judgment sound when it will, he will present himself before the sovereign judge with this book in his hand — and their most famous episode is the disclosure of a secret carried for forty years: the theft of a ribbon for which he allowed a young servant, Marion, to be blamed and dismissed. The modern confessional subject is a man who carries a secret and at last lays it before his reader. It is worth recalling that the same Rousseau held that no testimony could make vampires credible (§2.2): the theorist of the unbelievable dossier was also the founder of the modern confession.

Michel Foucault diagnosed the institution behind both. *La Volonté de savoir* (1976) argued that the West had made man *une bête d'aveu*, a confessing animal, and that confession — imposed annually on the laity by the Fourth Lateran Council (1215) and later dispersed into medicine, psychiatry, pedagogy, and literature — is a technique of power that produces the truths it claims to discover. Karatani Kōjin made the argument for Japan in *Nihon kindai bungaku no kigen* (*Origins of Modern Japanese Literature*, 1980): the confessional fiction of the late Meiji period, of which Tayama Katai's *Futon* (1907) is the founding instance, arose from a system of confession introduced through Protestant Christianity, and the interiority it claimed to reveal was constituted by the form that revealed it. A confessional booth in a European chapel, attended by ghosts, in a game made in Tokyo, thus stands where two histories of the confessing self intersect: the one that produced Rousseau and the one that, on Karatani's account, produced the modern Japanese interior.

Malraux's formula takes its place in this history (§1.2). The *Antimémoires* refuse confession: the pile of secrets is contemptible, and the memoirist declines to display it. Dracula's use of the formula in the prologue is Malrucian in tone and Foucauldian in effect, for his contempt is aimed at a human interior that he imagines confession would expose as squalid. The game's structure answers that the secret is not a residue to be despised but a depth to be sought, and that its disclosure may be an act not of power but of love. The castle's last confession is not extracted but given. At the end the son discloses to the dying father a secret the father did not know he lacked — the last words of the woman they both lost — and the father, hearing it, acknowledges his error. Confession, inverted, becomes testimony: the passing of a word from the one who remembers to the one who has forgotten.

4.5

The Midpoint Ending: Closure as Deception

The game's most audacious epistemic device is a false ending placed at its structural midpoint. A player who reaches the Castle Keep without the

Holy Glasses finds there Richter Belmont, enthroned, who declares himself the castle's new lord and fights Alucard; if he is killed, the game concludes and the credits roll. Nothing in the presentation marks this conclusion as false, and a long tradition of player testimony records the experience of those who took it for the end and learned only later, from friends or from print, that they had seen half the work. The game thus makes closure itself an object of suspicion. An ending is a claim to totality, and this ending lies.

Frank Kermode's *The Sense of an Ending* (1967) argued that fictions borrow their shape from apocalypse, imposing on the mere succession of time a structure in which the end confers meaning on all that precedes it; plot, on his account, converts the clock's indifferent succession into the meaningful interval between a tick and a tock. The false ending exploits this need. Its satisfactions are formally complete — the boss defeated, the castle's apparent lord overthrown, the credits rolling — and therefore persuasive. Peter Brooks's *Reading for the Plot* (1984), reading narrative through Freud's *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920), described plot as a detour between beginning and end, sustained against the danger of the short circuit, the premature or improper ending; Freud's organism, he recalled, wishes to die only in its own fashion (*nur auf seine Weise*). The midpoint ending is the short circuit made playable, and it is improper in the most literal sense, for it is the death of the wrong person. The player who kills Richter has killed a possessed man in place of his possessor, a human being in place of a monster — the very error of those who burned Lisa. The false ending is the game's first moral examination, and its failure is a failure of sight.

The structure has literary precedents in works whose first half seems whole. Shakespeare's *The Winter's Tale* (c. 1611) devotes its first three acts to a tragedy of false accusation — a king's jealousy, a queen condemned and reported dead, an infant cast out — and then, after Time crosses sixteen years as Chorus, turns into romance, ending in the scene in which the statue of the dead queen comes to life before her penitent husband. A spectator who left at the interval would believe he had seen a tragedy. Goethe's *Faust* offers the structure on a larger scale: the First Part (1808) closes with Gretchen's salvation and seems complete; the Second Part (1832) carries the work into a mirrored cosmos, setting a Classical Walpurgis Night against the Germanic Walpurgis Night of the First. In each case the second half

answers the first by inversion, and the restoration it offers — the living queen, the saved Faust — is available only to the audience that stays.

What the game rewards is a specific epistemic virtue: curiosity. The Holy Glasses are given only to the player who has found the two rings that open the way to the castle's centre (§4.6), and who has therefore explored beyond what the visible path required. Augustine condemned *curiositas* as the "lust of the eyes," *concupiscentia oculorum* (*Confessions* X.35.54), a craving to know for the sake of knowing; Hans Blumenberg traced the modern age's rehabilitation of that craving as legitimate in his account of the trial of theoretical curiosity (1966; revised 1973). *Symphony of the Night* sides with modernity against Augustine, with a twist Augustine might have appreciated: the reward of curiosity is a pair of *holy* glasses. The lust of the eyes, pursued far enough, ends in an instrument of revelation. Aristotle opened the *Metaphysics* by claiming that all human beings by nature desire to know, citing as evidence our delight in the senses, and above all in sight (980a). The false ending tests whether that desire will settle for the appearance of an end.

4.6

Sol et Luna: The Gold and Silver Rings

◆

The way to revelation passes through a marriage. To obtain the Holy Glasses, the player must find two rings in distant parts of the castle, a Gold Ring and a Silver Ring, and wear them together in the clock room of the Marble Gallery, where the floor opens and the hero descends to the castle's centre; there Maria Renard gives him the glasses. The metals are the oldest in alchemical symbolism. Gold is the sun and silver the moon, and their union — the *coniunctio* of Sol and Luna, king and queen, sulphur and mercury — is the central operation of the Great Work, from which the philosophers' stone or the hermaphroditic *Rebis* is born (§3.1). The woodcuts of the *Rosarium philosophorum* (1550) depict the stages: king and queen meet and join hands, enter the bath, unite, die together in the darkness of putrefaction, and rise as a single two-headed being; C. G. Jung read the sequence as a psychology of transference and individuation (Jung

Figure 8

Sol et Luna



Sol et Luna (§4.6). Worn together in the clock room, the Gold and Silver Rings perform the alchemical conjunction of sun and moon, from which the hermaphroditic Rebis is born; the floor opens, and at the castle's centre Maria gives the Holy Glasses. In the Kojiki*, sun and moon are born from the washed eyes of the widower Izanagi.*

1946; 1955–1956). The game's rings perform the conjunction on the hero's hands, in a room governed by a clock — the instrument that measures the alternation of sun and moon — and the consequence is a descent to the centre.

The interpretive point is filial. Alucard is himself the child of a conjunction of opposites: of a vampire lord and a human woman, of night and day. To wear the gold and the silver together is to wear the union of which he is the issue, and only by wearing his origin can he descend to the castle's centre and receive the means of seeing its truth. The androgyne of Kojima's portrait (§3.1) is here translated into procedure: the dhampir, the *Rebis* of the castle, must re-enact the marriage that made him. The alchemical tradition knew this narrative in literary form. *Chymische Hochzeit Christiani Rosencreutz* (1616), attributed to Johann Valentin Andreae, recounts a seven-day initiation in a castle in which a king and queen are beheaded and restored to life by alchemical operations. Its hero, having looked in secret upon the sleeping Venus in a hidden vault, is condemned at the end to remain as the castle's doorkeeper until another guest commits the same transgression. In the Chymical Wedding, to see the castle's secret is to inherit its gate.

The Japanese tradition supplies a mythic counterpart of startling precision. In the *Kojiki* (712), the creator god Izanagi descends to Yomi, the land of the dead, to bring back his dead wife Izanami. Breaking her prohibition, he kindles a light and sees her body, rotting and wreathed with maggots; he flees, and seals the passage behind him with a boulder. Returning from the underworld, he bathes to cleanse himself of death, and as he washes his face the sun goddess Amaterasu is born from his left eye and the moon god Tsukuyomi from his right. Sun and moon are born from the eyes of a widower who has looked upon his dead wife's corruption: the oldest Japanese narrative of mourning yields the cosmos its two lights. The constellation with the game needs little commentary — a father who cannot recover his dead wife; the sun and moon issuing from his washed eyes; and, in the castle, gold and silver rings that lead to the Holy Glasses, while among the father's relics lies his own Eye. It was this text that Motoori Norinaga finished expounding in 1798 (§3.7).

Two further stars complete the figure. Plato's allegory of the cave (*Republic* VII, 516a–b) describes the freed prisoner's ascent: dazzled by the

sun, he must look first at shadows and at reflections in water, then at the moon and the stars by night, and only last at the sun itself. The moon is the light of transition, the intermediate illumination for eyes not yet able to bear the day — the light that Chapter Three called the dhampir's own. And Wagner's *Das Rheingold* (1869) offers the dark counterpart of the conjunctive ring: Alberich can forge the ring of limitless power only by renouncing love ("Nur wer der Minne Macht versagt"), and the cycle ends when Brünnhilde returns the ring to the Rhine as Valhalla burns. Among the relics the son must gather in the Inverted Castle is the Ring of Vlad, the father's ring. The son's two rings of union lead to sight; the father's ring of power leads to the end of the castle. The conjunction of sun and moon is the game's first image of what dhampiric reason does: it holds opposites together long enough to see.

4.7

Apokalypsis: The Holy Glasses and the Unveiling of the Controller

◆

The Holy Glasses are the game's instrument of *apokalypsis* in the etymological sense: an unveiling, the removal of a covering from what was already there. Worn in the Castle Keep, they reveal what the naked eye could not see — an orb suspended above Richter's head, through which the dark priest Shaft controls him — and Alucard, striking the orb rather than the man, frees the hunter and exposes the possessor. The scene is the epistemic hinge of the work. Everything before it took place under a veil; everything after it takes place in a world turned over by what the unveiling disclosed.

Paul supplied the theology of such sight: "For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known" (1 Corinthians 13:12). The Vulgate's *per speculum in aenigmate* — through a mirror, in an enigma — names the condition of knowledge in this world, partial and riddling, and sets against it the eschatological vision in which knowing will match being known. Le Fanu borrowed the phrase for his collection (§2.5); the game makes it an item of

equipment. Its glasses do not darken but clarify, converting what was seen darkly into what is seen face to face. Heinrich von Kleist had drawn the opposite conclusion from the figure of spectacles. In a letter of 22 March 1801 to Wilhelmine von Zenge, written in the despair of his encounter with Kant, he imagined that if all human beings had green glasses instead of eyes, they would judge the objects they saw to be green, and could never decide whether the eye shows things as they are or adds something that belongs not to the things but to the eye. Kleist's glasses are the emblem of critical scepticism, a lens that may be the source of what it shows. The Holy Glasses answer Kleist's despair in the register of revelation: their lenses add nothing, and take the veil away.

Who gives the glasses matters. Maria Renard appears to the hero at the castle's centre after he has joined the sun and the moon on his hands, and gives him the means of revelation. The Apocalypse of John describes "a great wonder in heaven; a woman clothed with the sun, and the moon under her feet, and upon her head a crown of twelve stars," before whom stands "a great red dragon" ready to devour her child (Revelation 12:1–4); the dragon is "that old serpent, called the Devil" (12:9), the beast whose name the Wallachian voivodes bore (§2.1). Catholic tradition read the woman as Mary, and early modern painting represented the Immaculate Conception as a woman robed in light and standing on the crescent moon. That a woman named Maria should appear to the hero after he has united the gold of the sun and the silver of the moon, and should give him the means of an apocalypse in the house of the son of the Dragon, is a constellation that no designer needed to intend for the work to possess it.

What the glasses reveal is the controller, and here the game's epistemology turns reflexive. In Plato's cave (*Republic* VII, 514b), the prisoners watch shadows cast by objects that men carry behind a low wall, like the screen over which showmen display their puppets; liberation begins with the discovery of the hidden carriers. The orb above Richter is such a puppeteer, and its unveiling exposes the structure of the game itself, in which a body on the screen is moved by an invisible agency outside it. The player who has guided Alucard for hours is shown, in the possessed Richter, the image of control: a hunter whose actions are not his own, steered by a hand he cannot see. Chapter Five will pursue the ethical consequences of

this disclosure. Its epistemic consequence is that the deepest secret of the castle is the apparatus of play.

Early modern optics had shown how literally sight inverts. Kepler demonstrated in 1604 that the image formed on the retina is upside down, and Descartes, in the *Dioptrique* (1637), proposed an experiment to show it: take the eye of a man newly dead or, failing that, of an ox, strip away the membranes at its back, set it in the aperture of a darkened room, and the images of the things outside will appear on its rear surface, inverted. The eye of the dead shows the world upside down. Marx and Engels made the same optics the figure of ideology: in all ideology, they wrote in *Die deutsche Ideologie* (1845–1846), human beings and their circumstances appear upside down as in a camera obscura, and the inversion arises from their historical life-process as the inversion of objects on the retina arises from the physical one. The Holy Glasses correct a false world by revealing its hidden mechanism, and their immediate effect is that the world turns over. To see truly, in this castle, is to see the world inverted, as through the dead eye of Descartes or the camera obscura of Marx; and the Eye of Vlad waits among the relics of the second castle.

4.8

Per Motum Contrarium: The Inverted Castle and Hegel's *Verkehrte Welt*

◆

When the orb shatters, the castle turns over. The Inverted Castle that replaces Dracula's first house is the same building rotated through half a circle: its map is the first map turned upside down, its chambers are traversed along ceilings that have become floors, and its regions bear names that read the first castle backward. The Alchemy Laboratory becomes the Necromancy Laboratory, the Marble Gallery the Black Marble Gallery, the Long Library the Forbidden Library, the Royal Chapel the Anti-Chapel, and the Catacombs, which lay beneath the castle, become the Floating Catacombs. The transmutation of base matter into gold is inverted into the conjuring of the dead; a scholar's library becomes a forbidden one; the

Figure 9

Rectus et Inversus

Five regions of the first castle and the names they bear when it turns over (§4.8), every name a canon by contrary motion. The lower half is set for a reader seated across the table, as in the duet of §1.3: turn the book to read it.

Rectus

the first castle

Alchemy Laboratory

Marble Gallery

Long Library

Royal Chapel

Catacombs



Inversus

the Inverted Castle

Necromancy Laboratory

Black Marble Gallery

Forbidden Library

Anti-Chapel

Floating Catacombs

for the reader seated across the table

subterranean becomes aerial. Every name is a *canon per motum contrarium*, the subject sung against itself.

Hegel's analysis of the inverted world in the third chapter of the *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807) provides the philosophical grammar. The understanding first posits, behind the play of appearances, a calm kingdom of laws, a supersensible world that copies the sensible one in stable form; pursued further, this supersensible world turns into a second, the *verkehrte Welt*, in which everything is its own opposite — what is sweet in the first world is sour in the second, what is black is white, the north pole is the south. Hegel's decisive example is juridical: the punishment that in the first world disgraces and destroys the criminal is, in the inverted world, a pardon that preserves his essence and restores him to honour. But Hegel does not leave the two worlds side by side. The inverted world, he argues, is not a separate realm behind the first but the first world's own inner difference; each contains its opposite, and the truth is the unity of the two, the movement Hegel calls infinity. The chapter closes with the passage from consciousness to self-consciousness, in an image that reads as a gloss on the Holy Glasses: "Es zeigt sich, daß hinter dem sogenannten Vorhange, welcher das Innere verdecken soll, nichts zu sehen ist, wenn wir nicht selbst dahinter gehen." It turns out that behind the so-called curtain that is supposed to conceal the inner world there is nothing to be seen, unless we ourselves go behind it. The veil is lifted, and behind it the seeker meets himself.

The game enacts each stage of this dialectic. The first castle is the world of punishment, built by a father who holds humanity guilty; the second is its inversion, in which the son, gathering the father's relics, moves toward the pardon Lisa asked for (§1.5). The two castles are not two worlds but one building read in two directions, and the truth of the work is the unity of the two readings, which only a traversal of both can give. What lies behind the curtain is not a final object but the seeker's self-knowledge: Alucard's recognition of what he owes to each half of his blood.

The inverted world has a popular history as well as a speculative one. From the sixteenth century, European broadsides of *le monde à l'envers* showed oxen butchering their butchers, children chastising their parents, fish angling for the fisherman; Ernst Robert Curtius traced the topos of the world upside down to the classical *adynata*, catalogues of impossibilities

(*Europäische Literatur und lateinisches Mittelalter*, 1948), and Mikhail Bakhtin made the inversions of carnival — the crowning and uncrowning of a mock king — the core of a theory of popular culture in his study of Rabelais (completed 1940, published 1965). In the Inverted Castle the son judges the father, and the hierarchy of the house is turned over. Japanese custom adds a further sense, decisive for a work made in Tokyo. In traditional funerary practice the world of the dead is the reverse of the world of the living, and the rites mark the passage with inversions, *sakasa-goto*: the robe of the dead is closed right over left, against the practice of the living; a folding screen is set upside down beside the body; the water for washing the corpse is prepared by pouring hot into cold, against everyday habit. For a Japanese audience, a world turned upside down is a world dressed for the dead. The Inverted Castle is the castle in its funerary aspect — the capital beneath the waves (§3.7), the house prepared for a father's death.

Kant had named his own philosophy an inversion (B xvi), and the experimental psychology of the following century tested what it means to inhabit one. In 1897 — the year of Stoker's novel — George Stratton reported in the *Psychological Review* that he had worn, for eight days, a lens system that turned his visual field upside down and reversed it from left to right, and that as the days passed the inverted world grew habitable, its strangeness ever less remarked. The player of the Inverted Castle repeats Stratton's experiment. The disorientation of the first hours gives way to familiarity, and the inverted castle becomes a world in its own right. Hegel's lesson becomes a matter of habit: the inverted world is not alien but the same world known otherwise.

4.9

Mirror Fugue: Bach, Schoenberg, Escher, Hofstadter

THE TWO castles stand to each other as the two halves of a mirror fugue, and the analogy, pursued exactly, explains why the second is not a repetition of the first. In Contrapunctus 12 and 13 of *Die Kunst der Fuge*, Bach writes

each fugue twice, *rectus* and *inversus*, so that every interval of the first version is turned upside down in the second, and the two, each complete in itself, are the same work heard from opposite sides. The inversion is not a copy but a transformation that preserves identity while altering every particular: the subject is recognized in its inversion, yet nothing in the inversion sounds as before. So with the castle. The player recognizes every chamber of the Inverted Castle and traverses none of them as before; the familiar becomes strange without ceasing to be familiar — Freud's *unheimlich* (1919), the homely made unhomely, realized as architecture.

Arnold Schoenberg made such transformations the basis of a method. The row of twelve-tone composition appears in four forms — prime, retrograde, inversion, retrograde inversion — each transposable to twelve pitch levels; and in "Composition with Twelve Tones" (1941) Schoenberg justified the practice by appealing to the unity of musical space, in which, as in Swedenborg's heaven, there is no absolute up or down, left or right (§1.3). The mind, he argued, recognizes a musical shape in any of its orientations, as it recognizes a knife, a bottle, or a watch however they are turned. The Inverted Castle tests the claim in space. A player who has internalized the first castle recognizes the second, and the recognition is the condition of its strangeness.

M. C. Escher gave the visual arts their mirror fugues. *Relativity* (1953) depicts a building in which three systems of gravity coexist, so that figures use the same staircase on different surfaces, one climbing what another descends, each upright in his own world; *Drawing Hands* (1948) shows two hands each drawing the other into being; *Print Gallery* (1956) shows a young man in a gallery looking at a print of a town that expands to contain the very gallery in which he stands, a loop Escher could not close at its centre and left blank. The Inverted Castle is *Relativity* distributed in time — two gravities, first one and then the other, in a single building. *Print Gallery*, with its viewer inside the image he views and its unresolved centre, is the figure of the game's reflexivity, in which a player watches a screen on which a figure explores a castle that turns, at its midpoint, to show him the apparatus of his own looking (§4.7).

Douglas Hofstadter's *Gödel, Escher, Bach* (1979) gathered these figures under the concept of the strange loop: a hierarchy that, by moving upward or onward through its levels, returns to its starting point, as Escher's

staircases do, as the endlessly modulating canon of Bach's *Musical Offering* rises through its keys back to its beginning, and as Gödel's construction makes a formal system speak about itself. One of Hofstadter's dialogues is itself a crab canon, reading the same backward as forward, and his later work argued that the self is such a loop, a pattern that refers back to itself (Hofstadter 2007). Alucard is a strange loop. His name returns his father's name backward; his journey passes through the father's house twice, forward and inverted; and his identity is constituted by that return. The son knows himself by reading the father in reverse. Gödel's theorem, the third term of Hofstadter's triad, leads directly to the last question of this chapter: whether a totality can contain its own measure.

4.10

200.6 Percent: The Supplement and the Excess of Totality

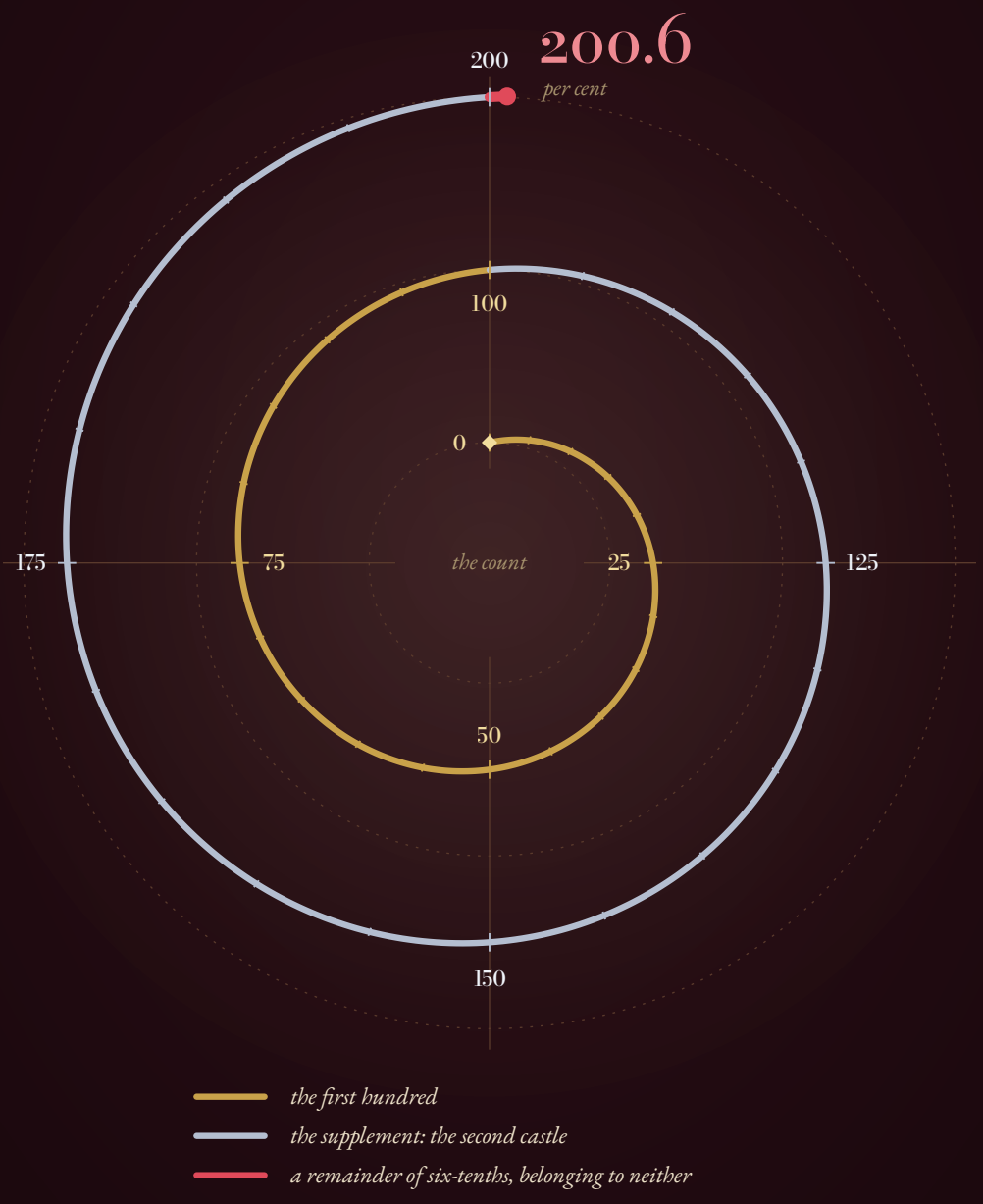
◆

The castle measures the player's knowledge as a percentage, and the measure exceeds itself. The map screen reports the proportion of rooms explored, and in the PlayStation version a figure that one might expect to culminate at one hundred can rise, once the Inverted Castle is open, to 200.6 per cent: two totalities and a remainder of six-tenths. Whatever the technical accounting behind the surplus, its form is philosophically exact. The first hundred per cent was not the whole; the second castle supplements it; and the supplement is itself supplemented by a fraction that belongs to neither. The game's measure of knowledge, pursued to its end, discloses that every whole it reported was partial.

Derrida's logic of the supplement names this structure. Reading Rousseau's *Confessions* in *De la grammatologie* (1967), Derrida followed Rousseau's "dangereux supplément" through its double sense of addition and substitution: the supplement is added to a plenitude that should not need it, and by being added reveals that the plenitude was lacking. The Inverted Castle is a supplement in this sense. Added to a castle that the false ending declared complete, it reveals that the first castle was never whole; and its own completion, at 200.6, is a further supplement that keeps the totality

Figure 10

Two Hundred Point Six



The arithmetic of the supplement (§4.10). A count one would expect to culminate at one hundred rises, once the Inverted Castle opens, to 200.6 per cent: two totalities and a remainder of six-tenths that belongs to neither. Drawn as a spiral, the remainder is the short red arc at its end.

open. The secret of the castle is not one hidden room among others but the impossibility of a final count. Kurt Gödel had proved in 1931 that any consistent formal system rich enough to express arithmetic contains true statements it cannot prove within itself. The castle's percentage is a game's figure of incompleteness: the system's measure of itself cannot close.

The excess has a moral as well as a logical meaning, which Benjamin articulated in an exchange with Max Horkheimer. Horkheimer wrote to him in March 1937 that past injustice is done and finished — the slain are truly slain — and that to declare the past incomplete is idealism. Benjamin answered, in a note for the *Passagen-Werk* (N 8,1), that history is not only a science but also a form of remembrance, *Eingedenken*, and that what science has established, remembrance can modify: it can make the incomplete, happiness, complete, and the complete, suffering, incomplete. "Das ist Theologie," he added — that is theology. *Symphony of the Night* stands with Benjamin. Lisa's death is a completed injustice, and the castle is its monument; but the son's remembrance — his carrying of her last words into the inverted house — renders the completed suffering incomplete, opening it to a recognition that the father's grief had foreclosed. The 200.6 per cent is the arithmetic of *Eingedenken*, a totality that remembrance has reopened.

The Japanese alphabet of impermanence offers a last gloss (§3.7). The *Iroha* contains every syllable once, a complete inventory, and its content is the transience of all things: the complete set teaches that nothing abides. The castle's completion figure teaches the same lesson from the other side. The more complete the knowledge, the more evident its excess, and the castle the player has measured to 200.6 per cent will in any case fall at dawn. Kant's first question thus receives a dhampiric answer. What can I know? I can know the world as far as my body can become what the world requires; I can know it by remembering, by searching, and by seeing through lenses that unveil rather than distort; I can know that every whole I map is exceeded by what it does not contain; and I can know that the deepest secret of the house I explore is the apparatus of my own exploring. Malraux's pile of secrets proves inexhaustible, and its inexhaustibility is not contemptible but the measure of a depth. From what can be known, the dissertation turns to what ought to be done.

V

Was soll ich tun?



Chapter Five

Was soll ich tun?

Lisa's Injunction, the Possessed Hero, and the Ethics of Mourning

The second of Kant's questions is answered in *Symphony of the Night* by a dead woman. Her word, carried by her son through the father's house and delivered at the father's death — do not hate humankind; if you cannot live among them, at least do them no harm, for their lot is already hard — is the ethical centre of the work, and every other figure in it can be measured by its distance from that word. This chapter reconstructs the game's ethics as an ethics of mourning, organized around a single opposition: the father, whose grief has become wrath, and the mother, whose suffering has become mercy. Between them stand the possessed hunter, who shows what becomes of those who fight monsters; the succubus, who counterfeits the mother's form; and the son, who must learn to tell the true word from its imitation, to strike the controller rather than the controlled, and to bring the father, at the last, to hear what his wrath had silenced. The argument proceeds from the anatomy of wrath (§5.1) through the injustice that provoked it (§§5.2–5.3), the corruption of the righteous (§§5.4–5.5), the prohibition of revenge (§5.6), the discernment of false compassion (§5.7), the philosophy of compassion itself (§5.8), the despair that compassion must answer (§5.9), and the reconciliation in which the ethics is consummated (§5.10).

5.1

The Wrath of the Widower: Dracula and the *Mēnis* of Achilles

◆

European literature begins with a grief that becomes a wrath. The first word of the *Iliad* is *mēnin*: "Sing, goddess, the wrath of Peleus' son Achilles, the accursed wrath that brought countless sorrows upon the Achaeans" (1.1–2). Leonard Muellner has argued that *mēnis* is no ordinary anger but a cosmic sanction, a wrath of the kind the poem otherwise attributes to gods, which threatens the order of the world against which it is directed (Muellner 1996). Achilles' *mēnis* has two objects. The first, against Agamemnon, withdraws him from the war; the second, after the death of Patroclus, returns him to it as an instrument of destruction. Grief does not soften him. He refuses food, drags Hector's corpse behind his chariot, and cuts the throats of twelve Trojan youths on Patroclus' pyre (23.175–176). The mourner becomes a slaughterer, and the poem does not conceal that his grief is the source of his savagery.

Dracula's war on humanity is a *mēnis* in Muellner's sense: the wrath of a being with a god's power, directed against the human order itself, born of the death of the beloved. A further Greek precedent sharpens the analogy. In the Homeric *Hymn to Demeter*, the goddess, grieving for the daughter whom Hades has carried off, withdraws from Olympus and makes the year terrible for mortals: the earth sends up no seed, and she would have destroyed the whole race of human beings by famine had Zeus not intervened (305–313). A divine mourner's grief nearly ends humanity, and the crisis is resolved by a compromise that institutes a cycle, Persephone spending part of each year below the earth and part above it. The castle's centennial return has the same form. Dracula's grief is not resolved but periodized; it returns, as Demeter's winter returns, on a schedule.

Japanese tradition gives the wrath of the wronged dead a name and a cult. The *onryō* is the vengeful spirit of one who died in injustice or bitterness, and the history of the Heian court was written in part in the language of their curses. Sugawara no Michizane, exiled on false charges in 901 and dead in exile two years later, was blamed for the plagues, droughts,

and lightning strikes that afflicted the capital and for the deaths of those who had ruined him, until the court restored his rank and enshrined him as Tenjin, the god of learning: the wrathful dead was pacified not by exorcism but by acknowledgment. The retired emperor Sutoku, defeated in the Hōgen disturbance of 1156 and exiled to Sanuki, is said in the *Hōgen Monogatari* to have copied sutras in his own blood and vowed to become a great demon of Japan; in "Shiramine," the first tale of Ueda Akinari's *Ugetsu Monogatari* (1776), the poet-monk Saigyō visits his tomb and meets his ghost, who boasts of the disasters his rage has brought upon the realm. The *onryō* is grief turned into a power over history, and its resolution, in the Japanese cult, is recognition rather than destruction.

Akinari offers, besides, the most exact Japanese portrait of a holy man turned monster by grief. In "Aozukin" ("The Blue Hood"), an abbot so loves a boy acolyte that when the boy dies he cannot bear to bury him; he caresses the corpse until it rots and eats its flesh, and becomes a demon who devours the dead of the village. The wandering Zen master Kaian seats him on a stone with a verse to ponder — the moon shines on the river, the wind blows through the pines; this long night, this clear evening, what is it for? — and returns a year later to find him still murmuring it, wasted to a skeleton; at a blow of Kaian's staff the abbot dissolves, leaving only bones and the blue hood. Attachment to the dead beloved transforms a man of religion into a devourer of the living and the dead; release comes on a moonlit night, through a word that loosens the attachment. Read beside "Aozukin," Dracula's story is the story of an attachment that has made its bearer a monster, waiting under the moon for the word that will release it.

5.2

The Witch-Fire: Lisa, Hypatia, Servetus

◆

The injustice that founds the castle is a burning. In the game's backstory, Lisa — a human woman, Dracula's wife, Alucard's mother — was condemned as a witch and executed by fire, and the father's war answers that fire. The scene belongs to a long European history in which learned, healing, or heterodox persons were destroyed by crowds and courts that

read their knowledge as diabolism. In Alexandria in 415, the philosopher and mathematician Hypatia was dragged from her carriage by a Christian mob, killed in a church, and her body torn apart and the pieces burned, as the church historian Socrates Scholasticus records with evident shame (*Historia ecclesiastica* VII.15). In 1431 — the year in which Dracula's father was invested with the Order of the Dragon, and about the year of Dracula's own birth (§2.1) — Joan of Arc was burned at Rouen as a relapsed heretic; a nullification trial annulled the verdict in 1456, and the Church canonized her in 1920: an institution's own *verkehrte Welt*, in which the punishment it had inflicted was inverted, too late, into honour. In 1553 the physician Michael Servetus was burned at Champel outside Geneva for his anti-Trinitarian theology, together with copies of his *Christianismi Restitutio*, the book in which, in the course of an argument about the divine spirit that dwells in the blood, he had described the pulmonary circulation. The man who discovered how the blood passes from the heart through the lungs died by fire for what he believed about the life in the blood. In 1600 Giordano Bruno burned in Rome (§4.3).

The great witch-hunts of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, legitimated by treatises such as Heinrich Kramer's *Malleus Maleficarum* (1486), killed tens of thousands, most of them women. Romantic historiography made of their victims a figure that still shapes the popular imagination, and that Lisa inherits. Jules Michelet's *La Sorcière* (1862) imagined the witch as the healer of the poor and the people's first physician — "Pendant mille ans, le seul médecin du peuple fut la Sorcière," for a thousand years the people's only doctor was the witch — persecuted by Church and state for her knowledge of herbs and of the body. Later historians have shown the picture to be largely a myth: the accused were seldom midwives or healers, and the persecutions were driven by local conflict and judicial procedure more than by any campaign against women's medicine (Harley 1990). But the myth names a truth the record confirms. The Jesuit Friedrich Spee, who had ministered to condemned witches in Franconia, published anonymously in 1631 the *Cautio Criminalis*, which argued that torture produces the confessions it seeks, that under such procedures anyone at all would confess, and that he had accompanied to the stake women he believed innocent. The witch trial is the confession of §4.4 at its most murderous: a machine for producing the guilt it presupposes.

René Girard made such persecutions the key to a theory of culture. *Le Bouc émissaire* (1982) opens with a fourteenth-century poem that describes the Black Death and, without any sign of doubt, the massacre of Jews accused of poisoning the wells; Girard reads it as the model "text of persecution," in which a community in crisis attributes its misfortune to a marginal victim, unites in violence against it, and so recovers its peace. The poem is Guillaume de Machaut's *Jugement du roy de Navarre* (c. 1349). The composer whose rondeau *Ma fin est mon commencement* opened this dissertation (§1.1) is also the author of the persecutors' testimony with which Girard's theory begins. In Girard's account the persecutors never see their victim's innocence, and the Gospels' decisive contribution was to reveal it, disclosing "things kept secret from the foundation of the world" (Matthew 13:35; Girard 1978). Lisa is a scapegoat in Girard's sense, and the game, like the Gospels in his reading, is told from the side of the victim. What it adds is the question his theory leaves open: what the victim's kin will do with the knowledge of her innocence.

The persecutory fire had a Japanese chapter, in inverted form. After the prohibition of Christianity in 1614, the shogunate hunted Japanese Christians with registers, inquisitions, and the trampling of sacred images, and in the Great Martyrdom at Nagasaki in 1622 dozens were executed, many by slow burning. In Japan the faith that had lit the European pyres was itself driven into the fire. A Japanese game that makes a woman burned by Christian townsfolk the origin of its tragedy writes from a history in which Christians were the burned as well as the burners — a history in which, as in the castle, every position can be turned over.

5.3

"Misery Made Me a Fiend": The Justified Monster

◆

The game grants its monster a justified grievance, and in this it belongs to the lineage of the most famous monster of the Romantic age. Mary Shelley — born on 30 August 1797, eleven days before her mother's death (§1.6) — gave the creature of *Frankenstein* (1818) the speech that founds the modern sympathy for monsters: "I was benevolent and good; misery made

me a fiend. Make me happy, and I shall again be virtuous." The creature's goodness is real, and it is destroyed by human cruelty: the cottagers who drive him off, the villagers who stone him, the man who shoots him for saving a drowning girl. Having read *Paradise Lost*, he knows his place in the story: "I ought to be thy Adam; but I am rather the fallen angel." Rousseau had set the premise in the first sentence of *Émile* (1762): "Tout est bien sortant des mains de l'Auteur des choses, tout dégénère entre les mains de l'homme" — everything is good as it leaves the hands of the Author of things; everything degenerates in the hands of man. The justified monster is Rousseau's natural goodness corrupted by society, and his violence is the return, upon society, of its own cruelty.

Dracula's claim is the creature's transposed from creation to bereavement. He was made a monster not by his maker's neglect but by his wife's killers, and his war on humanity answers their fire. The game does not dispute the grievance. Nowhere does it suggest that Lisa deserved her death, that her executioners acted in good faith, or that human beings are better than the vampire believes; its human figures are hunters, a possessed man, and a scheming priest, and the only wholly good human being in its story is the woman humanity burned. William Blake had observed that Milton wrote "in fetters when he wrote of Angels & God, and at liberty when of Devils & Hell," because he was "of the Devil's party without knowing it" (*The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*, 1790–1793). *Symphony of the Night* is of the devil's party knowingly, to the point of granting the devil his case. What it refuses is not the premise but the conclusion.

Hayao Miyazaki's *Mononoke-hime*, released in Japan four months after the game, gives the structure its most searching contemporary form. Its first image is a boar god, Nago, maddened by an iron ball lodged in his body by human guns and by hatred of the humans who are destroying the forest, transformed into a *tatarigami*, a curse-god, a seething mass of writhing tendrils. The young prince Ashitaka kills him to protect his village and receives his curse, which spreads through his arm and will in time kill him. The monster's rage is justified, the humans are guilty, and the hero who destroys the monster inherits its curse. Ashitaka's response is the film's ethical programme: to travel west and see the world with eyes unclouded by hatred, and, amid a war in which every party has its grievance, to take no

side but that of life. The film's monsters are justified and its humans guilty, and still it refuses revenge.

The justified monster poses the game's ethical problem in its sharpest form. If the grievance is true, on what ground can the response be refused? Not on the ground of human innocence, which the game nowhere asserts; not on the ground of the monster's malice, since his malice is his grief; and not on the ground of law, for the law that burned Lisa has no authority. The ground, as Chapter One anticipated (§1.5), is the condition of the guilty themselves: their lot is already hard. The refusal of revenge rests not on the merit of its objects but on their misery — a ground the following sections trace through the possessed hunter, the prohibition of the ghost, and the philosophy of compassion.

5.4

He Who Fights with Monsters: Richter, Recognition, and the Abyss

◆

The game's hunter becomes what he hunted, and Nietzsche gave the warning its canonical form: "Wer mit Ungeheuern kämpft, mag zusehn, dass er nicht dabei zum Ungeheuer wird. Und wenn du lange in einen Abgrund blickst, blickt der Abgrund auch in dich hinein" — whoever fights with monsters should see to it that he does not thereby become a monster; and if you gaze long into an abyss, the abyss also gazes into you (*Jenseits von Gut und Böse*, 1886, §146). Richter Belmont, the hero of 1792, is found in 1797 enthroned in the Castle Keep as the castle's lord. The fall is literal: the hunter occupies the throne of the hunted.

Hegel explains why the hunter is exposed to this fall. In the fourth chapter of the *Phänomenologie*, self-consciousness achieves certainty of itself only through recognition (*Anerkennung*) by another self-consciousness, and the struggle for recognition becomes a struggle of life and death that issues in the relation of master and servant, in which each depends on the other for the identity the struggle was meant to secure. The Belmonts are such a self-consciousness. Their identity exists only in relation to Dracula; every generation is defined by his return; and a Belmont with no

Dracula to fight is no one. The hunter needs the monster as the master needs the servant, and Shaft's possession of Richter exploits a dependency already present in the hunter's vocation. Alexandre Kojève's lectures on Hegel (1933–1939; published 1947) drew from this dialectic the thought of an end of history, after which the struggle for recognition would cease; in a note added to a later edition, after a visit to Japan in 1959, he imagined a post-historical humanity of pure formal values, of which Japanese "snobbery" was the model, and Azuma Hiroki would build his account of otaku culture on Kojève's distinction (Azuma 2001). A hunter after the end of the hunt is Kojève's post-historical man, and the possessed Richter is what such a man becomes when a priest offers him his history back.

Japanese legend preserves a scene in which the monster turns the charge of monstrosity against the hunter. In the story of Shuten-dōji, the demon king of Ōeyama, told in medieval narrative and in the Noh play *Ōeyama*, the warrior Minamoto no Raikō and his companions gain entry to the demon's stronghold disguised as mountain ascetics, ply him with drugged sake, and behead him as he sleeps. In the Noh the waking demon cries out against their deceit: they had promised there would be no falsehood, and yet — *kijin ni ōdō naki mono o* — among demons there is no crooked dealing. The demon accuses the heroes of a treachery demons do not practise, and the play lets the accusation stand. Dracula's *tu quoque* in the prologue (§1.1) is of this kind, and Richter's possession is its proof: the hunter's righteousness is no guarantee against becoming what it opposes.

The game's answer to the hunter's fall is an act of discrimination. Without the Holy Glasses, Alucard sees only a man who must be killed; with them, he sees the orb that controls the man, and he strikes the orb. The distinction is the one Augustine formulated in a letter on the correction of sinners: *cum dilectione hominum et odio vitiorum*, with love for persons and hatred of vices (*Epistula* 211.11). The game's ethics requires a way of seeing that separates the agent from what possesses him — the possessed hunter from the priest, the guilty crowd from the misery that drives it, the father from the grief that has made him a monster. It is the ethics of the Holy Glasses, and the first practical form of Lisa's injunction: to oppose evil without hating those through whom it acts.

5.5

The Marionette and the Orb: Kleist and Avatarial Possession

◆

The orb above Richter's head is a marionette's control, and the game's ethics of possession is best read through the most profound essay ever written about puppets. In Kleist's "Über das Marionettentheater" (1810), the principal dancer of the opera, Herr C., confesses his admiration for the marionettes of a street theatre. Their grace exceeds any dancer's, he explains, because the puppeteer moves only the centre of gravity, and the limbs follow as pure pendulums, free of the affectation that arises in a human body when the soul finds itself anywhere but at the centre of motion. Consciousness destroys grace: a youth who catches sight of himself in a mirror in the pose of the *Spinario* can never assume it again. Grace appears purest, C. concludes, in a body that has either no consciousness or an infinite one — "in dem Gliedermann, oder in dem Gott," in the jointed puppet or in the god — and humanity can recover it only by eating again of the tree of knowledge, to fall back into innocence: "das ist das letzte Kapitel von der Geschichte der Welt," that is the last chapter of the history of the world.

A videogame is a marionette theatre, and Kleist's essay describes its aesthetics with uncanny precision. The grace of Alucard's movement — the trailing cloak, the backward dash, the fluid arcs of leap and descent — is the grace of a figure moved from a centre outside itself, by a player whose will passes into the avatar without the affectation of a body's self-consciousness. The game also stages, in Richter, what the essay does not: the marionette as victim. Kant had made the relevant prohibition explicit twelve years before the castle's return: "Handle so, daß du die Menschheit, sowohl in deiner Person, als in der Person eines jeden andern, jederzeit zugleich als Zweck, niemals bloß als Mittel brauchest" — act so that you use humanity, in your own person as in the person of every other, always at the same time as an end, never merely as a means (*Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten*, 1785, Ak. 4:429). Possession is the paradigm of the forbidden: a person used wholly as a means, his body and will made the instrument of another's

purpose. Shaft's orb is the image of the violation of the formula of humanity.

What distinguishes the player's control of Alucard from the priest's control of Richter is consent. Bernard Suits defined playing a game as "the voluntary attempt to overcome unnecessary obstacles" (*The Grasshopper*, 1978), and the voluntariness is constitutive: the player adopts the game's goals in what Suits called the lusory attitude, and C. Thi Nguyen has described the result as an agency the player takes on for a time, as an actor takes on a role (Nguyen 2020). The possessed hunter is the anti-player, a body played without its consent. In revealing the orb, the Holy Glasses reveal the difference between play and possession; in striking it, Alucard restores to Richter the agency the priest had taken.

Two further images complete the analysis. In 1770 Wolfgang von Kempelen presented at the court of Vienna an automaton in Turkish costume that played chess against all comers; it toured Europe for decades, and in 1836 Poe argued, in "Maelzel's Chess-Player," that a human player must be hidden inside. Benjamin made the hoax the emblem of the first of his theses "Über den Begriff der Geschichte" (1940): a puppet in Turkish attire wins every game because a hunchbacked dwarf, a master of chess, sits concealed within and guides its hand by strings; the puppet called historical materialism, Benjamin wrote, can take on anyone if it enlists the services of theology, "die heute bekanntlich klein und häßlich ist und sich ohnehin nicht darf blicken lassen" — which today, as is well known, is small and ugly and must keep out of sight. In *Symphony of the Night* the hidden power that guides the hunter is literally a priest: theology, small and concealed, moves the puppet. The Japanese puppet theatre offers the opposite image. In *ningyō jōruri*, now called bunraku, the principal puppeteers work in full view of the audience, and Roland Barthes praised it for displaying the labour that Western puppetry conceals (*L'Empire des signes*, 1970). The Holy Glasses convert the castle's theatre from the European to the Japanese model: they make the operator visible. And once the operator is visible, the choice between striking the puppet and striking the hand that moves it becomes a moral choice.

5.6

The Inverted Ghost: *Hamlet* and the Prohibition of Revenge

◆

The ethical structure of *Symphony of the Night* is *Hamlet* inverted. In Shakespeare's tragedy a dead father returns as a ghost to command revenge: "I am thy father's spirit, / Doom'd for a certain term to walk the night" (1.5.9–10); "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" (1.5.25); "Remember me" (1.5.91). The son accepts the command and finds that it has unhinged time itself — "The time is out of joint; O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!" (1.5.188–189) — and the tragedy ends with the destruction of his house. In the game the dead parent is the mother, and her word inverts the ghost's: not revenge but its prohibition; not remember the crime but do not hate the criminals. The living parent, meanwhile, plays the ghost's part in the world, a father "doom'd for a certain term to walk the night," who returns on his centennial schedule to exact the vengeance he believes the dead require. The son stands between two parents as Hamlet stands between a ghost and a court, but the voice he obeys is the opposite of the one Hamlet obeyed, and the house that falls at the end falls without taking him with it.

Benjamin's *Trauerspiel* book culminates in Hamlet, the melancholic prince in whom alone, among the dramatis personae of the age, the Baroque mourning play finds a Christian resolution, his melancholy redeemed by being confronted rather than indulged (Benjamin 1928). Alucard is Hamlet's inverse in this as in the shape of the command. Hamlet's melancholy issues in delay and then in slaughter; Alucard's, which had withdrawn him from the world into sleep, issues in an act that ends a cycle of slaughter. Hamlet sets the time right by killing; Alucard sets it right by refusing to kill the man who stands in his way, and by bringing his father to hear what his wrath had silenced.

The prohibition of revenge is the more striking for the culture in which the game was made. Japan's most celebrated drama, *Kanadehon Chūshingura* (1748), stages the vendetta of the forty-seven *rōnin* of Akō, who in 1703 avenged their lord's enforced suicide by killing the official they held

responsible, and then accepted death themselves; their story of loyal revenge has been retold in every medium since. The *katakiuchi*, the sanctioned blood-revenge of the Edo period, remained legally recognized until its prohibition in 1873. Against a tradition that made revenge the supreme expression of fidelity to the dead, Lisa's word makes fidelity to the dead consist in the renunciation of revenge. The son honours his mother by not avenging her.

The Noh supplies the form in which this renunciation had been imagined in Japan long before the game. In Zeami's dream plays, the ghost of a warrior appears to a travelling monk, re-enacts the battle in which he died, and asks not for vengeance but for prayer; the play ends when the ghost, having relived his death in dance, departs toward release. The ghost of the Noh is Hamlet's father transformed by Buddhism, a revenant who asks the living not to kill on his behalf but to mourn for him. Section 5.10 returns to the most famous instance, *Atsumori*, in which the ghost raises his sword against the man who killed him and then lowers it. Lisa's command belongs to this family. She is a ghost who asks for mourning rather than revenge, and her son's fidelity to her takes the form the Japanese tradition calls *tomurai*, the care of the dead.

5.7

Kundry's Kiss: The Succubus and the Wisdom of Compassion

◆

The game tests its hero's fidelity to his mother by counterfeiting her. In the Inverted Castle, Alucard passes into a dreamlike scene in which his mother appears to him; the figure is a succubus wearing Lisa's form, and the son sees through the imposture and destroys it. The succubus belongs to the oldest demonology of the Christian West — Augustine records, with cautious credence, the widespread belief in spirits who assail human beings in sexual form (*De civitate Dei* XV.23), and the *Malleus Maleficarum* systematized it — but the game's use of the figure is precise. The demon does not appear as a stranger but as the beloved dead. The temptation is not desire alone but the counterfeit of the very voice the son has carried into the

castle: a false mother who would make of his love for her the instrument of his ruin.

Wagner had staged this temptation as the crisis of *Parsifal* (1882). In the second act, the sorcerer Klingsor sends Kundry to seduce the innocent hero in a magic garden, and she approaches him through his mother: she tells him of Herzeleide, who died of grief when he left her, and offers him, as his mother's last blessing, love's first kiss — "als Muttersegens letzten Gruß, der Liebe ersten Kuß." At the kiss Parsifal starts back, crying out the name of Amfortas, the wounded king whose suffering he had witnessed without understanding: the kiss meant to ensnare him gives him instead the knowledge of another's pain. So the work's prophecy is fulfilled: "durch Mitleid wissend, der reine Tor," made wise through compassion, the pure fool. The seduction through the mother's image issues in compassionate insight; the false mother teaches, against her purpose, what the true mother would have taught. Wagner had read Schopenhauer in 1854, and *Parsifal* is the Schopenhauerian drama of *Mitleid* (§5.8).

The scene requires what the Christian tradition called the discernment of spirits. "Satan himself is transformed into an angel of light," Paul warns (2 Corinthians 11:14), and "believe not every spirit, but try the spirits whether they are of God" (1 John 4:1); Ignatius of Loyola's rules for discernment in the *Spiritual Exercises* (1548) taught that the evil spirit counterfeits consolation and must be known by where its counsel leads. Alucard's criterion is his memory of the true mother. The memory the castle has restored to him (§4.3) becomes the touchstone by which a false image of the beloved is known for what it is: anamnesis is also discernment. The dhampir who carries his mother's word cannot be seduced by her likeness, because he knows the likeness by the word.

Japanese legend sets the true monster-mother against the false. In "Yuki-Onna," retold by Lafcadio Hearn in *Kwaidan* (1904), the woman of the snow kills an old woodcutter in a winter storm and spares his young apprentice, Minokichi, on condition that he never speak of what he saw. Years later, married to a beautiful woman named O-Yuki and the father of ten children, he tells her the story one night — and she reveals herself as the snow woman. She would kill him, she says, but for the children; she spares him for their sake, and vanishes. The monster here is the true mother, and her compassion for her children overrides both her vengeance and her law.

The game sets the two figures in counterpoint: the succubus, a monster who wears a mother's face to destroy a son, and Lisa, a human mother whose word to her son is mercy. Between them Alucard learns the difference between a love that consumes and a love that spares.

5.8

Mitleid: Schopenhauer and the *Compagnon de Misères*

◆

Lisa's word is a philosophy of compassion compressed into a sentence, and its fullest European articulation is Schopenhauer's. In the prize essay *Über die Grundlage der Moral* (1840), Schopenhauer argued that only actions arising from compassion, *Mitleid*, have genuine moral worth: egoism seeks one's own good and malice another's harm, but compassion takes another's suffering immediately as one's own motive, without reasoning or calculation. This everyday phenomenon he called "das große Mysterium der Ethik," the great mystery of ethics — mysterious because in it the barrier between individuals, which reason cannot remove, is removed in feeling. In *Die Welt als Wille und Vorstellung* (1819) he had gone further, holding that all true and pure love is compassion (§66), and he found the metaphysical formula of the experience in the Upanishadic *tat tvam asi*, "that thou art," which he read in Anquetil-Duperron's Latin version of the Upanishads, the *Oupnek'hat* of 1801–1802. In the suffering other, I recognize myself.

The anthropology on which this ethics rests is the one Dracula states and Lisa revalues. For Schopenhauer life is suffering, the will's endless striving punctuated by satisfactions that decay into boredom; human beings are wretched; and it is precisely their wretchedness that makes compassion the fitting attitude toward them. Hence his proposal in *Parerga und Paralipomena* (1851, II, §156) that the proper form of address between human beings would be "Leidensgefährte, Soci malorum, compagnon de misères, my fellow-sufferer," because the reminder of our common misery would teach the tolerance, patience, forbearance, and love of neighbour that each needs and each owes. Lisa's sentence is this salutation turned into a commandment: humanity's lot is already hard, so do it no harm. Rousseau

had grounded morality in the same feeling a century before, finding in *pitié*, the natural repugnance to see a sentient being suffer, a virtue prior to reflection that tempers the love of self (*Discours sur l'origine de l'inégalité*, 1755).

Dracula's position has its philosopher too. Nietzsche, Schopenhauer's apostate disciple, attacked compassion as a depressive affect that multiplies suffering and preserves what is failing — "die Praxis des Nihilismus," the practice of nihilism (*Der Antichrist*, 1888, §7) — and made pity the last temptation of Zarathustra. The vampire's contempt for the miserable little pile of secrets is Nietzschean in this sense: misery, for him, disqualifies. The game stages the quarrel between Schopenhauer and Nietzsche as a quarrel between mother and father, and gives the last word to the mother. It does so, significantly, without denying the father's premise. Lisa does not dispute that human beings are wretched; she draws the opposite conclusion from their wretchedness.

Japanese religious culture gave this ethics a maternal face. The bodhisattva Kannon (Avalokiteśvara), "the one who perceives the cries of the world," embodies *jihi*, the compassion of the Buddhist tradition, and is among the most widely venerated figures of Japanese Buddhism. During the two and a half centuries in which Christianity was proscribed in Japan, communities of hidden Christians, *kakure kirishitan*, venerated the Virgin in the guise of Kannon, in white porcelain statues of the bodhisattva holding a child that the authorities could not distinguish from Buddhist images: the so-called Maria Kannon. A figure at once Mary and Kannon, kept hidden for generations, is the perfect icon of a compassion that survives persecution by concealment — a pile of secrets that preserved a faith. Endō Shūsaku, the great Japanese Catholic novelist, built his theology on the contrast between a paternal God of judgment and a maternal God of forgiveness. In *Chinmoku* (*Silence*, 1966), a Portuguese priest under persecution tramples a sacred image to save tortured peasants, at the bidding of a Christ who wills to be trampled for their sake; in the stories and essays of *Haha naru mono* (1969), Endō argued that Japanese religious sensibility sought in God a mother who forgives rather than a father who condemns. *Symphony of the Night* is, in this sense, an Endōan work. Its paternal principle judges and condemns humanity; its maternal principle forgives; and the redemption of the father comes through the mother's word.

5.9

Devilman's Despair and Lisa's Counter-Testimony

• ◆ •

Japanese popular culture had already told the story of a hybrid who loses his beloved to a human mob, and had drawn the conclusion that Lisa forbids. Go Nagai's *Devilman* (1972–1973) begins with a boy, Akira Fudō, who fuses with the demon Amon and becomes a devilman, a being with a demon's body and a human heart — a dhampir by possession rather than by birth. His closest friend, Ryō Asuka, is revealed in the end as Satan himself, an angel of hermaphroditic beauty who loves Akira. As the existence of the demons becomes known, humanity turns on itself: governments and crowds hunt suspected demons and torture and massacre their neighbours, and in the work's most notorious sequence a mob breaks into the house of Akira's beloved, Miki Makimura, kills her and her younger brother, and parades her severed head. Akira, finding her remains, renounces the humanity he had fought to protect. In the final pages the world has been destroyed, and Satan sits beside the ruined body of the friend he loved, mourning him too late.

Devilman is the story of Dracula told from the hybrid's side, and its conclusion is Dracula's: human beings, seized by fear of the monstrous, become more monstrous than the monsters they fear, and do not deserve to be saved. Its witch-hunt is Lisa's burning universalized; its androgynous Satan, lover of the hybrid hero, is a figure that the androgyne of Chapter Three illuminates; and its ending is the apocalypse Dracula's war is meant to bring. The game is hard to imagine without this background, which shaped two decades of Japanese apocalyptic fiction (Chapter Six). What distinguishes it is that it gives the decisive word to the victim of the mob. Lisa is Miki: the beloved woman destroyed by a crowd that saw a monster in her. But where Akira speaks, over Miki's remains, for the living who have lost her, Lisa speaks for herself. Her word is a counter-testimony against *Devilman*'s verdict, delivered by the one witness whose right to condemn humanity no one could dispute — and she declines to exercise it.

The authority of this refusal is the authority of the victim. Hannah Arendt argued that forgiveness is the remedy for the irreversibility of action,

the only release from the chain of consequences a deed sets loose, and credited its discovery in the realm of human affairs to Jesus of Nazareth (*The Human Condition*, 1958, §33). Vladimir Jankélévitch held that certain crimes are inexpiable and that forgiveness can come only from their victims, who in the case of the dead are beyond asking (*Pardonner?*, 1971). Jacques Derrida pressed the paradox to its limit: forgiveness, if there is such a thing, forgives only the unforgivable, for to forgive the forgivable is merely to excuse (Derrida 1999). Lisa's word satisfies each of these conditions. It comes from the victim herself; it is spoken before her death, so that the dead woman has in a sense already been asked; and it forgives what cannot be forgiven — her own burning — for the sake of those who burned her. Paul Ricoeur called such forgiveness "difficult," a gift that exceeds any economy of exchange and must be received rather than demanded (*La Mémoire, l'histoire, l'oubli*, 2000).

Testimony carries the word. Lisa cannot speak in the castle; her son speaks for her, and the game's ethics depends on his fidelity as a witness. Ricoeur placed testimony at the root of historical knowledge, as the point at which the memory of one becomes the knowledge of others; the game places it at the root of ethical action. Alucard does not invent his mother's mercy, nor argue for it; he transmits it, unaltered, across the castle, to the one person who most needs to hear it and is least willing to. *Devilman* ends with a mourner who comes too late. *Symphony of the Night* ends with a witness who comes in time.

5.10

Priam's Tears and *Atsumori*'s Prayer: Reconciliation at the Father's Death

◆

The game's ethics is consummated in a reconciliation between enemies across a death, and its two great precedents stand at the end of the *Iliad* and at the heart of the Noh. The *Iliad*, which began with wrath, ends with tears. In the twenty-fourth book, Priam, king of Troy, crosses the plain by night under the guidance of Hermes, enters the tent of Achilles, and kisses the hands that killed his sons: "I have endured what no other mortal on

earth has yet endured, to raise to my lips the hand of the man who killed my sons" (24.505–506). Achilles, thinking of his own father, Peleus, whom he will never see again, weeps with him, the two enemies grieving together, one for a son and the other for a father and a friend. Then Achilles speaks the poem's anthropology: "ὡς γὰρ ἐπεκλώσαντο θεοὶ δειλοῖσι βροτοῖσι / ζώειν ἀχνυμένοις· αὐτοὶ δέ τ' ἀκηδέες εἰσί" — for so the gods have spun the thread for wretched mortals, that they should live in grief, while they themselves are free of care (24.525–526). He tells of the two jars that stand on the threshold of Zeus, one of evils and one of blessings, from which mortals receive a mixture, or evils alone. The wrath of Achilles ends not when it is defeated but when it recognizes, in the enemy's grief, its own. He returns Hector's body; the two eat together; and they look upon each other with wonder (24.629–632). Simone Weil, writing in 1940, called the *Iliad* the poem of force, which turns human beings into things, and found its greatness in a bitterness that falls equally on all, Greek and Trojan alike (Weil 1940–1941). The reconciliation of Priam and Achilles rests on that equality: the recognition of a common misery, *compagnon de misères*.

Zeami's *Atsumori* (early fifteenth century) gives the scene its Buddhist form. In the *Heike Monogatari*, the warrior Kumagai no Naozane, at the battle of Ichi-no-tani in 1184, unhorses a young Taira noble and tears off his helmet to behead him, and finds a boy of sixteen or so, the age of his own son. Unable to spare him without dishonour, he kills him, finds a flute at his waist, and in remorse leaves the warrior's life to become a monk under the name Renshō. In the Noh, years later, Renshō returns to Ichi-no-tani to pray for Atsumori's soul and meets his ghost, who re-enacts the night before the battle and his own death, and at the climax rises against his killer with drawn sword. Then he lowers it. The man who killed him has prayed for him; one who repays enmity with kindness is no longer an enemy; they will be reborn together on the same lotus. The ghost's last words are a recognition and a request: *kataki nite wa nakarikeri* — he was no enemy after all — and pray for me. The vengeance owed by the dead is renounced in favour of mourning, and killer and killed are bound together in the care of the dead.

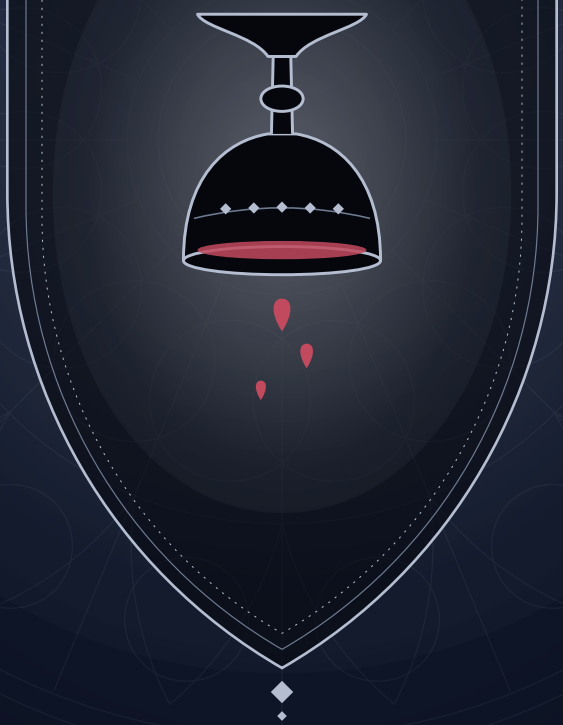
Symphony of the Night joins the two scenes. When Dracula falls for the last time, Alucard tells him what Lisa said at her death: her plea that their son not hate humankind, and her abiding love for her husband. The father,

who had made the world pay for her death, learns that she had asked the world to be spared and that she had loved him to the end; he asks her forgiveness, bids his son farewell, and dies. The *mēnis* that founded the castle ends as Achilles' did, not in defeat but in recognition — the recognition, through the beloved's word, that the grief he had turned against humanity was a grief she had refused to turn against anyone. It ends as Atsumori's did, with the sword lowered, the enemy forgiven, and the living charged with the care of the dead. The father is redeemed by hearing, the son by speaking; and the mother, absent from every scene, is present in the one word that makes the last scene possible.

The answer to Kant's second question follows. What ought I to do? Not to love humanity for its merits, which the game nowhere affirms; not to obey the law of the crowd that burned the innocent; not to avenge, though the grievance be just. I ought to see the person apart from what possesses him, and strike the possession; to refuse revenge in fidelity to the dead; to discern the true voice of compassion from its counterfeit; to recognize in the misery of others my own; and to carry the word of the victim to those who most need and least wish to hear it. Kant's own doctrine of virtue held that we have an indirect duty to cultivate compassion, and therefore not to avoid the places — the sickroom, the debtors' prison — where the suffering are to be found (*Tugendlehre* §35). Alucard's journey through the castle fulfils that duty in the house of the one who most needed compassion and least deserved it: his father. From what ought to be done, the dissertation turns to what may be hoped.

VI

Was darf ich hoffen?



Chapter Six

Was darf ich hoffen?

The Vampire as Critic, the Dark Priest, and the Eschatology of the Undead

The third of Kant's questions belongs, in his architectonic, to religion, and *Symphony of the Night* is saturated with religion while trusting none of its institutions. Its vampire is a critic of faith; its villainous agent is a priest; its weapons are sacred objects gathered indiscriminately from several traditions; its castle contains a chapel, a confessional, and a library turned forbidden; and its climax is a descent, through an inverted world, to the dismembered body of a father who has defied God. This chapter reads the game's religious imagination in eleven movements: the vampire as hermeneut of suspicion (§6.1); the inverted Eucharist (§6.2); the dark priest (§6.3); the syncretic arsenal (§6.4); Death as servant (§6.5); the theology of defiance (§6.6); the Gnostic castle (§6.7); the dismembered father (§6.8); Dante's inversion and the harrowing of hell (§6.9); the centennial return (§6.10); and the apocalyptic imaginary of the Japan in which the game was made (§6.11). Its thesis is that the game passes through the critique of religion to a hope that critique does not abolish: not the hope of an end of the world, which its villain pursues, but the hope that punishment can be turned into pardon.

6.1

The Vampire as Hermeneut of Suspicion: Voltaire, Feuerbach, Marx, Nietzsche

◆

The vampire of the prologue speaks as the Enlightenment's critic of religion. When Richter accuses him of stealing souls and enslaving human beings, Dracula answers that the same might be said of every faith (§1.1): the hunter's sacred cause is, on the vampire's account, another form of the domination it condemns. The charge has a precise genealogy. Voltaire, signing his letters with the abbreviated war-cry *Écrasez l'infâme*, made the persecuting Church the enemy of reason and humanity, and his campaign for Jean Calas — a Protestant merchant of Toulouse broken on the wheel in 1762 on the false charge of murdering his son to prevent his conversion, and posthumously rehabilitated in 1765 — dramatized the argument of the *Traité sur la tolérance* (1763): that religious zeal makes executioners of judges. The Voltaire who held that the true vampires lived in palaces (§2.2) supplies the vampire's argument that the real bloodsuckers are those who rule in God's name.

Ludwig Feuerbach gave the critique its method. *Das Wesen des Christentums* (1841) argued that God is the human essence projected, alienated, and worshipped as another, and the "Vorläufige Thesen zur Reformation der Philosophie" (1842) condensed the argument into a formula: "Das Geheimnis der Theologie ist die Anthropologie" — the secret of theology is anthropology. The formula answers the game's first question with its fourth. If the secret of God is man, then Dracula's "What is a man?" is the question to which all religion's secrets refer. Feuerbach's method, moreover, is an inversion. We need only make the predicate the subject, he wrote, "also die spekulative Philosophie nur umkehren, so haben wir die unverhüllte, die pure, blanke Wahrheit" — only invert speculative philosophy, and we have the unveiled, pure, naked truth. Inversion as unveiling: Feuerbach's transformative method is the Holy Glasses and the Inverted Castle in a single sentence (§§4.7–4.8).

Marx sharpened the critique into a theory of suffering: "Das religiöse Elend ist in einem der Ausdruck des wirklichen Elendes und in einem die

Protestation gegen das wirkliche Elend. Die Religion ist der Seufzer der bedrängten Kreatur, das Gemüt einer herzlosen Welt, wie sie der Geist geistloser Zustände ist. Sie ist das Opium des Volkes" — religious misery is at once the expression of real misery and the protest against it; religion is the sigh of the oppressed creature, the heart of a heartless world, the spirit of spiritless conditions; it is the opium of the people (*Zur Kritik der Hegelschen Rechtsphilosophie*, Einleitung, 1844). The passage is less contemptuous than its last sentence suggests. Its key word is *Elend*, misery, and it reads religion as a symptom of the very wretchedness that Dracula despises and Lisa pities (§1.5). Marx's critique contains, in its sigh and its heart, the compassion it would redirect from heaven to earth — and Marx, as Chapter One recalled (§1.7), was the theorist who called capital a vampire.

Nietzsche turned the critique against compassion itself. The madman of *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* (1882, §125) runs into the marketplace with a lantern in broad morning to announce "Gott ist todt! Gott bleibt todt! Und wir haben ihn getödtet!"; *Zur Genealogie der Moral* (1887) read Christianity as a priestly inversion of aristocratic values, a slave revolt in morality in which the weak called their weakness good; and *Der Antichrist* named Christianity the vampire of the Roman Empire (§58). Dracula is a Nietzschean aristocrat in this sense: he despises a faith that sanctifies weakness and pities the miserable. Paul Ricoeur grouped Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud as the masters of suspicion (Ricoeur 1965), and the vampire of the prologue speaks in all their voices. But Ricoeur also held that critique could open the way to a second naivety, a renewed hearing of the symbols it had stripped (§1.7). The game takes that path. It grants the vampire every argument against the religion that burned his wife, and then answers him not with a counter-argument but with a word of mercy spoken by the victim of that religion — a word religious in form and in content, though spoken by no institution.

6.2
The Inverted Eucharist

The vampire's sacrament is the Eucharist inverted, and the inversion is double. Mosaic law forbade the eating of blood because blood is life: "For the life of the flesh is in the blood ... ye shall eat the blood of no manner of flesh: for the life of all flesh is the blood thereof" (Leviticus 17:11, 14). The Gospel overturned the prohibition in the most scandalous of its sayings: "Whoso eateth my flesh, and drinketh my blood, hath eternal life" (John 6:54). The vampire overturns the overturning. Where Christ gives his own blood that others may live eternally, the vampire takes others' blood that he may live without end; where the Eucharist is a gift that founds a community, vampirism is a theft that founds a solitude. The Fourth Lateran Council (1215) defined the change of bread and wine into body and blood as transubstantiation, and the later Middle Ages surrounded the consecrated host with miracles of bleeding — that of Bolsena (1263), which the feast of Corpus Christi (1264) followed, is the most famous — and with accusations, directed against Jews, of profaning hosts until they bled, accusations that ended in massacres of the kind Girard analysed (§5.2). The blood of the sacrament and the blood of persecution flowed in the same imagination.

Stoker made the inversion explicit. In the twenty-first chapter of *Dracula*, the Count forces Mina Harker to drink from a wound he has opened in his breast, and names her in the language of marriage and sacrament: "flesh of my flesh; blood of my blood; kin of my kin; my bountiful wine-press for a while." The scene parodies the tenderest image of eucharistic piety, the pelican who, according to the *Physiologus*, revives her dead young with blood from her own breast, and whom the hymn *Adoro te devote* addresses as Christ himself: "Pie pellicane, Iesu Domine, / Me immundum munda tuo sanguine" — loving pelican, Lord Jesus, cleanse me, unclean, with your blood. The vampire's breast feeds in order to enslave. The Gothic tradition supplied the liturgy that accompanies it, the Black Mass, an inverted Mass performed over a profaned altar, of which the ceremonies alleged against the Abbé Guibourg in the Affair of the Poisons at the court

of Louis XIV (1679–1680) and the rite celebrated by Canon Docre in Huysmans's *Là-bas* (1891) are the historical and literary poles.

Symphony of the Night opens with the chalice of this anti-sacrament. In the prologue Dracula holds a goblet of wine as he disputes with Richter, and dashes it down as the duel begins: the vampire's cup, raised in the throne room and broken before the ordeal, is the inverted chalice that frames the work. The game's treatment of its own hero's appetite, by contrast, is discreet and exact. Alucard is never shown drinking human blood. He eats ordinary food, and the vampiric powers the game allows him — spells that draw life from the creatures he strikes — are exercised only on the denizens of his father's castle. The dhampir feeds, if he feeds at all, on the father's servants and never on the humans his mother asked him to spare. His relation to blood is the vampire's turned against the vampire: the retrograde of feeding.

The strangeness of the Eucharist was felt with particular force in Japan. When the Jesuit mission brought the Mass to Japan from 1549, the sacrament of a God whose flesh is eaten and whose blood is drunk could be heard by hostile ears as a rite of cannibalism and sorcery, and popular rumour in the age of the anti-Christian edicts credited the foreigners with drinking blood — the red wine of the altar read as what the liturgy said it was. A Japanese game whose villain is a vampire who scorns the Church, whose hero is a half-vampire who abstains, and whose arsenal includes the holy water of Catholic exorcism, inherits a long Japanese uncertainty about whether the Christian cup holds wine or blood.

6.3

The Dark Priest: Ambrosio, Schedoni, Frollo, Shaft

THE AGENT of evil in *Symphony of the Night* is not the vampire but a priest. Shaft, the cleric who in 1792 performed the rite that raised Dracula and who in 1797 possesses Richter, is the instrument of every catastrophe the game narrates: the vampire's return, the hunter's corruption, the castle's appearance before its time. In the prologue's aetiology, the vampire insisted

that he had been called back by human beings who wished to pay him tribute (§1.1); the human being who called him was a priest. Religion thus produces the monster twice in the game's story — once by burning his wife and once by summoning him — and the vampire's indictment of faith is, at the level of plot, borne out.

The figure belongs to the Gothic's founding typology. Matthew Lewis's *The Monk* (1796) made a revered Capuchin abbot, Ambrosio, the protagonist of a descent through seduction, rape, matricide, and incest, engineered by a demon in a woman's shape; at the end Satan reveals the secret of his victims' identity — the girl he violated and killed was his sister, the woman he murdered his mother — and casts him from a precipice. Ann Radcliffe's *The Italian, or the Confessional of the Black Penitents* (1797), written partly in answer to Lewis, made its villain a confessor, Schedoni, whose concealed past contains a fratricide, and opened with English travellers in a Neapolitan church learning of a confession once made in a certain confessional so terrible that it shook the priest who heard it. Victor Hugo's *Notre-Dame de Paris* (1831) gave the type its most influential form in the archdeacon Claude Frollo, scholar and alchemist, who, consumed by desire for the dancer Esmeralda, brings about her condemnation as a witch, and is hurled from the cathedral's tower by Quasimodo as she hangs. The dark priest is the confessor who weaponizes secrets, the scholar who turns knowledge to domination, and, in Frollo, the cleric who has a woman condemned for witchcraft: the burner of Lisa given a face.

Hugo's novel contains, besides, a meditation that bears on the game's medium. In the chapter "Ceci tuera cela" (V.2), the archdeacon, looking from the printed book on his table to the cathedral beyond his window, declares that this will kill that: the book will kill the building, and printing supplant architecture as the great book of humanity. *Symphony of the Night* reverses the prophecy. A medium of the century after Hugo's turns the book back into a building, making architecture once more the form in which a culture's memory and knowledge can be read (§4.3). The castle is the cathedral resurrected by the medium that, in Hugo's sense, should have finished it off.

Nietzsche supplies the theory of the dark priest's power. The ascetic priest of the *Genealogie der Moral* (1887, III, §15) is the shepherd of the sick, who rules by changing the direction of their *ressentiment*: to the suffering

who cry that someone must be to blame, he answers that they are right, and that they themselves are that someone, and so turns their pain into the instrument of his dominion. Shaft performs exactly this operation on the hunter. He takes the need that defines the Belmont vocation — the need for a monster to fight (§5.4) — and redirects it, until the hunter serves the monster's return. The dark priest is the one who knows what the righteous need and makes their righteousness his instrument. The game's response is not to abolish religion but to separate it from the priest: the word that undoes Shaft's work is spoken by a laywoman, a supposed witch, whose mercy is the religion the priests betrayed.

6.4

The Syncretic Arsenal: Cross, Bible, Holy Water, *Vibhūti*, *Agni*

◆

The weapons with which the castle is fought are a pantheon. Alucard's secondary arms, inherited from the series' sacred armoury, include the Cross, which flies out and returns to the hand that threw it; the Bible, which circles its bearer like an orbiting shield; and Holy Water, the sacramental of Catholic exorcism, whose vials burst into flame where they shatter. Beside these stand two weapons named from Hinduism: the *Vibhuti*, the sacred ash of Shaiva devotion, and the *Agunea*, a bolt named for Agni, the Vedic god of fire. His swords form a second pantheon. The Muramasa, named for the smith whose blades legend credits with a thirst for blood, grows stronger as it drinks; the Masamune bears the name of the smith whom legend made Muramasa's serene opposite; Gram, Balmung, and Tyrfing come from Norse and German heroic legend; Mourneblade from Michael Moorcock's tales of the doomed albino prince Elric; Gurthang from Tolkien; and the Vorpal Blade from "Jabberwocky," the poem Lewis Carroll printed in mirror-writing in *Through the Looking-Glass* (§1.3), whose boy hero slays the monster with it. The castle's armoury is a *musée imaginaire* of the sacred and the legendary, in which the instruments of incompatible traditions are ranged side by side.

The arrangement is not confusion but a recognizable religious logic, and its home is Japan. For more than a millennium before the Meiji government's edicts separating Shinto from Buddhism (1868), Japanese religious practice joined kami and buddhas in a single system, *shinbutsu shūgō*, and theorized the kami as local manifestations of buddhas and bodhisattvas, *honji suijaku*. Ian Reader and George Tanabe have described the common religion of Japan as oriented toward practical benefits, *genze riyaku*, sought from whatever shrine, temple, or amulet promises them (Reader and Tanabe 1998). The castle's sacred weapons are amulets in this sense: efficacious against evil whatever their origin, and valued for what they do rather than for the creed that produced them. The game's syncretism is a syncretism of efficacy.

The weapons' meanings nonetheless repay reading one by one, for together they compose an argument. The Cross returns: a boomerang is a retrograde in flight, and the sign of the crucifixion becomes, in the series' hands, a weapon that comes back. The Bible is the word made projectile, a literalization of Hebrews 4:12 — "the word of God is quick, and powerful, and sharper than any twoedged sword" — and of Paul's "sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God" (Ephesians 6:17). Holy Water is water that burns. *Vibhūti* is ash, the residue of fire: Shiva, the ascetic god who reduced Kāma, the god of desire, to ashes with the fire of his third eye, is depicted smeared with the ash of the cremation ground, and the devotee who marks his brow with it bears a sign of the body's impermanence. Agni is the fire of sacrifice and of the funeral pyre, the messenger who carries offerings to the gods and the dead to their ancestors; the Rig Veda's funeral hymn asks him not to consume the dead man utterly but to bear him on to the Fathers (10.16). In a game whose founding injustice is a woman burned alive, the arsenal includes ash and the god of the pyre. The fire that destroyed Lisa returns in the son's hands as the purifying fire that conveys the dead.

The armoury thus restates in its own register the game's verdict on religion. No tradition owns the sacred, and none is exempt from turning it to persecution; but the instruments of every tradition can be taken up against the evil that persecution serves. The dhampir fights his father's house with the relics of the faith whose adherents burned his mother, and with those of faiths that had no part in her death — a catholicity of arms that is also, in the end, a catholicity of mercy.

6.5

Death in Livery: The *Danse Macabre* Inverted

◆

The figure of Death in *Symphony of the Night* is a servant. He meets Alucard at the castle gate and strips him of his arms, he speaks as the retainer of his master's house, and he fights the son as an officer of the father. The medieval imagination had made Death the universal sovereign. In the *danse macabre* painted on the cloister walls of the Cimetière des Innocents in Paris in 1424–1425 and printed by Guyot Marchant in 1485, and in the woodcuts Hans Holbein designed in the 1520s and published at Lyon in 1538, Death comes for pope and emperor, king and abbess, merchant and child, and leads each away in the same dance: the great leveller, before whom rank is nothing. The game inverts the dance. Its Death wears livery; the leveller has become an aristocrat's retainer. That is the vampire's essence. The undead lord is the one being who has made Death his servant, and his castle is the house in which the democracy of mortality has been abolished.

Hegel had named Death the absolute master. In the dialectic of master and servant, the servant's consciousness is formed because it "hat die Furcht des Todes, des absoluten Herrn, empfunden" — it has felt the fear of death, the absolute master (*Phänomenologie*, IV A) — and that fear, together with labour, educates the servant toward freedom. Dracula's household inverts Hegel's hierarchy: the absolute master is himself a servant, and the lord of the castle has made the master of all lords his domestic. The servant's education is therefore impossible in this house, since no one in it can learn from the fear of death when Death obeys its owner. Only the dhampir, who belongs half to mortality, can bring into the castle the lesson the castle has abolished.

Folklore knew how one might bargain with Death, and its most famous tale turns on an inversion. In the Grimms' "Der Gevatter Tod" (*Kinder- und Hausmärchen*, no. 44), Death stands godfather to a poor man's son and makes him a physician: if Death stands at the head of a patient's bed, the patient must die; if at the foot, he will live. Twice the physician cheats his godfather by turning the patient round in the bed, so that Death finds

himself at the feet; and Death leads him, in punishment, to a cavern where the lives of all human beings burn as candles, and lets his candle go out. The tale passed to Japan and became, in a rakugo by San'yūtei Enchō of the Meiji period — adapted, it is generally held, from the Grimms' tale by way of a European intermediary — the story of "Shinigami," in which the hero turns a sickbed round to cheat a death-god and ends in a cave of candles, where his flame dies. The death-god of modern Japanese popular culture is thus partly an import from Europe, and its founding tale is a tale of rotation: a body turned through half a circle to put Death at the wrong end. The castle that turns over, the candles that line its corridors, and the liveried Death who serves its lord form a constellation with this tale. In the Inverted Castle the bed of the world is turned round, and whether Death stands at its head or at its foot is the question the second half decides.

The game's Death also performs the castle's first act, the stripping of the hero at the threshold (§1.5), which Chapter Seven will read as *kenōsis*. Here it suffices to note its theological irony. In the *danse macabre*, Death strips every rank of its insignia; in the game, Death strips the son of the house of his inherited arms, so that he must enter as a servant the house in which Death himself serves. The leveller's last office is to make the prince begin from nothing.

6.6

Non Serviam: Milton's Satan and Kierkegaard's Demonic Defiance

◆

Dracula's war is a refusal of God, and the theology of refusal has a name: *non serviam*, I will not serve. The Vulgate gives the words to rebellious Israel (Jeremiah 2:20), Christian tradition gave them to Lucifer, and Joyce's Stephen Dedalus would make them the motto of a modern apostasy, declaring that he will not serve that in which he no longer believes, "whether it call itself my home, my fatherland or my church" (*A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man*, 1916). Milton's Satan gave the refusal its grandeur — "Better to reign in Hell, than serve in Heav'n" (*Paradise Lost* I. 263) — and its psychology: "The mind is its own place, and in it self / Can

make a Heav'n of Hell, a Hell of Heav'n" (I.254–255). But the Satan of the soliloquy on Mount Niphates is not grand but wretched: "Me miserable! which way shall I flie / Infinite wrauth, and infinite despaire? / Which way I flie is Hell; my self am Hell" (IV.73–75). The rebel's defiance is sustained by a misery he cannot leave, and he resolves it only by inverting his values: "Evil be thou my Good" (IV.110). Dracula's anthropology — the miserable little pile of secrets — is the projection onto humanity of the misery Milton's Satan finds in himself.

Byron's *Manfred* (1817) gave the defiant mourner his Romantic form. Manfred, a magus tormented by guilt for the death of Astarte, the woman he loved and whose death he caused, commands spirits, defies the infernal powers, and has her phantom raised so that he may beg her forgiveness; she speaks his name, foretells his death on the morrow, and bids him farewell, but will not say that she forgives him. He refuses the Abbot's offer of reconciliation and dies unrepentant, declaring that it is not so difficult to die. *Symphony of the Night* answers *Manfred* point by point. Its mourner, too, has lost the woman he loved, defies heaven, and refuses every consolation the Church might offer; but the dead woman's word, when it reaches him through their son, grants what Astarte withheld. Lisa forgives, and asks mercy for no one but the humans who burned her. And the mourner, having heard her, does not die unrepentant: he asks her pardon.

Kierkegaard analysed the structure of such defiance in *Sygdommen til Døden* (*The Sickness unto Death*, 1849). Despair, on his account, takes two forms: in weakness, not willing to be oneself; in defiance, willing to be oneself against the power that established the self. Its highest form is demonic despair, which wills to be itself in its torment and holds fast to its suffering as an objection against existence. Kierkegaard's image for it is unforgettable: it is as if a slip of the pen in an author's manuscript became conscious of itself as an error and, out of hatred for the author, refused to be corrected, insisting on remaining as a witness against him — proof that he is a poor writer. The demonic despairer will not be consoled, because his misery is his argument. This is Dracula's condition precisely. His grief is his case against God and humanity, and to accept consolation would be to withdraw the case; the castle's centennial return is the misprint reasserting itself in every edition.

The son's name invites a final reflection that the argument can bear. Proofreaders have long read a text backward to catch the errors that a forward reading, carried along by sense, passes over. Alucard is his father's name read backward, and his journey reads his father's house in reverse: he is the proofreader of the paternal text. What he brings to it is not a refutation but the author's correction — the word of the one who loved the father most — and the climax of the game is the moment at which, against all the logic of demonic despair, the error consents to be corrected.

6.7

The Demiurge's Castle: Gnostic Cosmology and the Hymn of the Pearl

THE CASTLE has the structure of a Gnostic cosmos. In the systems recovered from the codices found at Nag Hammadi in 1945, the visible world is the work not of the true God but of a demiurge — in the *Apocryphon of John*, Yaldabaoth, ignorant offspring of a fallen Wisdom — who imprisons sparks of divine light in matter and sets archons to guard the spheres through which the soul must pass. Salvation comes by knowledge, *gnōsis*: a messenger descends from the realm of light, awakens the sleeping spark to remembrance of its origin, and leads it upward through the hostile spheres. Hans Jonas described the Gnostic world as a prison and the Gnostic self as a stranger in it, addressed by a call from beyond (Jonas 1934; 1958). Dracula's castle is a demiurge's world. Its lord is the sovereign of a closed cosmos without an outside (§4.1); its regions are guarded by powers who hold the fragments of a dispersed body; and the hero who descends into it must awaken to his own nature before he can redeem anything else. The history-of-religions school spoke, in a phrase much criticized since, of the Gnostic "redeemed redeemer," the saviour who must himself be saved (Reitzenstein 1921; Colpe 1961). Alucard, who recovers his own powers in the castle before he can free the hunter or release the father, is a redeemed redeemer.

The most beautiful text of this tradition reads as a scenario for the game. The "Hymn of the Pearl," preserved in Syriac in the apocryphal *Acts of*

Thomas (third century), tells of a prince sent by his parents, the King of Kings and the Queen of the East, to bring back from Egypt a pearl guarded by a serpent. Before he departs, they strip him of his robe of glory. In Egypt he puts on the garments of the Egyptians, eats their food, forgets that he is a king's son, and falls into a deep sleep. His parents send him a letter, which flies to him like an eagle and becomes a voice, telling him to wake and to remember that he is a son of kings. He wakes, charms the serpent to sleep by pronouncing over it his father's name, seizes the pearl, casts off his soiled garments, and turns for home; on the way his robe of glory comes to meet him, and in it, as in a mirror, he sees his whole self. The parallels compose themselves. The prince's sleep is Alucard's three centuries of withdrawal; the stripping of the robe is Death's divestiture at the gate; the letter from the parents is the mother's word; the serpent is the dragon whose name the father bears; and the serpent is overcome by the pronouncing of the father's name — which the son of Dracula carries, reversed, as his own. In 1897, the year of Stoker's novel, A. A. Bevan published at Cambridge an English translation of the hymn under the title *The Hymn of the Soul*.

The Japanese counterpart inverts the Gnostic robe. In the *Taketori Monogatari* (late ninth or tenth century), Kaguya-hime, a being from the moon raised by an old bamboo-cutter and his wife, must return to the moon when its people come for her. Before leaving she writes a letter to the emperor who loved her and leaves him an elixir of immortality; then a robe of feathers is laid upon her, and with it she forgets the cares and sorrows of the human world and ascends. Where the Gnostic robe restores memory, the lunar robe erases it, and with it the capacity for human feeling. The emperor, without her, has no wish to live forever, and orders the elixir burned on the mountain nearest heaven. The moon, in this oldest of Japanese tales, is the realm of beings who do not grieve; the human world is the realm of sorrow; and a man who loves makes the supreme refusal of an immortality without the beloved. Dracula's immortality, by contrast, outlived the beloved and was put to the service of grief. The game's subtitle places its whole action beneath the moon, and its hero belongs to both realms: he keeps the human capacity for sorrow that the robe of feathers would have taken from him.

6.8

Osiris, Zagreus, Relic: The Dismembered Father

THE INVERTED Castle holds the father's body in pieces, and its gathering places the game within the oldest mythology of the dismembered god. In Plutarch's account (*De Iside et Osiride* 18), Set kills his brother Osiris, cuts the body into fourteen pieces, and scatters them across Egypt; Isis searches the land, finds every piece but the phallus, which fishes had eaten, and buries each where she finds it, so that many places claimed a tomb of Osiris; restored by her care, Osiris becomes lord of the dead, and their son Horus avenges him. *Symphony of the Night* redistributes the roles in a telling way. The son gathers the father's scattered remains — Heart, Tooth, Rib, Ring, and Eye — as Isis gathered those of Osiris; but he does not take Horus's part as avenger, for the father's enemies are the very people his mother asked him to spare, and his task is not vengeance but release. Alucard plays the mother's part in the Egyptian myth and refuses the son's: he is the gatherer, not the avenger, and in this he is his mother's child.

The Orphic myth of Dionysus Zagreus adds the heart and the mirror. As Clement of Alexandria tells it (*Protrepticus* II.17–18), the Titans lured the infant Dionysus with toys — knucklebones, a ball, a top, golden apples, a mirror — tore him to pieces, and cooked his limbs; Athena saved his heart, which she carried still beating, and from which, in other versions, the god was reborn. The dismemberment begins with a child gazing into a mirror, and later Neoplatonic allegory read the mirror as the image in which the One, beholding itself, is drawn into the multiplicity of the world. A further tradition, attested late and in its fullest form only in the sixth-century Neoplatonist Olympiodorus, held that Zeus burned the Titans with his thunderbolt and that human beings were formed from their soot, so that humanity bears within it both the guilt of the Titans and the divinity of the god they devoured. Modern scholarship has questioned whether this "Orphic original sin" was ever an ancient doctrine (Edmonds 1999), but as an anthropology it is unforgettable: the human being as a mixture of murderer and victim, Titan and god. The Orphic human is a dhampir. And

among the castle's relics, the Heart of Vlad is the organ that the Orphic myth preserved for rebirth.

Christianity made the fragmented body of the holy dead the centre of a cult. Peter Brown showed how the late antique Church gathered round the tombs and fragments of the saints, whose *praesentia* brought heaven near (Brown 1981), and Patrick Geary documented the medieval traffic in stolen relics, *furta sacra*, by which communities acquired the power of the dead (Geary 1978). The word itself — *reliquiae*, from *relinquere*, "to leave behind" — names what remains. The game's inventory gives the term a double reference that is its deepest irony (§1.5): the category "Relics" holds both the fragments of the father's body and the powers the son recovers in himself. Both are what the father left behind — the one in the castle, the other in the son's blood.

Japanese legend gives the dismembered rebel a head that seeks its body. Taira no Masakado, who in 939 proclaimed himself the "new emperor" of the eastern provinces and was killed in 940, had his head displayed in the capital; legend holds that it stayed uncorrupted, called out for its body, and flew east, falling at last in the village that became Edo, where its mound, the Kubizuka, stands to this day among the office towers of central Tokyo, honoured and feared. The rebel's scattered body yearns for reunion, and the city has never dared to disturb the place where its head came down. Dracula's relics, scattered through the Inverted Castle and gathered by his son, belong to this family of remains that will not rest until they are reunited — and which, once reunited, permit the final rest that Osiris found as lord of the dead, and that the father of *Symphony of the Night* finds in hearing his son's word.

6.9

Through the Centre: Dante's Inversion and the Harrowing of Hell

◆

The turning of the castle has its great literary precedent at the centre of the *Inferno*. At the bottom of Hell, Lucifer stands frozen in the ice of Cocytus, and Virgil, carrying Dante, climbs down the shaggy flank of the

Figure ii

Through the Centre



Through the centre (§6.9). Dante's descent ends at the point where down becomes up, and the funnel of Hell and the mountain of Purgatory are the negative and the positive of one shape. The game is built on the same hinge: its first castle descends, its second climbs out, and it ends, like the Inferno*, with an emergence.*

fallen angel. At the hip he turns his head to where his feet had been and begins to climb (*Inferno* 34.79); Dante, looking back, sees Lucifer's legs held upward (34.90) and fears they are returning into Hell. Virgil explains that they have passed "'l punto / al qual si traggon d'ogne parte i pesi" — the point to which weights are drawn from every side (34.110–111): the centre of the earth and of gravity, at which descent becomes ascent and down becomes up. They climb through a hidden passage to the other hemisphere, "e quindi uscimmo a riveder le stelle" — and thence we came forth to see again the stars (34.139). Dante adds a cosmological detail of extraordinary consequence. When Lucifer fell from heaven on that side of the earth, the land fled from him, and the earth displaced by his fall rushed upward to form, on the opposite side, the mountain of Purgatory (34.121–126). The funnel of Hell and the mountain of purgation are the same shape turned over: the place of punishment and the place of purification are the negative and the positive of one another.

Symphony of the Night is built on Dante's hinge. Its first castle is a descent into the father's house of punishment, culminating at the point where, in the Keep, the hunter is unveiled as possessed; there the world turns, and the second castle — the same structure inverted — becomes the way out. The Inverted Castle is the game's Purgatory, Hell's shape turned upside down, a place not of damnation but of purification, in which the son gathers the father's remains and moves toward pardon. And the game ends, like the *Inferno*, with an emergence: the castle falls, the night ends, and the survivors see again — not the stars but the dawn.

The Christian tradition knew a descent into the realm of the dead that liberates rather than condemns. The First Epistle of Peter speaks of Christ preaching "unto the spirits in prison" (3:19), and the *Gospel of Nicodemus*, whose account of the descent into hell circulated from late antiquity, tells how Christ broke the gates of the underworld, bound Satan, and led out Adam and the righteous dead. Byzantine art painted the scene as the *Anastasis*: in the fresco of the Chora church in Constantinople (c. 1315–1321), Christ, robed in white, stands on the shattered gates of Hell, their locks and bolts scattered in the darkness beneath, and draws Adam and Eve from their tombs by the wrist. Alucard's descent has this structure: he enters the realm of the undead to free its captive, the possessed hunter, and in the end to release its lord.

The Buddhist tradition supplies the descent of a son for a parent. In the *Ullambana Sūtra*, the disciple Maudgalyāyana — Mokuren in Japanese — sees by his supernatural sight that his dead mother suffers among the hungry ghosts, and on the Buddha's instruction makes offerings to the monastic community that release her; the story is the charter of the summer festival of the dead, Obon. A son descends in vision to the underworld for his mother's sake. Alucard inverts the direction of Mokuren's piety: he descends into his father's hell carrying his mother's word, so that the father may be released by the mother through the son. In each tradition the descent is undertaken not to conquer the dead but to free them, and the hero who goes down into the realm of punishment comes up by turning it over.

6.10

The Centennial Return: Eliade and Nietzsche

◆

The castle returns once a century, and its return has the form of a cosmic rite. Mircea Eliade's *Le Mythe de l'éternel retour* (1949) argued that archaic societies abolished the "terror of history" by periodically regenerating time: at the New Year the creation of the world was repeated in ritual, chaos readmitted and overcome, and the cosmos begun again. The paradigm is Babylonian. At the Akitu festival of the New Year the *Enuma Elish* was recited, recounting how Marduk defeated Tiamat, the primordial sea-dragon of chaos, split her body in two, and made from its halves the heavens and the earth. The world is built from the body of a slain dragon. Hermann Gunkel's *Schöpfung und Chaos in Urzeit und Endzeit* (1895) traced the same combat from the beginning of time to its end, finding the primeval dragon again in the great red dragon of Revelation 12 (§4.7). The castle of the son of the Dragon, reappearing on its schedule to be overcome by a hunter of the destined line, is a dragon-combat repeated as cosmic rite; the Belmonts' recurring war is the series' Akitu.

Nietzsche gave the eternal return its existential form. In *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* (1882, §341), a demon steals into one's loneliest loneliness and announces that this life, exactly as it has been lived, must be lived again

innumerable times, every pain and every joy returning in the same sequence; one must either curse the demon or answer that one has never heard anything more divine. The thought is "the greatest weight," a test of whether a life can be affirmed in its entirety. Dracula's centennial return is the demon's sentence carried out. He must relive his grief and his war in every century, and his defiance (§6.6) is a refusal to affirm what he cannot escape. Louis-Auguste Blanqui, imprisoned in the Fort du Taureau in 1871, wrote in *L'Éternité par les astres* (1872) that in an infinite universe composed of finite elements every combination must recur, so that each of us lives innumerable lives on innumerable earths, identical or varied; Benjamin closed the 1939 exposé of his *Passagen-Werk* with Blanqui's vision, as the image of a modernity condemned to repeat itself. The series is Blanqui's cosmos: the same Dracula returning in innumerable variants on innumerable earths, each a little different and each the same.

Kant's own answer to the third question gives this repetition its sharpest irony. The *Kritik der praktischen Vernunft* (1788) argued that the moral law commands us to pursue the highest good, a holiness of will that no finite being can attain at any moment of its existence, and that we may therefore hope for an endless progress toward it, which presupposes the immortality of the soul. Immortality, for Kant, is a postulate of hope: an endless time in which a will may be perfected. The vampire possesses endless time and uses it for nothing of the kind. His undeath is the postulate of immortality without the progress that justified it — immortality as endless recurrence rather than endless improvement, Kant's hope parodied in Blanqui's prison. What, then, may be hoped? Not, in the game, that the cycle will be abolished: the series requires the castle to return, and its later instalments duly bring it back. Benjamin set another hope against Blanqui's despair: not the end of repetition but its interruption, a "messianic arrest of happening" in which a moment blasts open the continuum of history ("Über den Begriff der Geschichte," XVII). The game's hope is of this kind. Within a cycle it cannot end, it produces a moment of recognition — the father hearing the mother's word — that changes the meaning of the return. The castle will come back; the wrath that built it is, in this return, laid to rest.

The Japanese tradition gives periodic return a gentler form. At Obon the dead return each summer to their families, welcomed with fires lit at the threshold and sent away again with fires on the hills and lanterns floated on

the rivers; their return is an occasion not of combat but of hospitality and farewell. At Ise, the shrines of the imperial ancestors have been rebuilt on adjacent sites every twenty years, by tradition since the late seventh century and most recently in 2013, so that the most venerable sanctuary in Japan is also perpetually new. Eliade's eternal return, in these forms, is not a terror to be defied but a rhythm of renewal and care. *Symphony of the Night* moves its centennial return from the first register to the second. It begins as a dragon-combat and ends as a visitation of the dead — welcomed, heard, and sent away.

6.11

1995: Aum, *Evangelion*, and the Japanese Apocalyptic Imaginary

◆

Symphony of the Night was made in a Japan that had just lived through the nearest thing to an apocalypse in its postwar history. On 17 January 1995 the Great Hanshin earthquake killed more than six thousand people in and around Kōbe; on 20 March 1995 members of Aum Shinrikyō released sarin on five trains of the Tokyo subway, killing thirteen people and injuring thousands. Aum was an apocalyptic movement of extreme syncretism. Its guru, Shōkō Asahara, made the Hindu god Shiva its principal deity, proclaimed himself the Christ, borrowed the Christian vocabulary of Armageddon and the prophecies of Nostradamus, and drew his following from educated young people who found in his cosmic narrative a meaning the affluent society of the bubble years had failed to give them. The game was released in Japan on 20 March 1997, the second anniversary of the attack to the day. The coincidence proves nothing about the game's intentions; it places its release, with the exactness history sometimes provides, in the shadow of a catastrophe in which a priestly leader, drawing at once on the god of the sacred ash and on the Christian apocalypse, sought to bring about the end of the world.

Japanese literature took the measure of the event in the very month of the game's release. Murakami Haruki's *Andāguraundo* (*Underground*), a

book of interviews with victims of the attack, appeared in March 1997, and a companion volume of interviews with members of Aum followed in 1998. Murakami argued that Aum had offered its adherents a ready-made story in place of the stories they had been unable to make for themselves, and that the society which condemned the cult had no better story to offer. The diagnosis bears on the game's own structure. Shaft, the priest who resurrects the devil, offers the hunter a story — a monster to fight forever — in place of the life he had lost; Lisa's word offers her son not a story but an ethic, to be lived among others without hatred.

The popular culture of the mid-1990s had already absorbed the Christian apocalypse into its imagination. Go Nagai's *Devilman* had ended in a world destroyed by human paranoia (§5.9). Hayao Miyazaki's manga *Kaze no Tani no Naushika* (1982–1994) concluded with its heroine destroying a sealed crypt that held the technology and the plan to remake a purified humanity, choosing the polluted, mortal world over an engineered salvation. Hideaki Anno's *Shinseiki Evangelion* (television, 1995–1996; cinematic conclusion, July 1997) built its apocalypse from a bricolage of Christian and Kabbalistic imagery — Angels, Adam and Lilith, the Tree of Life, the Lance of Longinus — around a Human Instrumentality Project that would dissolve every individual into a single undifferentiated sea. Its emotional core was Schopenhauerian. The English title of its fourth episode, "Hedgehog's Dilemma," cites the parable in *Parerga und Paralipomena* (II, §396) of the porcupines who crowd together for warmth on a winter's day, prick one another with their quills, and must find the distance at which they can bear each other. At the end of the film, the boy at its centre refuses instrumentality and chooses a world of separate persons who can hurt him: the painful plurality of human beings rather than their merger.

Symphony of the Night belongs to this moment and answers its question. The apocalypse it stages is a father's war on humanity; the instrument of that apocalypse is a priest; its sacred weapons join the god of the ash to the Cross; and its resolution refuses both the end of the world and the dissolution of persons into a merciful unity. Like Nausicaä and the hero of *Evangelion*, its son chooses the world of separate, suffering, guilty human beings; unlike them, he does so in obedience to a word received from someone that world destroyed. Kant's third question receives its answer

here. What may I hope? Not for the end of the world, which the villain pursues; not for an immortality that repeats its grief forever; not for a salvation engineered by a priest or a plan. I may hope that punishment can be turned into pardon, as Hegel's inverted world promised (§4.8); that a moment of recognition can interrupt the cycle of wrath, as Benjamin hoped (§6.10); that the dead may be heard rather than avenged, and sent home with lights, as at Obon; and that the hard lot of human beings, which the vampire despised, may become, as their mother asked, the ground of mercy. The castle will return. The hope is that, when it does, someone will carry the word.

VII

Was ist der Mensch?



Chapter Seven

Was ist der Mensch?

The Retrograde Son — Dhampiric Being, Kenosis, and the Oedipal Vampire

Kant held that the first three questions of philosophy refer to the fourth, and this dissertation has followed the game's answers to them — knowledge as metamorphosis and the excess of totality, duty as mercy toward the miserable, hope as the turning of punishment into pardon — toward the figure in whom they converge. The fourth question, which Dracula poses at the threshold and answers with contempt, receives its answer not in a proposition but in a person: the dhampir. This chapter reads Alucard as the game's anthropology in eleven movements: his name (§7.1); the doctrine of two natures that his being parodies and fulfils (§7.2); the role of Antichrist that he refuses (§7.3); the emptying with which he enters the castle and the recollection by which he recovers himself (§§7.4–7.5); the animal forms in which he knows his father's house (§7.6); the family structure that binds the vampire to filiation (§7.7); the double, the afterimage, and the backward step that are his signatures in motion (§7.8); the aristocratic melancholy of his bearing (§7.9); the coffin in which he and the player rest and return (§7.10); and the refusal of inheritance with which he leaves (§7.11). The argument is that the dhampir is the human being as such, seen in the mirror of the monster: the creature that exists between, that can read its own origin backward, and that can refuse what it inherits.

7.1
The Name Read Backward

◆

Chapter One traced the retrograde name to its Hollywood origin (§1.3), and Chapter Two observed that Dracula is itself a patronymic, so that its reversal reverses filiation (§2.1). The philosophy of names allows the point to be stated more precisely. Frege distinguished the reference of a name, the object it designates, from its sense, the mode in which that object is presented (Frege 1892). In Universal's *Son of Dracula* (1943), "Alucard" and "Dracula" have different senses and the same reference: the reversed name is a disguise through which the same Count is presented otherwise. In Konami's usage from 1989, the reference divides. Alucard designates the son and Dracula the father, and the identity of their letters records a relation of origin rather than of identity. Saul Kripke's account of proper names as rigid designators, fixed by an initial act of naming and handed on through a chain of use (Kripke 1980), describes what happened to the name: its reference was re-baptized, and what had been a mask for the father became the name of another person, who carries the father within him as his reversal. The son is presented to the world in the mode of the father turned around.

Scripture knows the reversed name as an instrument of prophecy against the oppressor. In the cipher called *atbash*, the Hebrew alphabet is folded back upon itself, the first letter exchanged for the last and the second for the second-last, and the book of Jeremiah has been read since antiquity as using it to name the enemy covertly: "Sheshach" for Babel (25:26; 51:41) and "Leb-kamai" for Kasdim, the Chaldeans (51:1). A name written against the grain of the alphabet names the empire it prophesies against. Samuel Butler's satire *Erewhon* (1872), whose title reverses, imperfectly, the word "nowhere," supplies the moral of the device. In Erewhon illness is a crime, and a young man is tried and sentenced for pulmonary consumption; crime, by contrast, is treated as a misfortune deserving care, and embezzlers are visited by "straighteners," who minister to them as physicians minister to the sick. The country named by a reversed word is a *verkehrte Welt* in

Figure 12

Names Read Backward



Son of Dracula, *1943; Konami, from 1989*



Ave maris stella: *"mutans Evae nomen"*

ドラキュラ

Dorakyura

アルカード

Arukādo

read backward, ドーカルア*: nothing*

S	A	T	O	R
A	R	E	P	O
T	E	N	E	T
O	P	E	R	A
R	O	T	A	S

Pompeii, before 79 CE: the same in four directions



PATER NOSTER with A and O: a rearrangement proposed in 1926, still contested

Reversible names (§§1.3, 7.1). DRACULA from right to left is ALUCARD; the Vespers hymn changes the name of Eve, EVA, into Gabriel's AVE; the Sator square reads alike in four directions, and its letters have been rearranged, contestedly, into a PATER NOSTER cross with alpha and omega. In katakana the son's name, reversed, yields nothing.

which punishment and compassion have exchanged their objects: Hegel's inversion (§4.8) as political satire.

The retrograde has one further property that only a contrapuntal reading can register: it works in one script and not in another. In the Japanese text the son's name is written in katakana, アルカード, *Arukādo*, and read backward it yields nothing; the father's name, ドラキュラ, *Dorakyura*, lies concealed in it only for a reader of Roman letters. For the game's first audience, Alucard's secret was encoded in a foreign alphabet. The name that confesses its origin to an anglophone eye was, to a Japanese one, an opaque foreign word whose meaning lay in the script of Stoker's novel. The name is thus a secret in two senses: a reversal legible to some readers and not to others, and a pile of secrets that changes with the alphabet in which it is read.

7.2

Two Natures without Confusion: Chalcedon and the Dhampiric Hypostasis

◆

The dhampir's ontology has its most exact formula in the theology it parodies. In 451 the Council of Chalcedon defined the person of Christ as one hypostasis known in two natures "without confusion, without change, without division, without separation" — *ἀσυγχύτως, ἀτρέπτως, ἀδιαιρέτως, ἀχωρίστως*, in the Latin *inconfuse, immutabiliter, indivise, inseparabiliter* — the distinction of the natures being in no way abolished by the union, and the properties of each preserved and concurring in one person. The definition was drawn between two errors. Against the Nestorians, who seemed to divide Christ into two subjects, it insisted on one person; against Eutyches and those who held that the humanity was absorbed into the divinity like a drop dissolved in the sea, it insisted that the natures remain two. The dhampir is the Chalcedonian definition inverted: one person in two natures, not divine and human but demonic and human, held together without confusion and without separation.

The game's narrative can be read as a passage between the two heresies. Alucard's self-imposed sleep, undertaken to keep his father's blood from the

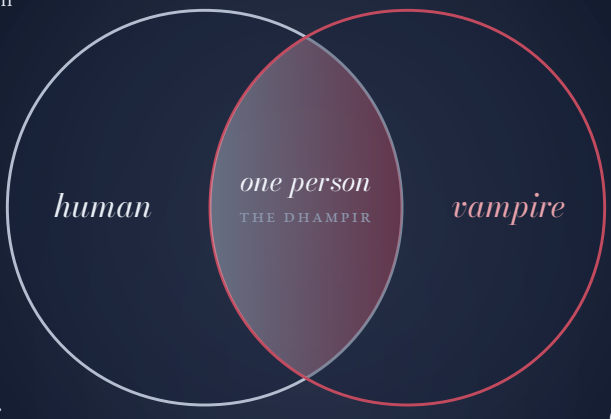
Figure 13

Two Natures

ἀσυγχύτως
inconfuse
without confusion

ἀτρέπτως
immutabiliter
without change

Chalcedon, 451



ἀδιαιρέτως
indivise
without division

ἀχωρίστως
inseparabiliter
without separation

Nestorian



division: the quarantine Alucard attempted by sleep

Chalcedonian



two natures in one person

Eutychian



absorption: a drop dissolved in the sea, the father's temptation

Shingon

ni ni funi

two, yet not two

Two natures without confusion (§7.2). The Council of Chalcedon defined one person in two natures by four negations; the dhampir is the definition inverted, demonic and human rather than divine and human. Between the errors of division and absorption lies the Shingon formula, two, yet not two.

world, was an attempted separation of natures — a Nestorian solution, in which the vampire half would be quarantined from the human by withdrawal from history. The castle's return refutes it: the son cannot sleep his blood away. The opposite temptation, the Eutychian, would be to let the human be absorbed into the vampire, the drop into the sea; it is the temptation the castle sets before him at every turn, and the one his father embodies. Alucard's way through the castle is Chalcedonian. He uses the vampire's powers — bat, wolf, mist, the spells that drain life from his father's creatures — in the service of the human ends his mother bequeathed him, without letting either nature dissolve the other. In the language of the later councils, he has two wills. The Third Council of Constantinople (681) affirmed against the monothelites that Christ possesses a human will as well as a divine one, the human freely conforming itself to the divine; its great defender, Maximus the Confessor, had his tongue and right hand cut off in 662 for maintaining it. The dhampir's vampire appetite and human compassion are two wills, and his drama is the conforming of the one to the other.

The doctrine of the communication of properties — *communicatio idiomatum*, by which what belongs to either nature may be predicated of the one person — has its counterpart in the game's mechanics. The bat's flight, the wolf's speed, and the mist's passage through grates belong to the vampire nature; they are exercised by a person whose ends belong to the human. The dhampir is not a confusion of natures but their communication in a single agency, and it is this, rather than any mixture, that makes him a figure of mediation.

The Japanese tradition supplies a formula as apt as Chalcedon's. Shingon esoteric Buddhism teaches that the two great mandalas, of the Womb Realm and the Diamond Realm — the one figuring the matrix of compassion, the other indestructible wisdom — are *ryōbu funi*, "the two parts not two," and medieval *Ryōbu Shintō* mapped the pair onto the Inner and Outer Shrines at Ise. The esoteric phrase *ni ni funi*, "two, yet not two," states with lapidary economy the condition that Chalcedon defined by negations. The dhampir is two and not two: a single being whose duality is neither dissolved into unity nor divided into a pair.

7.3

The Refused Antichrist: Adso, *Good Omens*, *Hellboy*

◆

The son of Dracula is, by the etymology of his father's name, the son of the Devil (§2.1), and Christian tradition had a name for the devil's son: Antichrist. The treatise on the Antichrist that Adso of Montier-en-Der composed around 950 for Queen Gerberga gathered the scattered prophecies into a biography. The Antichrist will be born of human parents, but the devil will enter his mother's womb at his conception and fill him wholly with diabolical power; he will be raised by sorcerers, work false miracles, rebuild the Temple, persecute the faithful, and reign for three years and a half before he is destroyed. The figure is a parody of the Incarnation — a man possessed from the womb by the adversary, as Christ was conceived by the Spirit — and it stands behind the "man of sin," the "son of perdition," of the Second Epistle to the Thessalonians (2:3), and the beast of the Apocalypse. The devil's son is destined to reign in his father's name.

Modern fiction made the refusal of that destiny a recurring plot, and its two most celebrated instances appeared in the years just before the game. In Terry Pratchett and Neil Gaiman's *Good Omens* (1990), the infant Antichrist is mislaid at birth and grows up as an ordinary boy in an English village; when the apocalypse arrives on schedule he refuses to begin it, and in the end rejects the infernal father who comes to claim him in favour of the human father who raised him. In Mike Mignola's *Hellboy* (from 1993–1994), a demon child summoned to earth in 1944 by Nazi occultists to become the beast of the apocalypse is raised by the professor who found him, files down his horns, and spends his life fighting the powers he was born to serve. The refused Antichrist is the hero of a culture that has lost confidence in its own apocalypses: the devil's son who declines his father's kingdom.

Symphony of the Night belongs to this lineage while differing from both works in a decisive respect. Adam Young and Hellboy refuse fathers who are strangers to them, and their human upbringing makes the refusal easy,

almost natural. Alucard knows his father, has fought him before, and loves him; and the human influence that shapes him is not an adoptive family but the memory of his dead mother. His refusal is therefore not a choice of one father over another but a fidelity to his mother maintained against his father, without ceasing to be his father's son. Ira Levin's *Rosemary's Baby* (1967), filmed by Roman Polanski in 1968, ends with a human mother rocking the cradle of the devil's child, drawn by maternal love toward a son whose nature she knows; what that love may make of him, the story leaves open. *Symphony of the Night* tells, in effect, what such a love might make: a son who carries his mother's word into his father's house and turns the father's power against the father's war.

The refused Antichrist completes the structure of retrogradation. The Antichrist is the devil's inversion of the Incarnation; the refused Antichrist inverts the inversion. A figure rotated through half a circle twice returns to its original orientation, and the double inversion of the dhampir returns not to divinity but to humanity. The devil's son who refuses to be Antichrist does not become a god. He becomes a man.

7.4

Kenōsis at the Gate: Death, Inanna, and the Robe of Glory

Alucard enters his father's house emptied. He arrives in possession of formidable arms and armour, and at the threshold Death takes them from him, so that he must cross the castle beginning from almost nothing. The Pauline hymn names the pattern: Christ, "being in the form of God, thought it not robbery to be equal with God: But made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant" (Philippians 2:6–7). The Greek verb is *ekenōsen*, he emptied himself, and from it the theology of *kenōsis* takes its name: the divine Son enters the world by laying aside the glory that was his. Nineteenth-century Lutheran theologians such as Gottfried Thomasius argued that the incarnate Christ divested himself of the relative attributes of divinity — omnipotence, omniscience — while retaining the essential ones of holiness and love; the son is defined, in his

descent, by what he keeps when everything else is taken. Alucard keeps his nature and his mother's word. What Death takes is his inheritance in its outward form, the equipment of a prince. The son enters the father's house, as the hymn has it, in the form of a servant — in a house where, as Chapter Six observed, Death himself is a servant (§6.5).

The oldest narrative of such a divestiture is Sumerian. In the *Descent of Inanna*, recorded in the early second millennium BCE, the goddess of love and war descends to the underworld to visit her sister Ereshkigal, its queen. At each of seven gates the gatekeeper, Neti, removes one of her insignia — the crown, the beads at her throat, the double strand on her breast, the breastplate, the golden ring, the measuring rod and line, the royal robe — and answers each protest with the same formula: the ways of the underworld are perfect and may not be questioned. She comes before Ereshkigal naked, is struck dead, and hangs as a corpse upon a hook, until creatures fashioned by the god Enki revive her with the food and water of life; she may return only by giving a substitute, and her husband Dumuzi is taken in her place, his sister afterwards sharing his term below so that each spends half the year among the dead. The descent strips the goddess of her powers; the return requires a substitute and institutes a cycle. *Symphony of the Night* reverses the economy of the myth. Alucard, too, is stripped at the gate, but the underworld restores rather than consumes his powers, and the substitute he refuses to provide is the one his father demanded: humanity, made to pay for Lisa's death.

The Japanese myth inverts the order of the stripping. When Izanagi returns from Yomi, where he has seen his dead wife's corruption (§4.6), he purifies himself in a river, casting off his staff, his sash, his bag, his robe, his trousers, his cap, and his armbands; from each discarded thing a deity is born, and only then, as he washes his face, does he engender the sun and the moon. Inanna is stripped on the way down, Izanagi strips himself on the way up, and the divestiture that the Mesopotamian myth makes a death becomes, in the Japanese, a generation of gods. The Hymn of the Pearl (§6.7) stands between them: the prince is stripped of his robe of glory before his descent and finds it again, as a mirror of his whole self, on his return.

Alucard's kenosis has the shape of all three. Like Inanna he loses his insignia at the threshold of the realm of death; like the prince of the Hymn

he will recover what was his; and like Izanagi he will bring forth, in the course of his journey, powers for which his stripping made room — not deities but the bat, the wolf, and the mist that his own nature contains. The emptying at the gate is the condition of the recollection that follows.

7.5

Anamnēsis: Relics as Recollection

◆

What Alucard recovers in the castle he already was. The relics through which his abilities return — the Soul of Bat, the Form of Mist, the Soul of Wolf, and the refinements that follow, Echo of Bat, Power of Wolf, Power of Mist — are not acquisitions but restorations, and the game's words for them are philosophically suggestive: "soul" and "form," *psychē* and *eidos*, the two terms in which Plato framed the doctrine that learning is recollection. In the *Phaedo* (72e–77a), Socrates argues that the soul must have known the Forms before birth, since we recognize equality in imperfectly equal things only by reference to an Equal we have never seen in the world; birth is a forgetting, and knowledge the recovery of what the soul once possessed. The Myth of Er at the end of the *Republic* (X, 621a) makes the forgetting a drink: before rebirth the souls cross the plain of Lethe and drink from the River of Unmindfulness, and those who drink more forget more. Alucard's sleep was his Lethe; the castle is his anamnesis.

The Orphic gold tablets give the doctrine a form that might have been written for the dhampir. Buried with initiates in southern Italy and Greece from the late fifth or fourth century BCE, the tablets of Hipponion and Petelia instruct the dead soul how to pass through the underworld: it must avoid the spring beside the white cypress, which is the water of forgetting, and ask the guardians to let it drink the cold water that flows from the lake of Memory, declaring as its password: "I am a child of Earth and of starry Heaven; but my race is of Heaven." The soul's credential before the guardians of the dead is its double parentage, a lineage from earth and from sky, and its salvation depends on drinking from Memory rather than Forgetting. The dhampir's descent into his father's house is such a passage:

a child of two lineages, who must remember rather than forget in order to come through.

Freud supplied the counterpart that the father embodies. In "Erinnern, Wiederholen und Durcharbeiten" (1914), he observed that the patient does not remember what he has forgotten and repressed but acts it out: he repeats it, without knowing that he is repeating it, and the work of analysis consists in turning repetition into remembrance. The castle stages the two terms of Freud's essay in father and son. Dracula repeats: his centennial return is a repetition compulsion, the reenactment of a loss he cannot remember rightly, since remembering it rightly would mean recalling Lisa's last words. Alucard remembers: his journey recovers what was his, and at its end he gives his father the memory that the father's repetition had kept from him. The final scene is analysis in Freud's sense, in which what has been repeated is at last remembered, and the repetition can cease.

The inventory files the father's remains beside the son's restored powers under the single heading of relics (§1.5; §6.8), and the juxtaposition now reveals its sense. The son recollects himself and gathers his father in a single movement, because what he must remember about himself is inseparable from what he must remember for his father. His powers are what the father's blood gave him; the father's remains are what the father's war has scattered; and the memory that binds them is the mother's word. Anamnesis in the castle is not the soul's private recovery of eternal Forms but the recovery, by a son, of a family's history — the condition, as Benjamin would say, of a remembrance that can make the completed incomplete (§4.10).

7.6

Bat, Wolf, Mist: Stoker's Metamorphoses and Becoming-Animal

◆

The three forms in which Alucard knows his father's house are his father's forms, inherited from Stoker (§2.5), and each opens a different relation between the human being and what exceeds it. The bat is flight and echo: the creature whose experience Thomas Nagel took as the paradigm of

a subjectivity inaccessible to us (§4.2), and whose form gives the son the heights of the castle and, with the Echo of Bat, a sense the human body lacks. The wolf is the ground, the pack, and speed, and it carries one of the oldest metamorphoses in European literature: the first individual transformation of Ovid's *Metamorphoses* (I.209–243) is that of Lycaon, the Arcadian king who served Jupiter human flesh and was turned into a wolf, his savagery made visible in his shape. Robert Burton's *Anatomy of Melancholy* (1621) classified lycanthropy as a species of melancholy, in which men "run howling about graves and fields in the night, and will not be persuaded but that they are wolves" (I.1.1.4). The wolf is the melancholic's animal, and Alucard is the melancholic prince of a mourning play (§1.4). The mist is dissolution, the body made breath: in Greek, Latin, and Hebrew alike the words for soul — *psychē*, *anima*, *ruach* — are words for breath and wind, and the form of mist, in which the son passes through grates and bars, makes the body almost a soul.

Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari gave the transformations a theory in *Mille plateaux* (1980). Becoming-animal, on their account, is neither imitation nor identification but an alliance, a passage of intensities between heterogeneous terms, propagated like a contagion through packs and multiplicities rather than inherited through lines of descent; and the vampire is one of their emblems of it. The game's forms answer to the theory's terms. Bat and wolf are pack animals, the creatures Stoker's Count commands as the children of the night; the mist is a becoming-imperceptible, the body dispersed into an atmosphere. In assuming them, Alucard enters the multiplicities of his father's world — but as one who passes through them, not one who dissolves into them. He returns, after every transformation, to the human form in which he bears his mother's word.

Kafka's *Die Verwandlung* (1915) is the great modern counter-text. Gregor Samsa wakes in his father's house transformed into a monstrous insect; his father drives him back into his room and, in the novella's most terrible scene, bombards him with apples, one of which lodges in his back and festers; Gregor dies, and the family, relieved, ride out into the open country in the spring. The son's metamorphosis in the father's house is, in Kafka, a curse that the father punishes with death. *Symphony of the Night* turns the story over. Its son transforms by inheritance and by choice, uses his animal forms to move through the father's house, and confronts the

father not as a victim but as the one who brings him an end and a word. Kafka wrote to his father in 1919, in a letter never delivered, that all his writing had been about him. The game is a letter delivered.

The Japanese tradition of transformation offers a final contrast. Its shape-changing animals — the fox, the badger, the cat — are *henge*, beings who take human form, and Kuzunoha, the fox who became a wife and mother (§2.3), is their most moving instance. The European vampire is a human-seeming being who takes animal forms; the Japanese *henge* is an animal who takes human form. The dhampir stands where the two directions meet. He is a being of mixed descent who takes animal shapes and yet keeps, as Kuzunoha's son kept his mother's poem, a parent's word about resentment.

7.7

The Vampire Who Filiates: Deleuze, Guattari, and the Oedipalized Undead

◆

"Le vampire ne filiationne pas, il contagionne": the vampire does not filiate, it infects (Deleuze and Guattari 1980). The sentence states the vampire's traditional difference from humanity. Human beings reproduce by descent, through families, names, and inheritances; vampires propagate by contagion, through bites that make kin of strangers without regard to lineage. Stoker's Count has no children; his brides and his victims are his family by infection. *Symphony of the Night* breaks this law. Its vampire marries a human woman and fathers a son; its central relation is filial; and its plot is a family drama in which father, mother, and son occupy the three corners of the triangle that, in *L'Anti-Œdipe* (1972), Deleuze and Guattari accused psychoanalysis of imposing on all desire. The game Oedipalizes the undead. It takes the creature that had stood for desire's escape from the family and gives it a family.

But it does not give it Oedipus. In Freud's scenario the son desires the mother and wishes the father dead; in *Totem und Tabu* (1913) the brothers of the primal horde kill the father who had monopolized the women and then, in remorse, raise him into a totem whose law binds them more

strongly than his living power had done: "Der Tote wurde nun stärker, als der Lebende gewesen war" — the dead man became stronger than the living one had been. The castle is the dead father's strength made architecture, an undead power stronger than any living lord. Yet the son's relation to the mother in the game is not desire but fidelity to her word, and his relation to the father is not a parricidal wish but a mission of release. The triangle is preserved and its affects inverted: the son allies himself with the dead mother against the living father's war, not to replace the father but to bring him to the mother's mercy. Jacques Lacan's "Name-of-the-Father," the paternal function by which the child enters the symbolic order of law and language, plays in French on *nom* and *non*, name and prohibition. Alucard bears the Name of the Father turned backward: his name is the father's name reversed into a refusal, a "no" to the father spoken in the father's own letters.

The oldest version of the prologue's question belongs to the Oedipus story itself. The Sphinx who besieged Thebes — a hybrid creature, part woman, part lion, part bird — killed those who could not answer her riddle: what goes on four feet, on two, and on three? Oedipus answered "man," who crawls as an infant, walks upright in his prime, and leans on a staff in old age (Apollodorus, *Bibliotheca* III.5.8; Athenaeus X.456b). The monster at the gate asks what a human being is, and the hero answers rightly — and does not know the man he himself is, the son who has killed his father and married his mother. Dracula's question at the threshold of the castle is the Sphinx's riddle in its baldest form, and Richter, who answers it with a whip, is Oedipus without even the right word. The riddle's own answer, moreover, defines the human being by transformation: the creature whose form changes through its life, from four feet to two to three. The dhampir, who passes through the forms of bat, wolf, and mist and returns to his own, answers the riddle not with a word but with a life.

The vampire who filiates thus becomes the bearer of a different anthropology from the vampire who infects. The infecting vampire makes all its victims alike; the filiating vampire produces a child unlike himself, a being of mixed descent in whom the father's nature is joined to another's. Filiation introduces difference into the undead. Through it the vampire's line acquires what contagion can never give it: a son who can refuse.

7.8
The Doppelgänger, the Afterimage, and the Backdash

◆

The dhampir is accompanied in motion by images of himself. Twice in the game he must fight a Doppelganger, a dark copy of his own figure that turns his own arts against him; as he moves, translucent afterimages trail behind him, so that his body leaves a visible wake of its recent positions; and his most characteristic movement is a dash backward, executed while he continues to face forward. Each is a figure of the retrograde son's relation to himself.

The doppelgänger is a word of 1796. Jean Paul coined *Doppeltgänger* in *Siebenkäs* — the novel that contained the Speech of the Dead Christ (§2.4) — glossing it as the name for people who see themselves, and gave his hero a double in his friend Leibgeber, with whom he exchanges names. The Romantic and Victorian doubles followed: Hoffmann's monk Medardus and his double in *Die Elixiere des Teufels* (1815–1816); Poe's "William Wilson" (1839), whose narrator kills the double who had pursued him as his conscience and hears it tell him that he has murdered himself; Stevenson's Jekyll and Hyde (1886); Wilde's Dorian Gray (1890), whose portrait bears his sins. Otto Rank's study of the double (1914) argued, in a formula Freud adopted in "Das Unheimliche" (1919), that the double was originally an insurance against the destruction of the ego, an "energische Dementierung der Macht des Todes," an energetic denial of the power of death, and became, once that denial was outgrown, the uncanny harbinger of death. The vampire is the double that never outgrew its first function: a self that has denied death, and become for that reason death's messenger to others. Japanese literature knows the double as the living spirit, *ikiryō*. In the "Aoi" chapter of the *Tale of Genji*, the spirit of the jealous Lady Rokujō leaves her body and torments Genji's wife in childbirth until she dies, and Rokujō learns what her double has done when she finds in her own hair the scent of the poppy seeds burned in the exorcists' rites. The self acts without the self's knowledge, and discovers its deeds by their traces. Alucard's Doppelganger, a darkened replica of his own figure, is his vampire half externalized as an

antagonist; to defeat it is to master in combat what he must master in himself.

The afterimages have another genealogy, in the photography of motion. In the 1880s Étienne-Jules Marey recorded the successive phases of a movement on a single plate, so that a walking man or a bird in flight appeared as a series of overlapping figures, and Marcel Duchamp's *Nu descendant un escalier n° 2* (1912) translated the method into painting. Alucard's trailing images are chronophotography in play: a body that carries its recent past visibly behind it, as memory carries the self. They are, in Henri Bergson's sense, duration made visible — the past persisting in the present rather than vanishing behind it.

The backdash completes the figure. In his first thesis on history (§5.5) Benjamin found an image of theology; in the ninth he found one of history itself. Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus* (1920), as Benjamin read it, shows the angel of history with his face turned toward the past, where he sees a single catastrophe piling wreckage upon wreckage at his feet; he would stay to awaken the dead and make whole what has been smashed, but a storm blowing from Paradise drives him irresistibly into the future, to which his back is turned. The angel moves backward into the future, facing the ruins. Alucard's signature movement is the angel's: a retreat that keeps its face toward what it retreats from. Players who race through the castle have long known that chained backdashes carry him across it faster than running, so that the retrograde son advances most swiftly by moving backward. He progresses as Benjamin's angel does, facing the catastrophe of the past — his mother's death, his father's war — while the storm of the game carries him on.

7.9

The Dandy and the Tragic Prince

◆

Alucard's bearing is that of a dandy, and the dandy is a figure of the decade in which the game is set. George Bryan Brummell rose to fame in the London of the 1790s as the arbiter of a new masculine elegance, austere where the old aristocracy had been ornate, and by the time Barbey

d'Aurevilly wrote his essay on Brummell and dandyism (1845) the type had become a philosophical figure. Baudelaire gave it its definitive analysis in "Le Peintre de la vie moderne" (1863). Dandyism, he wrote, appears above all in periods of transition, when democracy is not yet all-powerful and aristocracy only partly shaken and debased; it is "le dernier éclat d'héroïsme dans les décadences," the last spark of heroism amid decadence; and it is "un soleil couchant; comme l'astre qui décline, il est superbe, sans chaleur et plein de mélancolie" — a setting sun; like the declining star, it is superb, without warmth, and full of melancholy. The description fits the period of the game's fiction, the years of the Directory between the fall of a monarchy and the rise of an empire, and it fits its hero: an aristocrat of an abolished order, cool to the point of coldness, superbly composed, and melancholy.

The dandy's coldness is not indifference. Baudelaire insisted that dandyism is a discipline, a cult of the self that imposes on its adherent a stoic restraint and the proud satisfaction of never being astonished; and Albert Camus, in *L'Homme révolté* (1951), read the dandy as a rebel who, unable to find his existence confirmed by any order beyond himself, makes of his appearance a perpetual challenge. Alucard's restraint is of this kind, but its object differs. His composure holds in check not boredom but a blood that could destroy the world, and his refusal to be astonished is the outward form of a vigilance against his own nature. The dandy's cool is the dhampir's ethics made visible as style.

The game names the other half of his character in the title it gives the music of the Clock Tower: "The Tragic Prince." The European archetype is Hamlet (§5.6). Japanese culture has its own, and a name for the sympathy it evokes. *Hōgan-biiki*, "partiality for the *hōgan*," denotes the disposition to side with the doomed and the defeated, and takes its name from the court title of Minamoto no Yoshitsune, the brilliant young general who won the war against the Taira for his brother Yoritomo, was then hunted by him as a rival, and died at Koromogawa near Hiraizumi in 1189 — the year in which the golden hall of the Northern Fujiwara lost its last lord (§3.5). Ivan Morris called the tradition of such heroes "the nobility of failure" (Morris 1975): a heroism measured not by success but by sincerity in a cause that history defeats. And the *Tale of Genji*, the work Motoori Norinaga made the textbook of *mono no aware* (§3.7), records the death of its shining prince by an empty chapter. Between the book in which Genji is last seen and the

book that follows his death stands a chapter titled "Kumogakure," "Vanishing into the Clouds," which has a title and no text. The prince's end is narrated by silence.

Alucard is a tragic prince of an unusual kind. He does not fail; he defeats his father and saves the world. But his victory is a loss — his father's death, his own exile from both humanity and his father's kind — and the game ends with his vanishing. The dandy's setting sun and the empty chapter of *Genji* meet in his departure: a superb and melancholy figure who withdraws from the world he has saved, leaving behind him a silence that the story does not fill.

7.10

The Coffin as Save Point: Revenant Ludology

◆

The game's most audacious identification of player and protagonist is mechanical. To preserve progress, Alucard enters a coffin in one of the castle's save rooms; the lid closes; the game records its state and restores his strength; and when the player dies, play resumes from the last coffin in which he lay. Every save is a burial and every resumption a resurrection. The player of *Symphony of the Night* does not merely control an undead protagonist; he shares his mode of being, dying and returning as the vampire does, and resting between sessions in the box from which he will rise. The console switched off is the coffin closed, and the hero sleeps between sessions as he slept for three centuries before the game began.

The words encode the conjunction. *Coffin* derives, through the Old French *cofin*, from the Latin *cophinus* and the Greek *kophinos*, a basket, and the same root gives *coffer*, the chest in which valuables are kept: the save coffin is literally a coffer, the place where the treasure of the player's progress is stored. The Japanese language encodes the return. Its verb for coming back to life, *yomigaeru*, is formed from *Yomi*, the land of the dead to which Izanagi descended, and *kaeru*, to return: to revive is to come back from Yomi, and every resumption from a save is a *yomigaeri*. The arcade, from which the console game descends, inverted the oldest economy of death besides. The Greeks laid a coin in the mouth of the dead to pay Charon for

the crossing into Hades; the arcade asked for a coin to purchase return from death — "Continue?" — so that the obol bought passage back rather than passage over.

Freud's account of play is, at its origin, an account of mourning. In *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920) he described a game devised by his eighteen-month-old grandson, who would throw a wooden reel on a string out of sight with a long "o-o-o-o," which his mother and Freud understood as *fort*, "gone," and pull it back with a joyful *da*, "there." The game, Freud concluded, was the child's mastery of his mother's departures: by staging her disappearance and return himself, he turned a loss he suffered passively into a repetition he controlled. A footnote added that the child's mother had since died. The founding psychoanalytic theory of play is the theory of a game of disappearance and return, played by a child to master his mother's absence — a *Trauer-Spiel* in the most literal sense (§1.4). The save system of *Symphony of the Night* is a *fort-da* game of the same structure. The avatar vanishes in death and returns from the coffin; the castle disappears and returns on its century; and the son masters the loss of his mother by carrying her word through a house of repetitions until the repetition can stop.

A revenant ludology follows. Games have been described as an art of failure, whose pleasures depend on the possibility of losing and trying again (Juul 2013); *Symphony of the Night* gives that possibility an ontology. Its player is a revenant in the literal sense of the French word, one who comes back, and its formal structure — death, burial, and return — is the condition of the undead made into the grammar of play. The dhampir's condition, between death and life, is the condition of every player of the game. To play it is to be, for its duration, what its hero is.

7.11

The Accursed Share: Bataille and the Refusal of Inheritance

◆

The game ends with a refusal. When the father is dead and the castle collapses, Alucard resolves that the world has no need of the blood he

carries and withdraws from it; in one of the game's endings, Maria follows him into the unknown. The son who has crossed his father's house, gathered his father's remains, and given his father his mother's word does not take his father's throne. He lets the castle fall and goes. Chapter One named this final moment *apotaxis*, the renunciation that early baptism required of the candidate before the profession of faith (§1.5). Georges Bataille's general economy explains why the renunciation is not a loss.

La Part maudite (1949) argued that every living system produces more energy than it needs for its maintenance and growth, and that the excess — the accursed share — must be spent without return, either gloriously, in luxury, festival, art, and sacrifice, or catastrophically, in war. Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925) had described the potlatch of the peoples of the Pacific Northwest, in which chiefs asserted their rank by giving away or destroying wealth — breaking engraved copper plates and casting them into the sea — rather than accumulating it. Dracula's castle is accumulated excess turned to catastrophe: immortality, power, and grief hoarded and spent as war on humanity. The son's refusal of the inheritance is its expenditure in the glorious mode. He does not invest his father's power or reproduce it; he lets it go, and the castle's fall at dawn is a potlatch of the father's estate. In his later writings Bataille called the moment that serves nothing beyond itself sovereignty, and distinguished it from domination (*La Souveraineté*, written 1953–1956). Alucard is sovereign in Bataille's sense precisely because he refuses to rule.

The archetype of the prince who leaves his father's palace is Buddhist. In the legend of the Buddha, as Aśvaghoṣa told it in the *Buddhacarita* (first or second century), King Śuddhodana, warned that his son might renounce the world, built him palaces of pleasure from which every sign of suffering was concealed; but on his excursions the prince saw an old man, a sick man, a corpse, and an ascetic, and learned what his father had hidden. He left the palace by night, abandoning his inheritance, to seek release from suffering. The father's palace was a pile of secrets, built to keep a son from the knowledge of misery; the son's discovery of misery became compassion and renunciation. *Symphony of the Night* inverts the legend in one respect and repeats it in another. Dracula's castle hides not the world's suffering from the son but the father's suffering from the world, beneath a war; the son

discovers it and answers it with his mother's word. But the end is the same: having seen what the palace concealed, the prince renounces the palace.

Kant's fourth question can now be answered in the dhampir's terms. What is a man? Not a miserable little pile of secrets, though he has secrets and is miserable; not the beautiful strong being of the aesthete's creed, nor the guilty mass of the persecutors' fear. The human being is the creature that exists between — between the living and the dead, between the animal and the spirit, between the accuser and the accused — and that can read its own origin backward. It is Sophocles' *deinon*, the uncanniest of beings, never at home (§1.2); Schiller's player, fully human only where it plays (§1.2); the Orphic child of Earth and starry Heaven (§7.5); the Chalcedonian two-yet-not-two (§7.2); the Sphinx's answer, a creature of transformations (§7.7). Above all, it is the being that can refuse what it inherits. The vampire repeats; the human being remembers, forgives, and departs. This is the dhampir's anthropology, and it is the game's answer to the question its villain asked at the threshold: man is the one who can turn back the name of his father and choose his mother's mercy. The last chapter of this dissertation gathers the threads of that answer into a definition of dhampiric reason, and follows the game into its afterlives.



VIII

Compagnon de Misères

Chapter Eight

Conclusion — *Compagnon de Misères*

Dhampiric Reason and the Afterlives of the Night

The dissertation began with a question asked by a vampire at a threshold and has followed it through the four questions in which Kant summed up philosophy. This concluding chapter does three things. It recapitulates the argument in the manner its subject requires — backward (§8.1). It gathers the argument's results into a definition of dhampiric reason, the mode of understanding that the game constructs and that the dissertation has claimed as its original contribution, and defends that claim against the objections it invites (§8.2). And it follows the game into its afterlives: the genre it named (§8.3), the works of the following decades that inherited its architecture of secrets, its revenant ludology, and its drama of inherited blood (§§8.4–8.5), and the prospect it opens for an art of mourning in play (§8.6). A coda returns to the hour at which the game ends (§8.7).

8.1

Recapitulation in Inversion

A DISSERTATION on retrogradation should end by reading itself backward, and Irenaeus's term for salvation — *recapitulatio*, the retracing of a path in reverse so that its knots come loose (§1.3) — names the operation. The argument is therefore restated here from its last chapter to its first.

Chapter Seven answered Kant's fourth question in the figure of the dhampir. Alucard's name reverses a patronymic, and its secret is legible in one alphabet and not in another (§7.1); his being parodies and fulfils the Chalcedonian definition, two natures held together without confusion and without separation (§7.2); he is the refused Antichrist, whose double inversion returns not to divinity but to humanity (§7.3). He enters his father's house emptied, like Inanna at the gates of the underworld, and recovers in it what he already was (§§7.4–7.5); his animal forms are his father's, inhabited without dissolution (§7.6); he is the son whom the vampire, by filiating, made possible — a son who can refuse (§7.7). His motion is retrograde, a backward dash that faces what it leaves, like Benjamin's angel (§7.8); his bearing is the dandy's, a setting sun without warmth (§7.9); his rest is the coffin, which makes the player a revenant (§7.10); and his end is the refusal of inheritance, a sovereignty that consists in declining to rule (§7.11).

Chapter Six answered the third question. The vampire speaks for the masters of suspicion, and the game grants him their arguments (§6.1); its sacrament is the Eucharist inverted (§6.2); its villain is a priest (§6.3); its arsenal is a syncretism of efficacy (§6.4); its Death is a servant (§6.5); its father is Kierkegaard's misprint, which refuses correction until the last (§6.6). Its castle is a Gnostic prison through which a redeemed redeemer passes (§6.7); its father's body lies dismembered like Osiris's, and the son gathers it as Isis did (§6.8); its world turns at Dante's centre (§6.9); its return is eternal but interruptible (§6.10); and its hope, in the Japan of 1995, is neither the end of the world nor the dissolution of persons but the turning of punishment into pardon (§6.11).

Chapter Five answered the second. A widower's grief becomes a wrath against humanity (§5.1), provoked by a burning of the kind Europe inflicted

on its learned and its heterodox (§5.2); the grievance is just, and the game refuses its conclusion (§5.3). The hunter becomes the hunted (§5.4); possession is the paradigm of treating a person as a mere means, and play is distinguished from it by consent (§5.5). A ghost forbids revenge, inverting *Hamlet* (§5.6); a succubus counterfeits the mother, and the son discerns her by the mother's word (§5.7); that word is Schopenhauer's ethic of compassion (§5.8), a victim's counter-testimony against *Devilman*'s despair (§5.9), and it is consummated, as in *Iliad* 24 and *Atsumori*, in a reconciliation at a death (§5.10).

Chapter Four answered the first. The castle is a world without an outside (§4.1), organized by secrets that are present but unperceived (§4.2), mapped as a memory palace (§4.3), searched as a confessor searches (§4.4), and closed, falsely, at its midpoint (§4.5). The conjunction of sun and moon opens the way to revelation (§4.6); the Holy Glasses unveil the controller (§4.7); and the castle turns into Hegel's inverted world (§4.8), a mirror fugue (§4.9), and a totality that exceeds its own measure (§4.10).

Chapter Three described the game's sensuous form as a decadent sublime: an androgynous painted prince (§3.1), framed by a Japanese gothic of the imaginary aristocrat (§3.2), scored as an imaginary museum of forms (§3.3), built as a sublime of repeated tiles (§3.4), lit as a house of shadows (§3.5), rendered in a revenant medium (§3.6), and felt under the sign of impermanence (§3.7). Chapter Two reconstructed the genealogies the game inherits, from the voivode's printing press to the Belmont line, and found at every stage the vampire called into being by a human medium and a human desire. Chapter One posed the question, proposed the method, and stated the thesis that the following chapters have tested: that *Symphony of the Night* is a game of mourning whose argument is carried by retrograde and inversion, and whose answer to the question of the human is a pessimist anthropodicy. Read backward, the argument arrives where it began — at a threshold, a disputation, and a question that has now received its answer.

8.2
Dhampiric Reason Defined

THE DISSERTATION has claimed that *Symphony of the Night* constructs a mode of understanding, and that mode can now be defined. Dhampiric reason is the capacity to disclose the concealed half of an apparent totality by reading it against its own grain, without abolishing either of the halves thus brought into relation. Its operations are the four forms of contrapuntal transformation (§1.3), each of which the game embodies. The first is the **retrograde**, the reading of an origin backward: the son's name, the recapitulation of history, the anamnesis by which a self recovers what it was. The second is **inversion**, the turning of a world upside down to reveal what its orientation concealed: the Inverted Castle, Feuerbach's transformative method, Hegel's passage from punishment to pardon. The third is **retrograde inversion**, the two at once — the table duet read from both sides (§1.3) — in which the knower holds the world and its inversion together, as the player of the second castle holds the first in memory. The fourth is the **return to the prime**, the moment at which the transformed subject is restated in its original form, changed by what it has passed through. In the game it is the dawn after the inverted night, in which the son, having read his father backward and turned his father's house over, steps into the ordinary world.

Dhampiric reason must be distinguished from three neighbours. It is not dialectical reason in Hegel's sense, though it has learned from Hegel's inverted world. Hegelian *Aufhebung* cancels, preserves, and raises opposites into a higher unity in which their difference is overcome; dhampiric reason refuses that unity. Its formula is not synthesis but the Shingon "two, yet not two" (§7.2): it holds the halves together without dissolving them, as the dhampir holds his natures. It stands closer to Theodor Adorno's negative dialectics, which insisted on the non-identical remainder that every concept leaves behind (Adorno 1966), and which inverted Hegel's maxim that the true is the whole into the aphorism "Das Ganze ist das Unwahre," the whole is the false (*Minima Moralia*, 1951, §29). The castle's 200.6 per cent is Adorno's aphorism in arithmetic (§4.10). But dhampiric reason does not

end in negation; it ends in mercy. Nor is it simply the hermeneutics of suspicion (§6.1), although it passes through suspicion. It unmasks — the possessed hunter, the priest behind the possession, the grief behind the war — but its unmasking serves recognition rather than exposure, and it arrives, as Ricoeur hoped, at a second hearing of the symbols it has stripped.

Three older figures of thought stand nearest to it. Nicholas of Cusa's *De docta ignorantia* (1440) taught that the infinite is the coincidence of opposites and exceeds every finite measure, so that the highest knowledge is a learned ignorance that knows the limits of its measure; the castle's exceeding of its own percentage is a lesson in *docta ignorantia*. John Keats, in a letter of December 1817, named "Negative Capability" the condition of a mind "capable of being in uncertainties, Mysteries, doubts, without any irritable reaching after fact & reason"; dhampiric reason is negative capability made practical, the ability to remain between two natures without forcing their resolution. And Watsuji Tetsurō, in his *Rinrigaku* (*Ethics*, 1937–1949), observed that the Japanese word for the human being, *ningen* (人間), joins the character for person to the character for "between," and argued that the human being is constituted not as an isolated individual but as betweenness, *aidagara* — a being whose existence is the relation in which it stands. Watsuji's ethics answers Kant's fourth question in a word the dhampir embodies: the human being is the between.

Dhampiric reason thus has an epistemology, an ethics, and a hope, corresponding to Kant's first three questions. Its epistemology is metamorphic and supplementary: it knows by becoming what the world requires, and it knows that every whole it maps is exceeded. Its ethics is compassionate and discriminating: it strikes the possession and spares the possessed, and it grounds its mercy not in the merit of others but in their misery. Its hope is interruptive: it does not expect the end of the cycle, but it trusts that a moment of recognition can change the meaning of a return. And its answer to the fourth question is the dhampir's: the human being as the creature that exists between, that reads its origin backward, and that can refuse what it inherits.

Three objections must be met before the claim can stand. The first is that the dissertation overinterprets — that a game made by a commercial team to a schedule cannot bear the weight of Kant, Hegel, and Zeami.

Figure 14

The Between

人 · 間

hito, a person — *aida*, between

ningen

the human being



the ancient form: the moon seen through the gap of a gate

間柄

aidagara, *betweenness: Watsuji's word for the human condition*

The between (§8.2). Watsuji Tetsurō observed that ningen, *the human being, joins the character for person to the character for between, and described the human being as betweenness,* aidagara. *In its ancient form,* 間, *the character for between showed the moon seen through the gap of a gate.*

Umberto Eco distinguished the intention of the author and that of the reader from the intention of the work, *intentio operis*, and proposed as the test of an interpretation its coherence with the work as a whole: a reading is legitimate if other parts of the text confirm it and none contradicts it (Eco 1990). The readings proposed here have been held to that test. The inversion of the castle, the reversal of the name, the conjunction of the rings, the prohibition of revenge, and the final recognition are features of the work, not of its commentary, and the dissertation's claim is that they cohere — that the game's structure, read whole, says what its parts say severally. The evidential tiers announced at the outset, distinguishing documented filiation from generic inheritance and constellational affinity, have marked throughout where a claim rests on a source and where on an arrangement. The second objection concerns translation. Some readings depend on the English text, such as Malraux's formula; others on the Japanese, such as the katakana name and the moon of the subtitle. But a work that exists in two languages exists in both, and its reception has been shaped by both; Hans Robert Jauss's account of the horizon of expectations within which a work is received (Jauss 1967) allows the anglophone and Japanese receptions to be read as two voices of a single history, which is what a contrapuntal method requires. The third objection is phenomenological: players do not experience the game as philosophy. Most do not, as most spectators of *Hamlet* do not experience it as a treatise on Danish succession. Gadamer's account of the artwork as play (§1.2) holds that a work's meaning is realized in its being played rather than in its players' reflections, and the dissertation's procedural method (§1.7) has located the game's philosophy in what play does — in the coffin, the map, the turned castle, the struck orb — rather than in what players say. A player who has turned the castle over, spared the hunter, and heard the father's last words has performed the argument, whether or not he has named it.

8.3

The Metroidvania and the Ludic Architecture of the Secret

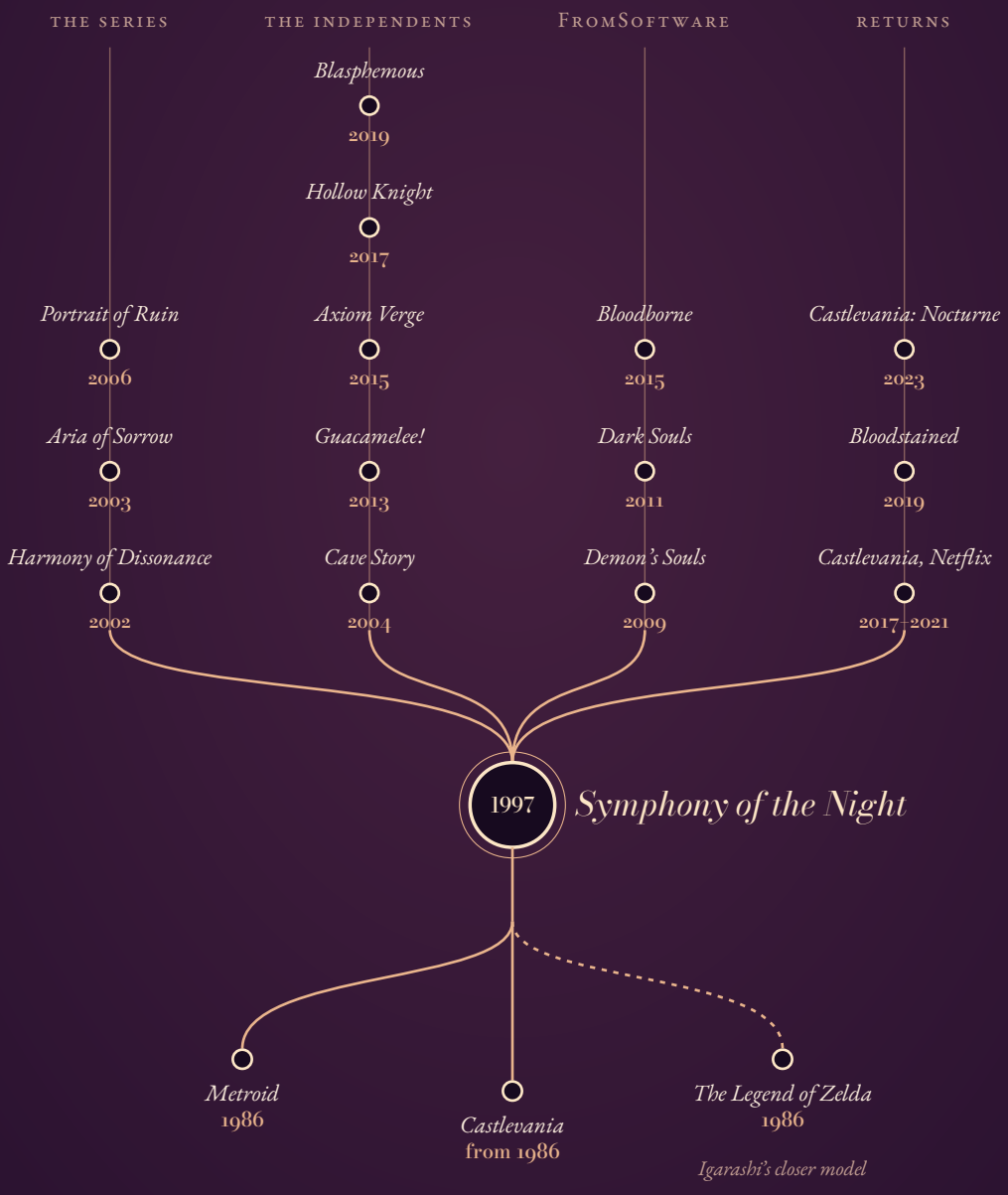
THE GAME'S most visible legacy is a genre, and the genre's name records the double inheritance this dissertation has traced. "Metroidvania," the compound that game journalism popularized in the following decade, joins Nintendo's *Metroid* (1986), whose labyrinthine planet opened progressively to its heroine's acquired abilities, to the *Castlevania* series, in which *Symphony of the Night* had fused that architecture with the experience system of the role-playing game and the Gothic world of its own lineage; Koji Igarashi, for his part, has recalled the *Legend of Zelda* series as the closer model (§1.8). The genre's grammar is the grammar of the castle as epistemic object (Chapter Four): an interconnected world whose regions are gated by abilities, revealed progressively on a map, and saturated with secrets that are visible before they are attainable.

Its central movement is the retrograde. A Metroidvania is defined by return through known space with new capacities — what players call backtracking — so that progress in such a game consists largely in going back. The revisited room is the same room and not the same: Heraclitus held that one cannot step twice into the same river, and the genre builds a world of rooms one cannot enter twice, because the one who enters has changed. Uexküll's *Umwelt* (§4.2) becomes a principle of design: the world grows as the body that perceives it grows. The genre's culture of expert play has produced, moreover, its own form of reading against the grain. Speedrunners seek "sequence breaks," routes that pass through the world in an order its designers did not intend, exploiting the geometry of rooms and the physics of movement to reach late regions early. A sequence break is a contrapuntal reading of a game: the same architecture traversed in an order that discloses possibilities its intended reading concealed.

The genre also inherited the castle's arithmetic of completion. The percentage that *Symphony of the Night* displays on its map became, in the following decade, a culture: the systems of achievements and trophies introduced on the major consoles from 2005 turned every game into a

Figure 15

Heirs by Filiation



Descendants by filiation, not mere contagion (§§8.3–8.5). The genre's name joins Metroid to Castlevania, with Zelda as Igarashi's own model. From 1997 the lines run through the series under Igarashi, the independent revival, FromSoftware's revenant ludology, and the works that returned directly to the matter of the night.

ledger of completion, and players who pursue the full count are known, in their own idiom, as completionists. The game's 200.6 per cent stands at the head of this culture as its ironic emblem. It invites the desire for totality and then exceeds it, teaching the completionist, as the *Iroha* teaches the reader of its complete syllabary (§3.7), that the full count is not the whole. The genre's best works have kept the lesson, hiding beyond their apparent completion a further region, a second ending, or a secret the map does not record.

The series itself developed the game's themes for a decade under Igarashi. *Castlevania: Harmony of Dissonance* (2002) divided its world into two superimposed and subtly divergent castles; *Aria of Sorrow* (2003) made its hero, Soma Cruz, the reincarnation of Dracula himself, a young man who learns that he is destined to become the dark lord and refuses — a refused Antichrist (§7.3) at the centre of the series; *Portrait of Ruin* (2006) opened worlds inside the castle's paintings, extending the galleries of 1997 into portals. Beyond the series, the genre underwent the revenant history that Chapter Three predicted for its medium. After the turn of the century the large studios largely abandoned two-dimensional action games, and the form was revived by independent developers working with small teams and modest means: Daisuke Amaya's *Cave Story* (2004), the work of a single developer; *Guacamelee!* (2013), whose hero passes between the world of the living and the world of the dead as between two versions of the same map; *Axiom Verge* (2015); and the works discussed below. Rosalind Krauss's thesis that a medium becomes available for reinvention when it becomes obsolete (§3.6) found in the Metroidvania one of its clearest confirmations. The outmoded form returned, sustained by new means of production, and carried with it the architecture of the secret that *Symphony of the Night* had perfected.

8.4

Souls, *Bloodborne*, *Hollow Knight*, *Blasphemous*

◆

The deepest afterlife of *Symphony of the Night* lies not in imitations of its surface but in works that inherited its philosophical form. The series

directed by Hidetaka Miyazaki at FromSoftware — *Demon's Souls* (2009) and *Dark Souls* (2011) above all — joined an interconnected world of shortcuts and secrets to a revenant ludology made explicit. The player of *Dark Souls* is one of the Undead, cursed to return after every death to the last bonfire at which he rested; and the game makes humanity itself a quantity, an item the player can collect, spend, and lose, falling into a "hollow" state when it is gone. Kant's fourth question becomes a mechanic: one can be more or less human, and the measure of one's humanity is a resource. The game's endings pose the question of the eternal return (§6.10) as a choice. The player may sacrifice himself to prolong a dying Age of Fire, as countless predecessors have done, or let the fire fade and inaugurate an age of dark. The cycle can be continued or refused.

Bloodborne (2015), from the same director, set the inheritance in a Gothic city ruled by a Healing Church that administers blood as medicine and sacrament — the inverted Eucharist of Chapter Six made an institution — and whose hunters, fighting a plague of beasts, become beasts themselves, as Nietzsche warned (§5.4). Its most original mechanic is an epistemology. A statistic called Insight measures the forbidden knowledge the hunter has acquired, and as it rises he begins to see what was always there and invisible: vast beings clinging to the city's buildings, sounds without a source. Insight is the Holy Glasses as a gradient, and the game adds what *Symphony of the Night* did not, that the sight which unveils also endangers the one who sees. One of its endings releases the hunter from the city's nightmare into a waking world at sunrise.

Team Cherry's *Hollow Knight* (2017), made by a small Australian studio, transposed the Metroidvania into a fallen kingdom of insects and gave it a family drama of inherited emptiness. To seal away a plague, its king made children of the void, vessels meant to be perfectly empty — without mind, will, or voice — and chose one of them to contain the infection; the vessel failed because it was not empty enough, and the player is another of those children, wandering a kingdom built on the bodies of siblings sacrificed to their father's design. The father's demand is a perverted *kenōsis* (§7.4): not a son who empties himself in love but a child emptied by command. The game's endings let the player take the failed vessel's place and renew the seal, or embrace the void that is his inheritance and end the plague at its source.

Its map, bought from a wandering cartographer and inked in only when the player rests, makes cartography an act within the fiction (§4.3).

Blasphemous (2019), developed by The Game Kitchen in Seville, returned the genre to the Europe whose Gothic the Japanese game had reimagined. Its world is a land of penance shaped by the imagery of Andalusian Holy Week — hooded penitents, polychrome sculpture, processional thrones — and governed by an arbitrary divine power called the Miracle, which rewards and punishes without reason; its hero, the Penitent One, wields a sword born of guilt. The game turns the critique of religion (Chapter Six) into a world: a theodicy that has failed, a faith become a machine for producing suffering, and a protagonist who must cross it in silence. The counterpoint that began when a Tokyo studio reimagined the European Gothic closes when a Spanish studio reimagines the Japanese reimagining.

These works share with *Symphony of the Night* four features the preceding chapters isolated: an architecture of the secret, a revenant structure of death and return, an inheritance of blood or curse transmitted from a father, and the possibility, at the end, of refusing the cycle. They are, in this sense, its descendants by filiation and not merely by contagion — heirs who have read their inheritance and, in each case, offered the player the dhampir's choice.

8.5

Bloodstained and the Netflix *Castlevania*

Two works of the following decades returned directly to the matter of *Symphony of the Night*, and the comparison clarifies what the original achieved. In 2015 Koji Igarashi, having left Konami, launched a crowdfunding campaign for a spiritual successor that became one of the most heavily funded game campaigns of its time. *Bloodstained: Ritual of the Night* (2019), developed by ArtPlay with music by Michiru Yamane, sets its action in a demonic castle raised in an England of the Industrial Revolution by a man named Gebel. Gebel and the heroine, Miriam, are both Shardbinders, orphans into whose bodies a guild of alchemists implanted

demonic crystals in a ritual meant to summon hell: human beings made half-demon not by birth but by experiment. Gebel, embittered by what was done to him, raises the castle in revenge on the world that made him; Miriam, bearing the same curse, sets out to stop him. The structure of the 1997 game is reproduced in a new key — two hybrids, one who has chosen vengeance and one who must answer him, and a monstrous architecture raised by a justified grievance (§5.3).

The animated series *Castlevania* (2017–2021), written by Warren Ellis for Netflix, carried the series' mythology to its widest audience and made explicit much that *Symphony of the Night* had left implicit. Its first episode shows Lisa as a woman of science who comes to Dracula's castle seeking knowledge, becomes his wife, and practises medicine among the people of Wallachia, until a bishop has her burned as a witch while Dracula is away; at the stake she pleads for mercy for her killers, in words that recall those of the crucified (Luke 23:34), and Dracula, returning to find her dead, gives Wallachia a year to make its peace before unleashing an army of the night. The series stages the confrontation of father and son as the game did not: in its second season Alucard kills his father in the room where he had been a child, and the father, recognizing whom he is fighting and where, ceases to resist. Its third season dwells on the son's solitude in the empty castle and on the trauma of betrayal, and its fourth turns on an alchemical device called the Rebis Engine, designed to resurrect Dracula and Lisa joined in a single body — the alchemical androgyne of Chapters Three and Four made a plot device — before ending with the two restored to life and choosing a hidden, human existence far from the world. Its successor, *Castlevania: Nocturne* (from 2023), moved the action to France in 1792, making the revolutionary year of the game's prologue (§1.6) its explicit subject.

The comparison measures the discipline of the original. *Bloodstained* reproduces the structure of grievance and response but distributes it between two equal hybrids, so that the answer to vengeance is less a word received than a parallel choice. The Netflix series supplies everything the game withholds — Lisa's life, the father's grief in its full expression, the son's trauma, the parents' restoration — and its consolation is generous. But the ending in which the dead woman returns undoes the work of mourning that *Symphony of the Night* performs. In the game Lisa does not come back. Her word does, carried by her son, and the father is redeemed by

hearing it, not by having her restored. The game's refusal of resurrection is its stringency: it asks its player to accept that the dead are gone and that what remains of them is the word they leave, and it makes that acceptance the condition of the father's peace. Coppola's film had ended with love restoring the vampire's soul (§2.6); the Netflix series ends with love restoring the vampire's wife. *Symphony of the Night* ends with a mother's word restoring nothing but a father's capacity to grieve rightly. It is the most austere of the three, and the most truthful about mourning.

8.6

The *Trauerspiel* and the Future of Mourning in Play

◆

The largest claim the dissertation can make for *Symphony of the Night* concerns its medium. Benjamin's *Trauerspiel* was a play of mourning; the German word allows it to be a game of mourning as well (§1.4), and the game has shown what such a thing could be. Its structure of repetition — the castle's centennial return, the player's deaths and resurrections, the backtracking through known rooms — is the form of the medium itself, and the game discovers in that form a capacity the psychoanalytic tradition had named. Freud distinguished repetition, the acting-out of what cannot be remembered, from working-through, *Durcharbeiten*, the repetition that transforms what it repeats until it can be remembered and released (§7.5). A medium constituted by repetition is a medium in which repetition can become working-through. *Symphony of the Night* stages that possibility in its story, where the father's repetition is ended by the son's remembrance, and realizes it in its play, where the repeated traversal of the castle changes the one who traverses it.

The decades since have produced a body of games devoted explicitly to grief, and they confirm the claim. Ryan and Amy Green's *That Dragon, Cancer* (2016) made a game of their young son's terminal illness; *What Remains of Edith Finch* (2017) gathered a family's deaths into a house of rooms, each the memory of one of the dead; *Gris* (2018) made a landscape of a loss. Moon Studios' *Ori and the Blind Forest* (2015), a Metroidvania in

the direct line of *Symphony of the Night*, makes its antagonist a grieving parent: the great owl Kuro, whose young were destroyed in a catastrophe of light, steals the light of the forest to protect her last egg, and at the end, recognizing what her grief has wrought, carries the light back to its source and is consumed by it, while her surviving child passes into the care of those she had fought. A mourning parent whose grief has become a war against the world, ended by recognition and sacrifice, the child entrusted to others: the structure of 1997 returns in a forest of light.

Two further works stand in the same line. Thunder Lotus's *Spiritfarer* (2020) casts its player as a ferrymaster of the dead — the office of Charon (§7.10) — who houses, feeds, and comforts the spirits of the departed until each is ready to be released through a door at the edge of the world. The care of the dead, *tomurai* (§5.6), becomes the substance of play, and its rhythm of hospitality and farewell is the rhythm of Obon (§6.10). Supergiant Games' *Hades* (2020) gives its hero the name of the dismembered god of the Orphic myth, Zagreus (§6.8), and makes him the son of the lord of the dead, who tries again and again to escape his father's house in search of his absent mother; each death returns him home, and each return deepens a family drama that ends not in escape but in reconciliation — the mother restored to the house, the father softened, the son's repetitions transformed into a reason to stay. *Hades* is the most direct heir of the 1997 game's union of revenant ludology and filial drama, and its ending, in which the repetitions are not abolished but redeemed, is a working-through in Freud's sense.

The future of mourning in play lies, on this argument, where *Symphony of the Night* placed it: not in games that represent grief but in games whose form is a work of mourning — whose repetitions are structured so that the player, by repeating, comes to remember, and by remembering, comes to release. Such games do not console by restoring the dead. They teach, as the dhampir learned, that the dead return as a word to be carried, and that the carrying of it can end a war. Kant's fourth question was a question about a being who must live with loss. The art of play, the dissertation suggests, may be the art in which that being learns how.

8.7
Coda: Morning

◆

Symphony of the Night ends at dawn. The castle that rose out of time falls; the night that began with a disputation in a throne room ends with a son walking into the morning; and the woman whose death began everything is present only as the word that ended it. English allows a pun that the game's Japanese makers did not intend and that its anglophone players have perhaps always heard: mourning and morning are one sound. Like the retrograde name that reveals its secret only in Roman letters (§7.1), the pun belongs to one language and not to another, and, like that name, it says something true of the work. The game is a work of mourning that ends in morning, and the second is the fruit of the first. Japanese offers its own figure. Its word for dawn, *yoake*, means the opening of the night: night is not abolished by morning but opened, as a door is opened, or a box. The castle's night opens, at the end, onto a world that has not changed and onto a son who has.

In the year after the castle's fictional return, Haydn's *Die Schöpfung* was first performed in Vienna (1798). It opens with a representation of chaos, a slow movement of unresolved harmonies in which every expected cadence is deferred; then the chorus sings that God said, Let there be light, and at the words "und es ward Licht" the whole orchestra breaks into a fortissimo chord of C major. The chaos of the first castle, the inverted world of the second, and the light that follows them have the shape of Haydn's overture, and of every work that passes through darkness to a dawn it does not take for granted.

The dissertation began with Machaut's rondeau, *Ma fin est mon commencement* (§1.1), and it ends where it began: at a threshold, with a question. Dracula asked what a man is, and answered that he is a miserable little pile of secrets. The game has spent its night disproving the contempt without disputing the misery. Human beings are wretched; they burn the innocent and fear what they do not understand; their secrets are many and their lot is hard. The vampire drew from this the conclusion that they deserved destruction. A woman they killed drew the opposite, and her son carried

her conclusion through the house of the vampire to his death. What is a man? A fellow-sufferer, *compagnon de misères*, to be spared because his lot is already hard. That is the pessimist anthropodicy of *Symphony of the Night*, and the dawn at its end is the light in which it can be seen.

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Keywords

Castlevania: Symphony of the Night; *Akumajō Dracula X: Gekka no Yasōkyoku*; Konami; Toru Hagihara; Koji Igarashi; Ayami Kojima; Michiru Yamane; Metroidvania; game studies; ludic hermeneutics; procedural rhetoric; ergodic literature; philosophy of play; Schiller's *Spieltrieb*; Gadamer; Gothic studies; the Gothic videogame; vampire studies; monster theory; the dhampir; Alucard; Vlad III; Bram Stoker; John Polidori; Goethe, "Die Braut von Korinth"; Coleridge, "Christabel"; Novalis; the *Balladenjahr* of 1797; the "Oldest System-Programme of German Idealism"; new mythology; Kantian anthropology; *Was ist der Mensch?*; André Malraux; Pascal; theodicy; anthropodicy; pessimism; Schopenhauer; *Mitleid*; compassion ethics; Hegel; *verkehrte Welt*; inversion; retrograde; counterpoint; *canon cancrizans*; mirror fugue; J. S. Bach; Schoenberg; *Ave/Eva*; Irenaeus; recapitulation; *kenōsis*; *anamnēsis*; *apokalypsis*; *peripeteia*; *anagnōrisis*; *apotaxis*; Walter Benjamin; *Trauerspiel*; allegory; mourning and melancholia; Abraham and Torok; crypt and phantom; hermeneutics of suspicion; Ricoeur; secrecy and confession; Foucault; memory palace; revenant ludology; save-point ontology; avatarial possession; Japanese Gothic; *onryō*; dream-Noh; *mono no aware*; *mujō*; *tanbi*; *visual kei*; *shōjo* manga; Japanese Occidentalism; *mukoku-useki*; 1797; 1997; comparative mythology; Order of the Dragon; Habsburg vampire controversy; *Visum et Repertum*; Augustin Calmet; Rousseau on testimony; Hume, "Of Miracles"; incorruptibility and the *tympaniaios*; phantasmagoria; *benandanti*; Carlo Ginzburg; *pharmakon*; the scapegoat; Abe no Seimei; Kuzunoha; Bürger, "Lenore"; "Kubla Khan"; "The Rime of the Ancient Mariner"; Wackenroder; E. T. A. Hoffmann; Jean Paul; Hölderlin; Sade; Byron, *The Giaour*; Le Fanu, "Carmilla"; *Varney the Vampire*; Friedrich Kittler; Murnau, *Nosferatu*; Universal horror; Hammer Films; seriality; Herzog; Coppola; Eiko Ishioka; Anne Rice; *Botan Dōrō*; Tezuka, *Dororo*; Mizuki, *GeGeGe no Kitarō*; Moto Hagio; *Vampire Hunter D*; Yoshitaka Amano; *JoJo's Bizarre Adventure*; *Inuyasha*; *Hellsing*; *Simon's Quest*; *Rondo of Blood*; decadent sublime; *The King's Two Bodies*; androgyny; the *Rebis*; Schlegel, *Lucinde*; Gautier; Péladan and the Rose+Croix; Eliade, *coincidentia oppositorum*; Suzuki Harunobu; *onnagata* and *otokoyaku*; Takarazuka; *bishōnen*; Tanizaki, "Shisei"; the Gothic as pseudepigraphy; Shibusawa Tatsuhiko; X Japan; Malice Mizer; Elegant Gothic Lolita; the *kazoku*; Bourdieu, distinction; partita; toccata; requiem; *tombeau*; Mozart's Requiem; Berlioz, *Symphonie fantastique*; *Fantasia*; Burke on the sublime; the artificial infinite; Kant's mathematical and dynamical sublime; Piranesi, *Carceri*; De Quincey; John Soane; Tanizaki, *In Praise of Shadows*; Chūson-ji Konjikidō; Bashō; Odilon Redon; Huys-

mans, *À rebours*; the outmoded; Rosalind Krauss; McLuhan's tetrad; hauntology; sprite; *emaki* and *fukinuki yatai*; Superflat; *nijigen*; *Heike Monogatari*; the *Iroha*; Motoori Norinaga; ruin aesthetics; Hubert Robert; *The Castle of Otranto*; "The Fall of the House of Usher"; Azuchi Castle; Kinkaku-ji; Kant's Copernican revolution; Borges, "La casa de Asterión"; Peake, Gormenghast; Kafka, *Das Schloß*; Kafka, "Vor dem Gesetz"; Calvino, *Il castello dei destini incrociati*; Simmel on the secret; Meno's paradox; Kermode, *The Genesis of Secrecy*; Uexküll, *Umwelt*; Nagel's bat; the sunlike eye; the art of memory; Simonides; *Rhetorica ad Herennium*; Camillo's Memory Theatre; Giordano Bruno; Matteo Ricci; Frances Yates; cognitive mapping; Augustine, *Confessions*; Rousseau, *Confessions*; Foucault's confessing animal; Karatani Kōjin; the false ending; Kermode, *The Sense of an Ending*; Peter Brooks; *The Winter's Tale*; Goethe, *Faust*; curiosity; Blumenberg; the *coniunctio*; *Rosarium philosophorum*; *Chymische Hochzeit*; Izanagi and Izanami; Amaterasu and Tsukuyomi; Plato's cave; Wagner, *Der Ring des Nibelungen*; 1 Corinthians 13:12; Kleist's green glasses; the Woman of the Apocalypse; Kepler; Descartes, *Dioptrique*; camera obscura; *le monde à l'envers*; Bakhtin's carnival; *sakasa-goto*; Stratton's inverting lenses; twelve-tone method; Escher; Hofstadter's strange loop; Gödel's incompleteness; Derrida's supplement; Benjamin's *Eingedenken*; 200.6 per cent; *mēnis*; Leonard Muellner; Homeric *Hymn to Demeter*; Sugawara no Michizane; Emperor Sutoku; Ueda Akinari, *Ugetsu Monogatari*; "Aozukin"; Hypatia; Joan of Arc; Michael Servetus; *Malleus Maleficarum*; Michelet, *La Sorcière*; Friedrich Spee, *Cautio Criminalis*; Girard, *Le Bouc émissaire*; Guillaume de Machaut; the Great Martyrdom of Nagasaki; Mary Shelley, *Frankenstein*; William Blake; Miyazaki, *Mononoke-hime*; Nietzsche on monsters and the abyss; the struggle for recognition; Kojève; Shuten-dōji; *cum dilectione hominum et odio vitiorum*; Kleist, "Über das Marionettentheater"; the formula of humanity; Bernard Suits and the lusory attitude; Kempelen's chess automaton; Benjamin, "Über den Begriff der Geschichte"; bunraku; *Hamlet*; *Kanadehon Chūshingura*; *katakiuchi*; the succubus; Wagner, *Parsifal*; discernment of spirits; "Yuki-Onna"; Schopenhauer, *Über die Grundlage der Moral*; *tat tvam asi*; Rousseau's *pitié*; Nietzsche's critique of pity; Kannon; Maria Kannon; *kakure kirishitan*; Endō Shūsaku; Go Nagai, *Devilman*; forgiveness; Hannah Arendt; Jankélévitch; Derrida on forgiveness; Ricoeur on testimony; *Iliad* 24; Simone Weil; Zeami, *Atsumori*; reconciliation; ethics of mourning; critique of religion; Voltaire, *Écrasez l'infâme*; the Calas affair; Feuerbach, *Das Wesen des Christentums*; Marx on religion; the death of God; the ascetic priest; inverted Eucharist; transubstantiation; the pelican; the Black Mass; Lewis, *The Monk*; Radcliffe, *The Italian*; Hugo, *Notre-Dame de Paris*; "Ceci tuera cela"; the dark priest; syncretism; *vibhūti*; Agni; Muramasa; the Vorpal Blade; *shinbutsu shūgō*; *genze riyaku*; *danse macabre*; Holbein, *Dance of Death*; Grimm, "Der Gevatter Tod"; San'yūtei Enchō, "Shinigami"; *non serviam*; Milton's Satan; Byron, *Manfred*; Kierkegaard, *The Sickness unto Death*; demonic despair; Gnosticism; the demiurge; Hans Jonas; the redeemed redeemer; the Hymn of the Pearl; *Taketori Monogatari*; Osiris; Dionysus Zagreus; Orphic anthropogony; relic cult; Peter Brown; *furta sacra*; Taira no Masakado; Dante, *Inferno* 34; Purgatory; the Harrowing of Hell; *Anastasis*; Mokuren and Obon; eternal return; *Enuma Elish*; Gunkel, *Chaoskampf*; Nietzsche's eternal recurrence;

Blanqui, *L'Éternité par les astres*; Kant's postulate of immortality; messianic interruption; Ise *shikinen sengū*; Aum Shinrikyō; Murakami Haruki, *Underground*; *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind*; *Neon Genesis Evangelion*; Schopenhauer's porcupines; the Japanese apocalyptic imaginary; Frege, sense and reference; Kripke, rigid designation; *atbash*; Butler, *Erewhon*; Council of Chalcedon; Nestorianism and Eutychianism; dyothelitism; Maximus the Confessor; *communicatio idiomatum*; *ryōbu funi*; the Antichrist; Adso of Montier-en-Der; *Good Omens*; *Hellboy*; *Rosemary's Baby*; kenotic Christology; *Descent of Inanna*; Izanagi's purification; Plato, *Phaedo*; the Myth of Er; Orphic gold tablets; Freud, "Erinnern, Wiederholen und Durcharbeiten"; repetition compulsion; Ovid, *Metamorphoses*; Lycaon; Burton on lycanthropy; becoming-animal; Kafka, *Die Verwandlung*; Kafka, "Brief an den Vater"; *henge*; Deleuze and Guattari; *L'Anti-Œdipe*; *Totem und Tabu*; Lacan's Name-of-the-Father; the Sphinx's riddle; the doppelgänger; Jean Paul, *Siebenkäs*; Poe, "William Wilson"; Otto Rank; *ikiryō*; Lady Rokujō; Marey's chronophotography; Duchamp; Bergson's duration; Klee, *Angelus Novus*; the backdash; dandyism; Brummell; Baudelaire, "Le Peintre de la vie moderne"; Camus, *L'Homme révolté*; *hōgan-biiki*; Minamoto no Yoshitsune; Ivan Morris, *The Nobility of Failure*; "Kumogakure"; the coffin as save point; *yomigaeri*; Charon's obol; *fort-da*; Juul, *The Art of Failure*; Bataille, *La Part maudite*; Mauss, potlatch; sovereignty; the Great Departure; Aśvaghoṣa, *Buddhacarita*; dhampiric anthropology; dhampiric reason; negative dialectics; Theodor W. Adorno; Nicholas of Cusa; negative capability; Watsuji Tetsurō; Metroidvania design; backtracking; sequence breaking; completionism; FromSoftware; Team Cherry; The Game Kitchen; ArtPlay; Powerhouse Animation; working-through; games of mourning; Supergiant Games; Thunder Lotus Games; Moon Studios; Haydn's Creation; mourning and morning.

8

und es ward Licht

Haydn, Die Schöpfung, *1798*

夜明け

yoake: *the opening of the night*



Ma fin est mon commencement